this repression was successful and what it meant. A capsule version of one such narrative appears in the opening paragraph of an essay by Rosalind Krauss entitled "Grids":

> In the early part of this century there began to appear, first in France and then in Russia and in Holland, a structure that has remained emblematic of the modernist ambition within the visual arts ever since. Surfacing in pre-War cubist painting and subsequently becoming ever more stringent and manifest, the grid announces, among other things, modern art's will to silence, its hostility to literature, to narrative, to discourse. As such, the grid has done its job with striking efficiency. The barrier it has lowered between the arts of vision and those of language has been almost totally successful in walling the visual arts into a realm of exclusive visuality and defending them against the intrusion of speech.[4]

The basic point of this passage seems clear enough, but there is something curiously at odds with this point in the rhetorical figures that Krauss employs. It seems a bit strange, for instance, to describe this image of hostility to language as an "emblematic" structure, since emblems, along with hieroglyphs, pictograms, and symbols, are the kinds of pictures that are traditionally regarded as being most contaminated by language; an emblem, in fact, is technically a composite visual-verbal form, an allegorical image accompanied by a textual gloss. And it seems almost wilfully paradoxical to personify this antilinguistic grid with its "will to silence" as someone who "announces" things. If this grid has been so successful at placing a barrier between the arts of vision and language, one wonders how it could have the eloquence Krauss ascribes to it.

Whatever criticism we might make of Krauss's rhetoric, we certainly could not charge her with presenting an eccentric or unprecedented account of the history of abstract art. One might even call this an entirely orthodox version of the story, one that has been retold in many ways over the last ninety years, usually under the rubric of abstractions like "opticality" and "purity."[5] The abstract artist, as

4. Rosalind Krauss, "Grids," in *The Originality of the Avant Garde and Other Modernist Myths* (Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 1985), p. 9; further page references will be cited in the text.

5. Krauss herself has been, it should be noted, a resolute critic of the orthodoxy of "optical purity" in more recent writings. See her essay, "Anti-Vision," *October,* no. 36 (Spring 1986), and *The Optical Unconscious* (Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 1993).

Clement Greenberg put it, is a "purist" who "insists upon excluding 'literature' and subject matter from plastic art."[6] Although the elimination of subject matter—the represented objects of traditional painting—is the more famous and obvious gesture of abstract art, the truly fundamental problem, in Greenberg's view, was the inevitable literary associations these objects carried: "It was not realistic imitation in itself that did the damage so much as realistic illusion in the service of . . . literature."[7]

The project of abstract painting (as understood by some of its principal advocates) is only secondarily an overcoming of representation or illusion; the primary aim is the erection of a wall between the arts of vision and those of language. Sometimes this project expresses itself more generally as an attack on the "confusion of the arts," the blurring of the boundaries between painting and other media. In Michael Fried's highly influential accounts of abstract painting, this confusion is called "theatricality," a term which evokes the necessary mixture of visual/verbal codes in theatrical presentation and designates a notion of art as a performative or persuasive act directed toward and conscious of a beholder.[8] Fried opens his classic essay, "Art and Objecthood" (1967), by suggesting that anti- or postmodernist art (what Fried calls "Literalist" art) achieves this theatrical orientation by recourse to language: "It seeks to declare and occupy a position—one which can be formulated in words, and in fact has been formulated by some of its leading practitioners . . . this distinguishes it from modernist painting and sculpture" (p. 438). We should note here the subtle equivocation in Fried's claim. The formulation of the Literalist position "in words" and that this position has been formulated "by some of its leading practitioners" (not by critics) are

6. *Clement Greenberg: The Collected Essays and Criticism*, 2 vols., edited by John O'Brian (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1986), I:23. All subsequent quotations will be from this edition, cited in the text by volume and page number.

7. Greenberg qualifies this by specifying "sentimental and declamatory" literature as the offender but then qualifies his qualification by saying that *all* of "Western and Graeco-Roman art" shows that these offensive literary values go "hand in hand" with "realistic illusion" (Greenberg, "Towards a Newer Laocoon" [1940], I:27).

8. See especially Michael Fried's "Art and Objecthood," *ArtForum* (June 1967), reprinted in *Aesthetics: A Critical Anthology*, edited by George Dickie and Richard Sclafani (New York: St. Martin's, 1977), pp. 438–60; further page references will be cited in the text.

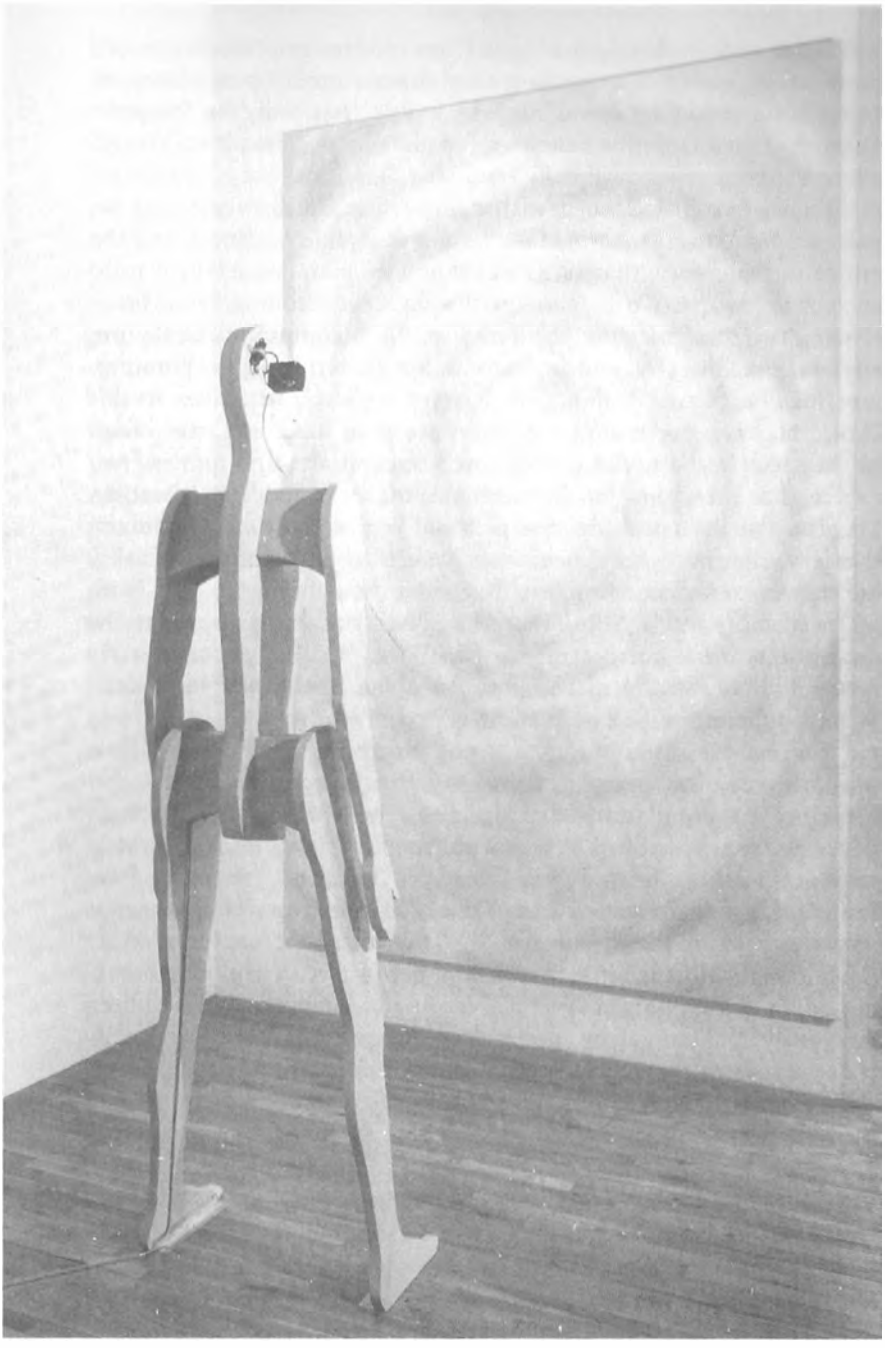
equally crucial in distinguishing it from modernism. Modernist art, presumably, occupies a position that either *cannot* or *need not*, in some basic sense, be formulated in words, especially by its practitioners. Obviously this cannot mean that modernist art is beyond all verbal commentary (Fried's own writing is testimony enough on this point), but it does suggest that modernism in the visual arts involves a certain resistance to language, a discipline of the eye and the critical/artistic voice that seeks to acknowledge the pure, silent presence of the work. Words allow us to place the painting "*in a situation*" which "*includes the beholder*" (p. 445), compromising the purity of the medium by reducing it to rhetoric and turning the paintings into merely "literal"[9] objects in a stage setting. The stakes in this choice between purity and confusion are, at a minimum, the values of the modernist tradition as opposed to rival arts and movements: "there is a war going on between theater and modernist painting, between the theatrical and the pictorial" (p. 451). At a maximum, the very values of art as such are at stake: "theater and theatricality are at war today, not simply with modernist painting . . . but with art as such" (p. 455); "the concepts of quality and value—and to the extent that these are central to art, the concept of art itself—are meaningful or wholly meaningful, only within the individual arts. What lies between the arts is theater" (p. 457).

Given these assumptions, it is not surprising that Fried has little use for many of the movements associated with postmodernism. Performance art, installations, hyper-realism, the New Imagism, intermedia experiments, and other recent movements are often deliberately theatrical, deliberately situated "between the arts," and they have been aptly summarized by Craig Owens as "an eruption of language into the field of the visual arts."[10] This metaphor captures rather melodramatically the sense that postmodernism is an explosive breaking down of that barrier between vision and language that had been rigorously maintained by modernism. Among the most theatrically transgressive of these visual-verbal compositions are Jonathan Borofsky's installations of silhouettes of human figures standing in front of his abstract paintings (figure 31).[11] These monumental automatons

9. The "literal" plays a role in Fried's criticism analogous to the "literary" in Greenberg.

10. Craig Owens, "Earthwords," *October*, no. 10 (Fall 1979): 126–27.

11. See *Jonathan Borofsky*, catalog of the show at the Philadelphia Museum of Art, compiled by Mark Rosenthal and Richard Marshall (1984), pl. 62: *Green Space Painting with Chattering Man*.



31. Jonathan Borofsky, photograph (by Geoffrey Clements) of installation entitled *Green Space Painting with Chattering Man at 2,841,789*. 1983. Collection of the artist. Photograph courtesy of the Paula Cooper Gallery, New York.

have small loudspeakers planted in their mouths and motorized pulleys moving their metal jaws. As the jaw swings up and down, we hear the recorded voice monotonously droning the words "chatter, chatter; chatter, chatter," as if the figure were one of those gallery-goers who feels compelled to talk endlessly about every painting in the exhibition. It's hard to imagine a funnier travesty of what Krauss calls "modern art's will to silence," its "defence against the intrusion of speech." All the taboos against "confusion of the arts" in the name of the aesthetic purity of the medium are violated by this grafting of sculpture, painting, and voice in a theatrical, almost fun-house setting.

What makes this particular installation especially provocative, however, is not just its violation of modernist taboos, but its suggestion that those taboos were never successfully enforced, that the silent temple of pure abstraction was always a place where a lot of prefabricated people with talking heads gathered to repeat a litany of prerecorded utterances. Borofsky gives us a kind of three-dimensional animated cartoon of the space of artistic exhibition as a place where people come to talk about and even "to" the paintings. This image is strikingly at odds with Rosalind Krauss's account of the "grid" of abstraction as an almost "totally successful" suppression of language. Borofsky may be suggesting that, in point of fact, the reverse was true, that the fewer verbal promptings provided by the painter in the form of titles, narrative clues, or subject matter, the more demand for the spectator to fill the void with language. Not that this suggestion is original with Borofsky (or with me).[12] Early in the seventies the journalist Tom Wolfe, in a hilariously vulgar and philistine put-down of modern art, made his own "break-through" in comprehending the pure visuality of abstraction:

> All these years I, like so many others, had stood in front of a thousand, two thousand, God-knows how many thousand Pollocks, de Koonings, Newmans, Nolands, Rothkos, Rauschenbergs, Judds, Johnses, Olitskis, Louises . . . now squinting, now popping the eye sockets open, now drawing back, now moving closer . . . waiting for something to radiate directly from the paintings on these invariably pure white walls . . . into my own optic chiasma. All these years . . . I had assumed that in art, if nowhere else, seeing is believing. Now at last . . . I could see. I

12. Harold Rosenberg notes also that "the place of literature has been taken by the rhetoric of abstract concepts," but he regards this as a mainly negative development. See *The De-definition of Art* (New York: Macmillan, 1972), p. 56.

> had gotten it backward all along. Not "seeing is believing," you ninny, but "believing is seeing," for *Modern Art has become completely literary: the paintings and other works exist only to illustrate the text.*[13]

Wolfe was aware, of course, of what "every art-history student is told," that "the Modern movement began about 1900 with a complete rejection of the *literary* nature of academic art" (p. 7), but he came to a realization which seems to have eluded, not just the apologists for modernism, but postmodern theorists as well: the wall erected against language and literature by the grid of abstraction only kept out a certain kind of verbal contamination, but it absolutely depended, at the same time, on the collaboration of painting with another kind of discourse, what we may call, for lack of a better term, the discourse of theory. If we summarize the traditional collaboration of painting and literature under the classic Horatian maxim, *ut pictura poesis*, as in painting, so in poetry, then the maxim for abstract art is not hard to predict: *ut pictura theoria*. Or, as Wolfe expresses it: "these days, without a theory to go with it, I can't see a painting" (p. 4).

Even with a theory, of course, Wolfe can't see abstract painting, and he only bothered to learn enough about it to make a few cheap shots about the contradiction between abstract art's professed elimination of language and its actual involvement with language. Like his "scandalous" discovery that abstract artists actually cared about acquiring money and fame from their painting, Wolfe's revelation of this paradox in the ideology of modernism goes about as deep as the average political cartoon. Which doesn't prevent us from learning something from this cartoon that seems to have eluded most commentators on abstract art: namely, that the entire antiverbal ideology of abstraction, its depiction as a rigorous "barrier" between vision and language, is a myth that needs to be understood and not just debunked. If abstract art actually was and is an art of "the painted word," as Wolfe claims, what is that word, how is it made manifest in the paintings, and why did its presence have to be denied?

I've already suggested a short answer to the first question: "theory" is the "word" that stands in the same relation to abstract art that traditional literary forms had to representational painting. By "theory" I mean that curious hybrid of mainly prose discourse compounded from aesthetics and other branches of philosophy, as well

13. Tom Wolfe, *The Painted Word* (New York: Bantam Books, 1976), p. 6; further page references will be cited in the text.

as from literary criticism, linguistics, the natural and social sciences, psychology, history, political thought, and religion. Sometimes this sort of writing is called "intellectual prose" or simply "criticism," and it is characterized, generally, by a refusal of disciplinary identity—it is rarely *just* history or science or moral philosophy, but a synthetic discourse that ranges over several specialized idioms.

A good way to see how this sort of prose comes to be focused on the problems of abstract painting is to ask oneself what sorts of things Clement Greenberg, the most important American apologist for abstraction, had to know in order to write the sort of criticism he wrote. The answer is: a fair amount of art history, the fundamentals of Kantian aesthetics, a sense of Marxist historical and critical categories, mediated mainly through Trotsky, experience as a painter and friend of painters, four languages, some practical experience in business and government bureaucracy, an acquaintance with European politics, and membership in the group of intellectuals writing for *Partisan Review* around World War II. Other writers on abstract art bring other areas of expertise: Rudolf Arnheim brings a great deal of Kant and a wealth of experimental evidence from studies of visual perception in gestalt psychology; Michael Fried brings a phenomenological perspective leavened by the tradition of Anglo-American philosophy mediated through Stanley Cavell; Rosalind Krauss unites a firsthand acquaintance with the art world with a combination of structuralism, deconstruction, and a Foucauldian approach to history. The other thing all these writers share is that they write well, or persuasively, or in a style which enables discussion of abstract paintings, often by providing a set of formulas, a language game that can be carried on. Their effect is to make the apparent "wall" or "grid" between abstract art and language seem more like a screen door through which the winds of theoretical discourse blow freely. These "winds" may include a fair amount of hot air, as Jonathan Borofsky suggests. There is no necessary connection between good theory and good painting (Leo Steinberg complains, for instance, that Jasper Johns is a very good painter but a very bad theorist).[14] There is, however, a necessary connection between the meaning of abstract painting and the theoretical discourse around it.

A predictable objection to my claim here is that this discourse arises only *after* the fact of artistic creation; it may provide an expla-

14. Leo Steinberg, *Other Criteria* (London: Oxford University Press, 1972), p. 52: "I think he [Johns] fails, not as a painter, but as a theorist." Michael Fried would perhaps express just the opposite judgment.

nation of a painting or a movement, but it is not constitutive of and prior to painting the way traditional literary and historical narratives were. *Ut pictura poesis* meant an art of mutual imitation and collaboration between two "sister arts," both dwelling in the realm of the aesthetic; *ut pictura theoria* is an unequal relationship of mere convenience, between the master-work of abstract painting and the humble servant of critical prose. There are two sorts of answers to this objection. The first is simply the empirical fact that, for many modern artists, theory has been a constitutive *pre*-text for their work.[15] Cézanne believed that "all things, particularly in art, are theory developed and applied in contact with nature."[16] An even more comprehensive and ambitious claim for a tradition of *ut pictura theoria* has recently been articulated by Robert Morris, a sculptor and painter whose career spans the major American art movements from late modernism to the present.[17] Morris argues that the evolution of modern art may be mapped as a progression of textualizing theories: early abstraction (Kandinsky, Malevich, Mondrian) builds principally on the theoretical manifestos written by the artists' themselves, and based on their readings of nineteenth-century idealist philosophy; American abstract expressionism tends to rely more on critics like Clement Greenberg, a division of labor between the silent artist and his critical spokesman;[18] with minimalism and postmodernism, Morris argues, the textual accompaniments to visual art are once again being produced by the artists' themselves, and the theoretical resources of these texts are to be found in structuralism and deconstruction.

But this answer is still open to the objection that this language is somehow all "outside" the paintings themselves, no matter who produces it or when. It still does not seem *visible* or "coded" in the works

15. Indeed, the notion of "painting theory" precedes modernist abstraction, as the examples of Turner, Blake, and Hogarth show. See my essay, "Metamorphoses of the Vortex," in *Articulate Images*, edited by Richard Wendorf (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 1983), pp. 125–68.

16. Paul Cézanne, "Letter to Charles Camoin," 22 February 1903, reprinted in *Theories of Modern Art*, edited by Herschel B. Chipp (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1968), p. 18.

17. Robert Morris, "Words and Images in Recent Art," *Critical Inquiry* 15:2 (Winter 1989): 337–47.

18. See Ann Gibson, "Abstract Expressionism's Evasion of Language," *Art Journal* 47:3 (Fall 1988): 208–14, for ample documentation of the resistance to verbalization by American painters and sculptors in the forties and fifties.

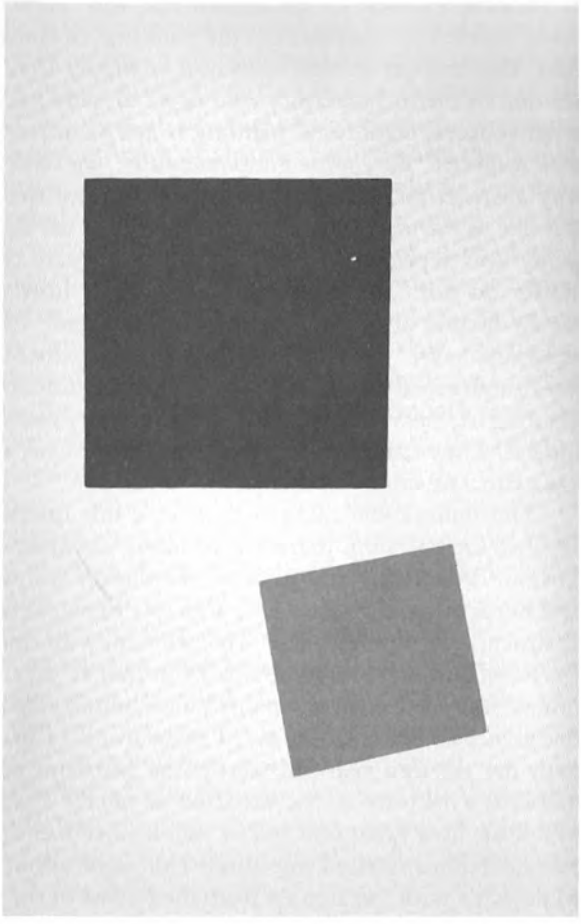
of Jackson Pollock or Mondrian the way biblical narratives were made visible and immanent in the paintings of Raphael and Michelangelo. One answer to this objection is simply that biblical narratives are *not* visible to spectators who don't already know the stories from other sources; traditional painting is not so different from modern in that respect.[19] But, more fundamentally, we have to understand the way abstract art sees itself as having changed the rules of the game. It is one of the principal doctrines of abstract art that although iconography and represented objects may disappear, content and subject matter do not. These paintings, no matter how abstract, are never merely formal or decorative; the "greatest fear" of the abstract artist, as Krauss says, "is that he may be making *mere* abstraction, abstraction uninformed by subject, contentless abstraction" (p. 237).[20] The question is, how can a painting without represented objects have a subject? How can pure forms of paint on canvas say *anything,* much less articulate complex theoretical concepts?

The remarkable thing is that once this question is raised about an abstract painting, there are so many answers. Take, for instance, Kasimir Malevich's composition commonly known as "Red Square and Black Square" (figure 32), arguably the most famous and familiar abstract painting ever made. The problem with this picture is not that we have nothing to say about it, or that it says nothing to us, but rather that we feel overwhelmed and embarrassed by the number of things it can be made to say. I once stood in front of this painting with my thirteen-year-old son at the Museum of Modern Art. His innocent eyes took in the situation at once. "I suppose you're going to tell me how great and full of significance *this* one is, too," he said. Several replies crossed my mind. I thought about explaining to him Malevich's wish "to free art from the ballast of the objective world."[21] I thought of Rosalind Krauss's claim that Malevich is painting the "operations of the Hegelian dialectic." I sorted through my stock of

19. One of the principal objectives of early modernist formalism was the attempt to suspend or erase awareness of literary, narrative elements in traditional painting to allow concentration on things like "significant form."

20. Cp. Clement Greenberg's contention that "every work of art" (including pure abstraction) "must have content." Greenberg distinguishes, however, "content" from "subject matter," the latter referring to "something the artist does or does not have in mind when he is actually at work" ("Towards a Newer Laocoon," *Collected Essays,* I:28).

21. Quoted in Alfred Barr, *Cubism and Abstract Art* (1936; Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1986), p. 122.



32. Kasimir Malevich, *Painterly Realism. Boy with Knapsack—Color Masses in the Fourth Dimension* (1915). Formerly titled *Suprematist Composition: Red Square and Black Square.* Oil on canvas, 28 × 17½". The Museum of Modern Art, New York.

iconographic conventions for the meaning of the colors red and black, the numerological significance of the square as an emblem of earthly foundations, the square as an "expression" (in Malevich's terms) "of binary thought."[22] I recalled a few basic principles from Arnheim on the psychology of visual perception that might explain the effects of the whole composition, effects of size, placement, relation to frame, etc. Ultimately, of course, I resorted to the usual evasion fathers inflict on their sons on these occasions and appealed to authority. I said, "Well, believe it or not, I know someone who has written seventy-five

22. Quoted in Krauss, "Reading Jackson Pollock Abstractly," in *Originality of the Avant-Garde,* p. 238.

pages just trying to explain this one painting."[23] My son looked at me in disbelief: "Well I could say everything there is to say about it in one sentence." "Oh?" I said. "And what is that one sentence?" He scarcely hesitated: "There is a small tilted red square below a larger black square."

It didn't take too much prodding on my part to get my son to admit that he hadn't quite said *everything* there is to say about the painting in this one sentence (he said nothing about the white background, for instance, or the fact that "below" is not quite exact enough). But this answer stuck with me for several reasons. First, it does seem to me that there is a real truth in thinking of this as a "one-sentence" painting, in the way a geometrical figure may illustrate a single algebraic proposition, or a haiku may attempt to capture a scenic image. Second, I was glad to see that my son seemed intuitively to grasp a crucial feature of the language game of abstract art: he didn't say it was a "picture of a red and black square," or a representation of these figures. He saw it as a direct *pre*sentation of the figures: "there *is* a small tilted red square below a larger black square." Third, I felt gratified that he shared my sense that the "hero" of this painting, the protagonist of its one-sentence narrative, is the tilted red square. I'm not sure I'd want to claim that this is an objective "fact" about the painting's meaning, a message that is unequivocally coded in its composition; there must be viewers who identify with the black square. But I can at least testify that it is a social fact about the perception of the painting, verified in numerous other conversations. Even more interesting, I would suggest, are the little scenes like this one that are played out repeatedly in front of abstract paintings, in which a believer or connoisseur (or somebody who has taken Art 101) tries to explain one of these objects to a nonbeliever.

This sort of social fact is, I would suggest, a primary piece of data that tends to be repressed by abstract art's ideology of silent meditation, its tendency to project a solitary, sensitive spectator vibrating to the ineffable tunes of the Hegelian dialectic or the Kantian categories. Perhaps the most important thing this little conversation with my son reminded me of was the fact that Hegel's dialectic is at bottom a social relationship, an image of the mutual dependence of master and

23. I was thinking of Charles Altieri's painstaking efforts to rescue the notion of "representation" (or, more precisely, "representativeness") in abstract painting. See Altieri, "Representation, Representativeness, and Non-Representational Art," *Journal of Comparative Literature and Aesthetics* 5 (1982): 1–23.

slave. Malevich's image is surely dialectical and abstract, but language, narrative, and discourse can never—should never—be excluded from it. The relation of beholder and image is not exhausted by an epistemological model of subject and object, but includes an ethical-political relation, an intersubjective, dialogical encounter with an object that is itself dialectically constructed. The relation of black square to red square is not just the relation between abstract opposites like stability and tilt, large and small, but of more potent, ideologically charged associations like deadly black and vivid, revolutionary red, domination and resistance, or of even more personal and emotional relationships like father and son. I take it that there's no need for me to specify which square is the father, which the son.[24]

These sorts of "square," sentimental, bourgeois associations are exactly what abstract art tried to deny as "kitsch" in the name of high artistic "purity." But this denial was never entirely successful; it was continually contradicted, in social fact, by the elaboration of a quasi-philosophical discourse called "art theory," which filled the exhibition space with subtle, learned chatter. This discourse was difficult and esoteric, of course, so that it could easily become the property of a priesthood uniquely qualified to speak it. The true face of the "will to silence" in abstract art is not the "grid" of its compositional forms, but the imposition of a social mandate: you, who are not qualified to speak about this painting, keep your mouths shut. The uninstructed public, like my thirteen-year-old son, suspecting that there is nothing interesting to be said about these objects in any case, has been content to leave it to the acolytes of abstraction or to give these objects what the ideology of abstraction demanded—silent, mystified reverence, repressed suspicion. The difficult question remains: why was it so crucial to pretend that language was being kept out of the picture? Why did the "purity" of the visual arts need to be so rigorously protected from the contamination of language? Why could "ut pictura theoria" not speak its own name?

One problem with this question is that it has too many answers: the repression of language in abstract painting was, to borrow a term from psychoanalysis, "overdetermined" or excessively motivated. The shortest answer is, of course, a denial of the whole premise of the question in the orthodox claim that abstract art does not repress language; it simply creates "purely visual" images that have no linguistic or literary features to be repressed. Abstraction, on this ac-

24. The new title of Malevich's composition, *Boy with Knapsack*, makes his work look even less abstract.

count, is merely allowing the natural teleology of the visual and pictorial field to realize itself. This answer usually comes up in "scientific" accounts of abstraction as experiments in the physiology of vision and may be seen in Clement Greenberg's quite orthodox account of Courbet as "the first real avant-garde painter," who "tried to reduce his art to immediate sense data by painting only what the eye could see as a machine unaided by the mind" (1:29). A similar orthodoxy informs Greenberg's discussion of the impressionists' "discovery" that "the data of sight, taken most literally, are nothing but colors" (1:201). This mechanistic, materialist explanation could then be adduced in support of more refined, spiritual accounts, notions of "intuition," and the quasi-religious aesthetic of "revelation at first glance" (1:xxiv). In contrast to traditional art with its anecdotes and allegories, there is no temporal sequence to be "read" or deciphered in abstract painting: its forms are grasped in an instantaneous, intuitive perception—a single moment crystalized in space. Paintings are to be seen, not heard, or heard only as a silent, frozen music. The notion of Kantian "intuition" or Hegelian "Being/Nothingness" might be adduced as a philosophical clincher for this strange synthesis of science, religion, and psychology, but the link with linguistic structures remains almost invisible.

These external rationalizations for the purging of literary/linguistic values in painting found strong support in many painters' sense of the history of their own craft. Despite the official ideology of the "sister arts" and *ut pictura poesis*, the actual relations of verbal and visual art since the Renaissance might be more aptly described as a battle or contest, what Leonardo da Vinci called a *paragone*. From the standpoint of professional competition, the incorporation of literary elements in painting could be viewed as a mere expedient in the long struggle of painters to attain the respectability enjoyed by poets. This objective attained, painting was ready to "come into its own," to shed its reliance on literature, and turn its attention to the unique problems of its own medium. The notions of self-reflexive art and art for art's sake collaborated with a heightened sense of professional self-regard that was fueled by the philosophical and scientific theories of "pure vision" and "intuition." When all these elements united with a sense of moral fervor and revolutionary enthusiasm, the combination was irresistible. The "purity" of abstract art could be understood simultaneously as a scientific, religious, and ethical-political reformation. The "innocent eye" of the ideal spectator was at once the unbiased eye of science and the spiritually purified eye of the individuals in a new social order to be produced by religious reformation and/or material

revolution. The totems of this new religious/social order were to be the paintings themselves, now finally emergent as the dominant art form of advanced culture. As a not-so-incidental professional side effect, the traditional dominance of literature over the visual arts would be reversed; painting would not only "come into its own," it would become the model for literature.

Now I hope it is clear, not only how powerful and convincing this array of motivations for the repression of literature could be, but how unstable and self-contradictory its elements were.[25] Ruthless scientific materialism had to cooperate with refined idealism, spiritualism, and aestheticism. (At the time I was first drafting this essay, an exhibition on "The Spiritual in Modern Art" in Los Angeles was heralding itself as a corrective to the falsely materialistic, secular, and hedonistic image that it saw dominating abstract painting.) Other contradictions came to abstraction as external forces. The cult of the "innocent eye" had to confront the empirical fact that innocent, uncultivated spectators found the new art utterly mystifying. The hope for an art that would prepare revolutionary consciousness had to face the reality that the only two actual revolutionary movements in the modern period, fascism and communism, both quickly rejected the avant-garde and abstraction.[26] The purist ideology of abstraction was continually disrupted, then, by impurities and contradictions within its own rhetoric, within the practice of its own artists, and from without—from the concrete world of historical circumstance.

Clement Greenberg's unquestionable supremacy as the apologist of abstract art in the United States is a direct consequence of his marvelous rhetorical juggling act, his ability to elide the contradictions in the program of abstract art. Greenberg's way of accomplishing this was to station himself as an insider/outsider to an avant-garde equated with pictorial abstraction, sympathetic to its basic program, but in a position to be historically critical of it at the same time. A

25. Clement Greenberg noted the contradictory elements of the abstractionist avant-garde ("tendencies go in opposite directions, and cross-purposes meet") but emphasizes their consolidation "into a school, dogma, and credo" (*Collected Essays,* I:30, 36).

26. It's important to note, however, that abstraction was only one among many avant-garde styles in the modern era. Among Greenberg's accomplishments was his fostering of the myth that abstraction was the uniquely privileged bearer of advanced artistic consciousness and that rival movements like dadaism and surrealism could be dismissed. For more on the privileging of abstraction, see the discussion of Alfred Barr and the note to Buchloh below.

typical expression of this equivocal position is the now-familiar sentence from "Towards a Newer Laocoon" (1940): "When the purist insists upon excluding 'literature' and subject matter from plastic art, now and in the future, the most we can charge him with off-hand is an unhistorical attitude" (I:23).

Greenberg puts himself in the position of the friendly advocate who helps out his client by minimizing the charge (the avant-garde is merely unhistorical) and offering to pay the fine by supplying that missing history. This history is, as it turns out, precisely that narrative of failed revolution and political marginalization of the avant-garde that, as we have seen, contradicts its idealized self-image. Even more disquieting, Greenberg makes it clear that the avant-garde, far from occupying a revolutionary posture, is actually a bourgeois movement that depends upon the patronage of the capitalist ruling classes for its sustenance; its "purity," from either a political or religious point of view, is continually in danger of being compromised by the vulgarity and materialism around it. In another sense, however, this very vulgarity, the popular productions of mass culture that Greenberg labels "kitsch," is what he offers to avant-garde culture as something to oppose, a common enemy that may distract it from its own impurities and contradictions. Kitsch is art which has not renounced its reliance on literature, which is filled with representations of familiar, formulaic, and sentimental stories: magazine covers (most notably the *Saturday Evening Post,* calendar art, Socialist Realism, and Hollywood movies (recently—in the forties—corrupted even further by learning to talk) are the principal visual examples. Kitsch is mass-produced, notes Greenberg, for the "industrial masses" who have recently been transformed by "universal literacy" into proper consumers for pseudo-art. Abstract art, then, is (like all high "formal" culture) actually an aristocratic form, made by and for a tiny elite in the cosmopolitan centers of advanced capitalist countries; in preindustrial societies, Greenberg even suggests that formal culture is "generally much superior" in "slave-owning tribes" (I:19n.6). All the pretensions to purity, immediacy, and "innocent eyes" are belied by the reliance of high formalist art on a very impure socioeconomic base and its appeal to a sophisticated, cultivated spectator whose eyes are far from innocent. The only thing that prevents this art from being, in Greenberg's words, a decadent "Alexandrianism" is that it is not "motionless," but dynamic and changing (I:6).

Greenberg's account of the materialist underside of abstract art is too vulgar for some consumers, not vulgar enough for others (he doesn't contemplate the possibility, for instance, that the "dynamic

movement" in avant-garde art may be something like the dynamic movement in automobile styles and dress fashions).[27] But it did have the salutary effect of exposing the contradictions of the avant-garde while at the same time holding it together in a precarious unity, at least for a few years. T. J. Clark has summarized Greenberg's position as an "Eliotic Trotskyism," a phrase that nicely captures the synthesis of conservative elitism and left-wing radicalism in Greenberg's rhetoric.[28] Greenberg codified both the ahistorical self-image of abstract purity and its claims to a historically inevitable role, a synthesis that can be seen falling to pieces in the debate between Michael Fried and T. J. Clark, Fried following what Clark calls the "old-time religion" of Greenberg's aestheticism, Clark following what Fried calls the "vulgar and demeaning" tendencies of Greenberg's Marxism.[29]

Greenberg's repression of the verbal element in abstract art, while thorough, was too explicit about the social meaning of these repressions, too clearly embattled in contradictions, to be successful in inaugurating a stable orthodoxy that could be elaborated as a discipline. (One might say that what Greenberg bequeathed us was a debate, of which the Clark-Fried encounter was a recent example.) The institutionalization of abstract art was already well prepared, however, by a slightly earlier text, Alfred H. Barr's *Cubism and Abstract Art,* the catalog for the 1936 show of European abstract painting at the Museum of Modern Art. Barr's way of repressing the verbal dimension of abstract art is, in contrast to Greenberg, simply not to mention it as a matter that was *ever* of concern to painters of any period. The motive force in Barr's history is nothing more complex than boredom:

> The pictorial conquest of the external visual world had been completed and refined many times and in different ways during the previous half millennium. The more adventurous and original artists had grown bored with painting facts. By a common and powerful impulse they were driven to abandon the imitation of natural appearance. (first published, 1936; Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1986, p. 11)

27. See Leo Steinberg, *Other Criteria,* for a consideration of this possibility.

28. See "Clement Greenberg's Theory of Art," in *The Politics of Interpretation,* edited by W. J. T. Mitchell (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1983), pp. 203–20.

29. This debate, which first developed in *Critical Inquiry* (September 1982), grew out of Fried's response to Clark's essay on Clement Greenberg, cited above, and is reprinted in *The Politics of Interpretation,* pp. 203–38.

The "history" that follows is a sequence of artifacts, names of movements, styles, and influences with only the most cursory reference to the historical conditions that gave them urgency. What Barr does provide in the place of history, however, is a highly compelling myth that synthesizes perfectly the scientific and religious self-representations of abstract art. This myth, in contrast to the entangled controversies of art theory, is a kind of exoteric, publicly accessible crystallization of theory, one that can be codified easily for classroom presentations. Although Barr's text has actually been reissued only three times—1966, 1974, and 1986—its determination of the basic sequence of objects in the Permanent Collection of the Museum of Modern Art has exerted its influence upon thousands of beholders who have never read the book.[30]

If it seems that I am exaggerating in calling *Cubism and Abstract Art* a "mythic" text, I would ask you to read Robert Rosenblum's foreword to the 1986 edition. Rosenblum, a distinguished art historian who has written important books on the tradition of "pre-abstract" art in the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries,[31] defines Barr's influence in the most precise terms when he calls it the "Bible of modern art," a kind of "talisman" for the "budding art historian," with "an authority verging on the Old Testament's," a "rockbottom foundation for all my subsequent studies of twentieth century art" (p. 1), as it has been, I'm sure, for many generations of graduate students in art history. Even more significant than this tribute to Barr's

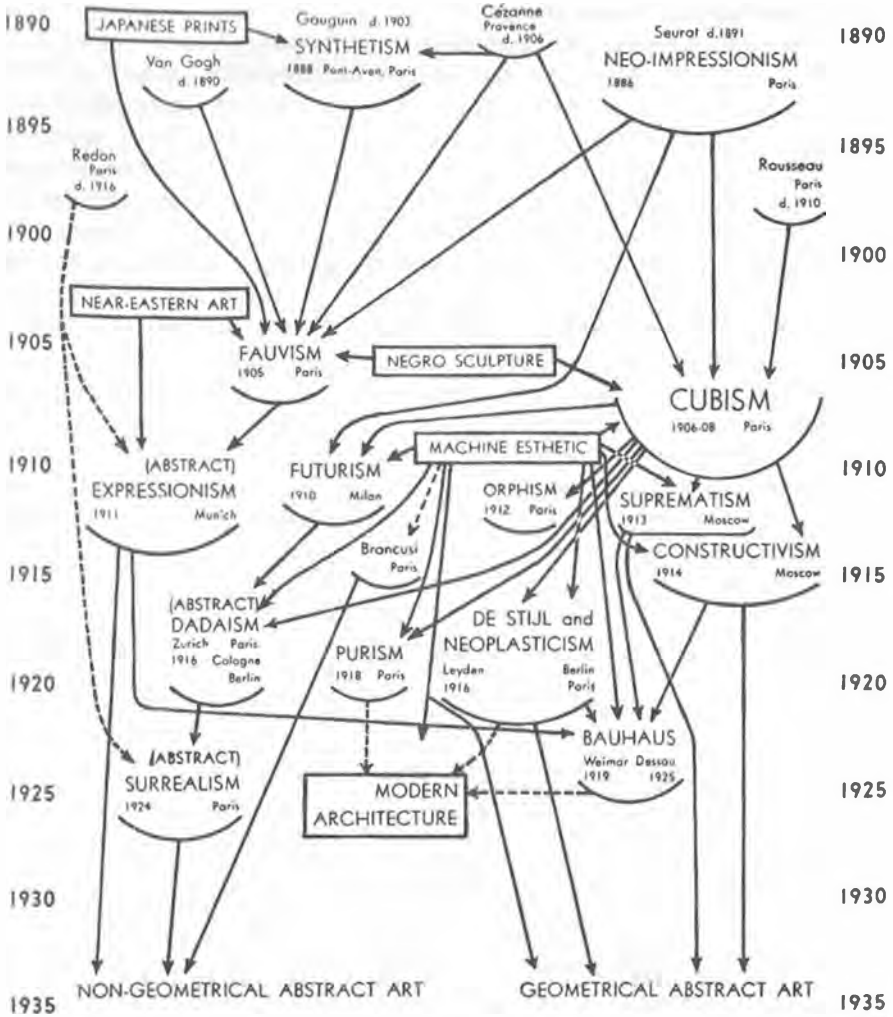
30. For an excellent account of Barr's de-historicizing influence on the American reception of modernism, see Benjamin H. D. Buchloh, "From Faktura to Factography," in *October: The First Decade, 1976–1986,* edited by Annette Michelson, Rosalind Krauss, Douglas Crimp, and Joan Copjec (Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 1987), pp. 77–113. Buchloh makes it clear that Barr laid the groundwork for the equation of the avant-garde with abstract painting. During Barr's visit to the Soviet Union in 1927 he tried in vain to find abstract paintings, the new productivist aesthetic having pushed painting aside. Undeterred, Barr "continued in his plan to lay the foundations of an avant-garde art in the United States according to the model that had been developed in the first two decades of this century . . . " (p. 78). For more on Barr's "reduced, decontextualized, and exclusionary view of modern art's history," see Terry Smith, *Making the Modern* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1993), chapter 11, "'Pure' Modernism, Inc.," pp. 385–95.

31. Robert Rosenblum, *Transformations in Late Eighteenth Century Art* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1967), and *Modern Painting and the Northern Romantic Tradition* (New York: Harper and Row, 1975); further page references will be cited in the text.

authority is Rosenblum's singling out of a particular image in Barr's text that mediated this authority. This image is not, as we might expect, the Malevich composition which adorns the cover of the 1986 edition, nor any of the Kandinskys or Braques or Picassos which punctuate its historical narrative. It is, rather, a scholar's image, a diagram of the evolution of modern art from impressionism to 1936 (figure 33). Rosenblum's commentary on this diagram (the diagram itself has unaccountably been left out of the 1986 reprint) is worth quoting at length:

> As for this diagram, I still recall vividly its heraldic power; for it proclaimed, with a schema more familiar to the sciences, an evolutionary pedigree for abstract art that seemed as immutable as a chart tracing the House of Windsor or the Bourbon Dynasty. Darwinian assumptions merged with the pursuit of genealogical blue blood in pronouncing, for instance, that a coupling of van Gogh and Gauguin created Fauvism, just as sodium and chlorine would make salt; and that Cubism, that most fertile of monarchs, had an amazing variety of princely offspring, from Orphism to Purism. At the bottom of the chart, which was marked off, in graph-paper fashion, by five-year periods, starting in 1890 at the top and ending with what was then the present, 1935, this multiplicity had been distilled into two parallel but polarized currents, nongeometrical and geometrical abstract art. The skeletal clarity and purity of this diagram were fleshed out in the text itself, which . . . outlined in the most pithy and impersonal way the visual mutations and the historical facts that accounted for the thrilling invention of a totally unfamiliar art belonging to our century and no other. (pp. 1–2)

Rosenblum's amazing pastiche of metaphors captures perfectly the contradictory elements in Barr's abstract image of abstract art: it is a religious icon and yet a scientific graph; a figure of ancient, traditional privilege and yet an image of chemical processes and Darwinian selection; an emblem of complex variety reducible to binary polarities converging in a single origin; a mere heuristic device, which could be casually left out of the latest edition, and a "heraldic" device invested with power and aura. All the paradoxes we have seen in the self-representation of abstract art are captured in Barr's diagram and naturalized as an organic image, an inverted tree which is at the same time a rational, artificial construction, a pyramid of deductions from first premises. This diagram can serve, moreover, for the elaboration of an indefinite number of narratives about the evolution of abstract art—as a quest-romance in which heroic artists search for the holy grail of pure abstraction, smashing the false, illusionistic images of



33. Chart prepared by Alfred H. Barr, Jr., for the jacket cover of the exhibition catalog *Cubism and Abstract Art,* by Alfred H. Barr, Jr., published by The Museum of Modern Art, New York, 1936. Exhibition held 2 March–19 April 1936. Photograph courtesy of The Museum of Modern Art, New York.

mere "nature" to find a spiritual essence; as a modern epic of scientific discovery that unveils the laws of light and visual perception; as a revolutionary saga that records the victories of an avant-garde in quest of moral and political regeneration. The discursive cement that holds all of these narratives together is a "rhetoric of iconoclasm" that stages the quest for purity as the destruction of outmoded, superstitious, or illusory images, a rhetoric in which aesthetic elitism, Marxist radicalism, and scientific rationalism can find a common language.[32]

Perhaps the most fundamental message of Barr's diagram is its graphic refutation of the idea that the modernist "grid" is a barrier between vision and language. What Barr provides, most conspicuously, is a *narrative* dimension to the perception of modern art which synthesizes the rhetoric of religious reformation with scientific "breakthroughs" and political progress. The myth of the absolute presence of the individual painting is articulated side-by-side with an even more insistent emphasis on its position in a temporal sequence: this is partly a result of Barr's treatment of paintings themselves as "events," as historically important moments in a master-narrative: "earlier and more creative years of a movement or individual have been emphasized at the expense of later work which may be fine in quality but comparatively unimportant historically" (p. 9). But even more significant is Barr's discussion of paths of influence as "entertaining sequences," a suggestion that one of the constitutive aesthetic *pleasures* in abstract painting is our sense of its place in a more or less familiar story. The story, in short, *should not be in principle* (though it may be in practice) the province of art historical professionals; it should be publicly readable and visible in the object. Clement Greenberg's claim that the pleasure of traditional painting is produced by the stories it represents resurfaces in a new form in Barr's version of abstract art. The difference is that the stories are represented in a different way and are known only to an elite audience of connoisseurs, critics, and historians; for them, the expressive improvisations of Kandinsky and the pure geometry of Malevich are eloquent hieroglyphics, memorials of great moments in the epic of abstract painting, stations of the cross in the theatrical passion play of modernism.

Barr's diagram, then, is like all abstract paintings a visual machine for the generation of language. Much of this language may be trivial chatter, as Jonathan Borofsky suggests, or misguided, as Clement Greenberg complained when he predicted that the average gallery-

32. See my essay, "The Rhetoric of Iconoclasm," in *Iconology* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1986).

goer would mutter "nothing but wallpaper" when confronted with a Jackson Pollock. Much of it may be the refinement and detailed elaboration of myths, as is a large portion of the art historical writing that grows out of Alfred Barr. But there is no use thinking we can ignore this chatter in favor of "the paintings themselves," for the meaning of the paintings is precisely a function of their use in the elaborate language game that is abstract art. There is also no use thinking that we could make an end run around the paintings and the discourse they embody into some objective "history" that will explain them. Our problem, I would suggest, is to work through the visual-verbal matrix that is abstract art, focusing on those places where this matrix seems to fracture its gridlike network of binary oppositions and admit the presence of something beyond the screen.

The best way I can illustrate this point is by focusing more closely on a disruptive element in the symmetry of Barr's diagram. Rosenblum describes this image as reducing the "multiplicity" of abstract art to "two parallel but polarized currents, nongeometrical and geometrical abstract art." But Rosenblum also notes in passing that there is a third current, represented in red in the first edition, but reduced to monochromatic black in the later printings. This "third current" is the "external" influence of "foreign" arts (the influence of what was called "Negro sculpture" on cubism being the most famous) and what might be called "internally foreign" arts drawn from industrial design—the box labeled "machine esthetic." Unlike the "heresies" of surrealism, dadaism, or synthetic cubism (all of which Barr manages to contain dialectically in the master-narrative of abstract art), these elements seem to originate elsewhere, to occupy the role of silent Other to abstract art's binary dialogue with itself. I say "silent Other" because Negro sculpture (for instance) does not "inform" or "influence" or "speak to" cubism the way cubism speaks to and dominates its "princely offspring." The black arrows in Barr's diagram mean something quite different from the red arrows—the difference, say, between influencing and being appropriated, or dominating and being dominated. The black arrows are father-son relationships; the red describe the relation of imperial master to colonial subject. Both the industrial basis of imperial domination (figured in the "machine esthetic") and the colonized subjects play the Other to the idealist dialectics of abstraction.[33]

33. It might be worth pondering the uncanny echoing of the color scheme in Malevich's *Red Square and Black Square,* which replaced Barr's diagram as the cover image in the 1986 edition of *Cubism and Abstract Art.*

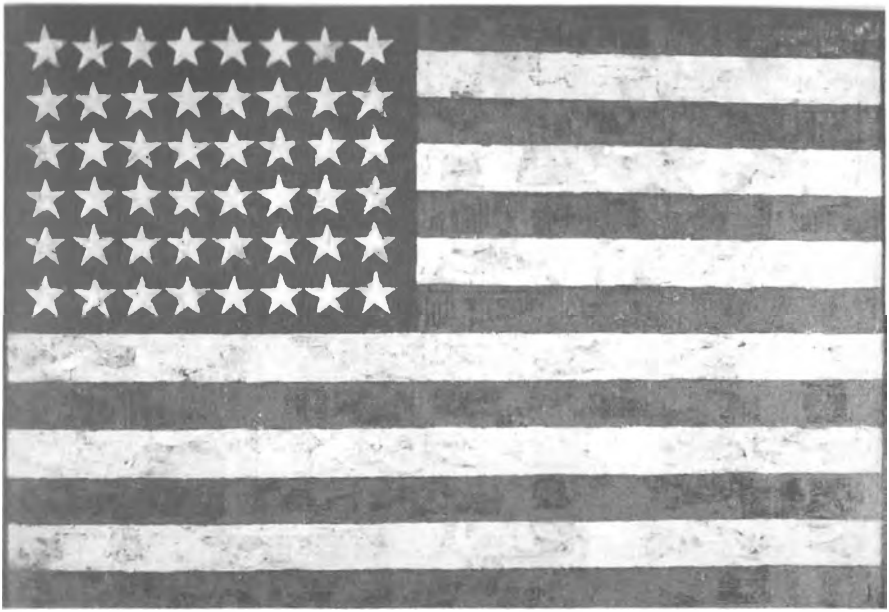
Barr's abstract grid, then, has a thread in it which, if read properly, opens onto a history and a social reality that complicates its self-representation as a quest for purity. Cool rationality and problem-solving "breakthroughs" may have as much to do with the automobile industry as with Platonic idealism.[34] As for the religious side of abstraction: Meyer Schapiro noted long ago the curious fact that "the highest praise" of a modern work of art "is to describe it in the language of magic and fetishism."[35] But which fetishism? The sense of irrational, timeless power discovered in the exotic arts of the primitive or the oriental? Or the more familiar, domestic phenomenon known as "commodity fetishism"—the projection of a magical halo onto expensive or well-publicized objects? Both these paths of abstraction lead back to the ordinary world—to the vulgar realities of imperialism at its outer and inner borders, to "kitsch," undeniably the world's first universal, imperial culture, to mass literacy and communication, to the universal narratives of "literary" painting, and to the social, historical realities abstraction tries to renounce under the name of literature. The only thing we can charge the purist with when he denies "literature," says Greenberg, "is an unhistorical attitude."

If we ask when abstraction stopped being an avant-garde movement, dying to be reborn as a tradition that must treat these forbidden subjects as heresies to be repressed, an obvious answer is: at least as early as Barr, who noted in 1935 that "ten years ago one heard on all sides that abstract art was dead" (p. 9) and who sees his own work as "in no sense a pioneering effort."[36] In America, the death knell is usually placed thirty years later, right after the Korean War, when a discharged soldier named Jasper Johns returned from America's first sobering experience as an imperial power and began to produce a series of paintings that outraged the high abstractionists and are

34. See Leo Steinberg, *Other Criteria,* for a development of this idea.

35. Meyer Schapiro, *Modern Art, 19th and 20th Centuries: Selected Papers* (New York: Braziller, 1978), p. 200. Schapiro is, so far as I know, the only early commentator on abstract art to see that its "primitivism" was directly linked to the "colonial imperialism that made these primitive objects physically accessible" (p. 200).

36. This may be Barr's tacit acknowledgment of his impressions during his 1927 visit to the Soviet Union where he indeed did hear "on all sides" that abstraction was no longer the interest of the avant-garde. The death knell in this case might be put back to 1915. See note to Buchloh above.



34. Jasper Johns, *Flag* (1954–55; dated 1954 on reverse). Encaustic, oil, and collage on fabric mounted on plywood, 42¼ × 60⅝". The Museum of Modern Art, New York. Gift of Philip Johnson in honor of Alfred H. Barr, Jr. © Jasper Johns/VAGA, New York 1993.

widely regarded as bringing the end of modernist abstraction and the beginning of postmodernism. Johns's two most famous motifs of this period, the "Flag" and "Target" series (see figures 34 and 35), bring us back to where we started, to the silent grid, now uniting the two traditions of Barr's diagram by rendering pure geometry with expressionistic, antigeometrical brush-strokes. The Hegelian binarism is preserved at the level of form and technique, an apt focus for the by now traditional discourse of *ut pictura theoria,* with its metaphysics of purity, flatness, and anti-illusionism. But a new "other" from the concrete, ordinary world breaks into and dominates this refined discourse—nothing less than the sort of kitsch icons Greenberg had banished from serious art. The first is a sentimental emblem, a totem of mass culture surrounded by the connotations of nationalistic demagoguery that Clement Greenberg had always associated with kitsch and Walter Benjamin associated with fascism (associations that seem unavoidable for a painting from the early fifties, the era of HUAC,

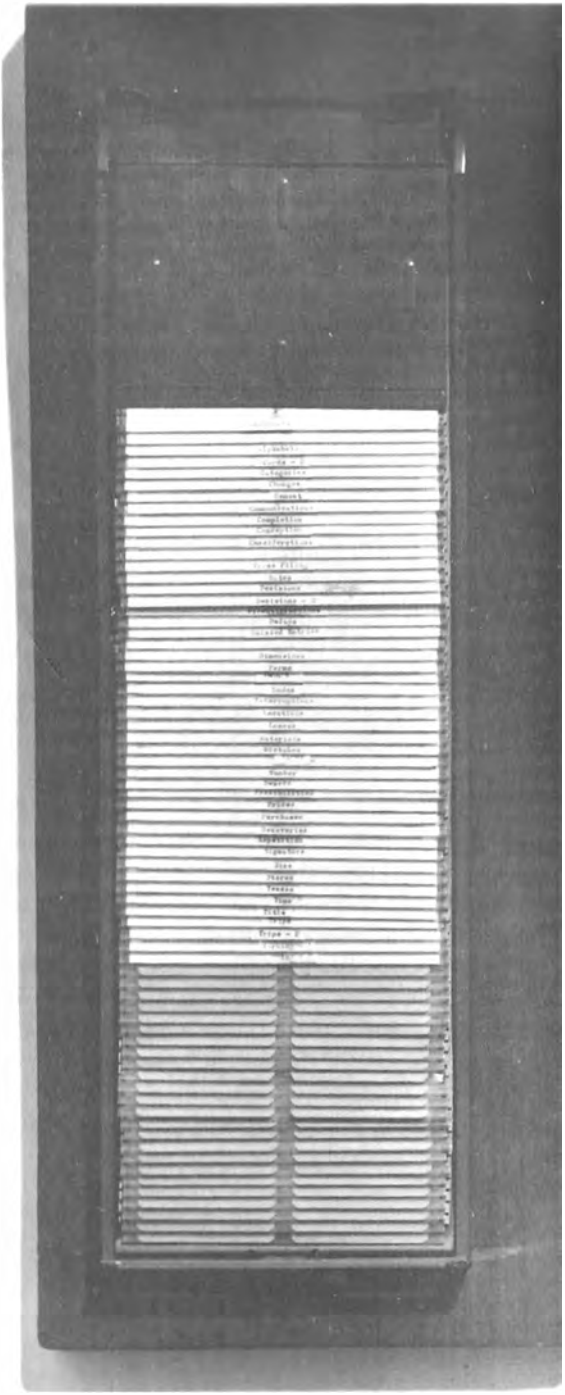
35. Jasper Johns, *Target with Four Faces* (1955). Assemblage: encaustic and collage on canvas with objects, 26 × 26″ surmounted by four tinted plaster faces in wood box with hinged front. Box, closed, 3¼ × 26 × 3½″. Overall dimensions with box open, 33⅝ × 26 × 3″. The Museum of Modern Art, New York. Gift of Mr. and Mrs. Robert C. Scull. © Jasper Johns/ VAGA, New York 1993.

McCarthy, and Cold War flag-waving).[37] The other motif, like the flag, is a version of the grid, but in this case it is not the grid of national unity and imperial power, but a figure of the field of power and surveillance on which it stands, an optical array whose function is the cultivation of predatory, aggressive vision. The purity of this optical, painterly statement is disrupted by a kind of sculptural editorial comment in the plaster figures displayed across the top. In one version we find four identical faces with the eyes cut off, as if the aggressive vision invited by the target implied a blindness somewhere else. In another version, we find fragments of the human form, once again, displayed as a kind of consequence of or comment on the proposition articulated by the target. It's hard to imagine a more

37. These associations were clear to Alfred Barr, who refused to buy *Flag* for the Museum of Modern Art, "fearing political repercussions." See Michael Crichton, *Jasper Johns* (New York: Harry Abrams, 1977), p. 73.

vulgar and direct set of statements combined with a more subtle commentary on the tradition that Johns grows out of and deconstructs. In retrospect, it may seem hard to understand how difficult it was for critics committed to the purist, abstractionist agenda to see what was happening in these works, to comprehend their inevitability in relation to the master-narratives to which the purists were themselves committed. The "Flags" and "Targets" compositions have by now become as transparently emblematic of an artistic revolution as the abstractions of Malevich were to Alfred Barr. The revolution they signal, commonly called "postmodernism," in retrospect, has been no less problematic, equivocal, unfinished, and prematurely obsolete than the modernism it claimed to supersede. The replacement of global imaginaries like the Cold War and nuclear holocaust by new global realities such as the triumph of corporate capitalism and neofascist nationalisms no doubt requires a reassessment and a renaming of the cultural dominants of our period and a reconsideration of exactly what postmodernism has come to.

Among the accomplishments of the revolution signaled by Johns's "Flags" and "Targets" was the reopening of art (for better or worse) to what Edward Said would call "wordly" concerns—to kitsch, mass culture, the mixture of media, political propaganda, and theater—the resurgence of artistic impurity, hybridity, and heterogeneity summarized as the "eruption of language into the aesthetic field." This "eruption" has occasioned new, revisionist histories of the modernism it supplanted, histories in which Greenbergian abstraction tends to be de-centered and jostled about by alternative traditions in modernism. The survival of these alternative modernist traditions—not only the obvious ones like surrealism, dadaism, and constructivism, but what one might call the "redlined" zones of Barr's diagram, the "primitive" and the "industrial"—made possible the opening of new regions of the seeable and sayable in both modernism and postmodernism. The exploration of one of these regions, the reconfigured relation of word, image, and object in minimalism, specifically in the sculpture, painting, and writing of Robert Morris, will be the subject of the next essay.



36. Robert Morris, *Card File*, 1963. Mixed media on board. Ca. 10 × 20″. Pompidou Center, Paris.

WORD, IMAGE, AND OBJECT: WALL LABELS FOR ROBERT MORRIS

The relation of word and image seems exactly analogous to the relation of words and objects. The imagetext reinscribes, within the worlds of visual and verbal representation, the shifting relations of names and things, the sayable and seeable, discourse *about* and experience *of*. And yet the obvious analogy draws all its interest from the equally obvious and radical discrepancy between images and objects, representations and *pre*sentations. What is this discrepancy? Is it nothing more than a flash of repetition, a double take like the one that transforms an object into an image, a picture into a metapicture? What is an object? What is its relation to a subject and to the words and images that subjects construct to make objects intelligible? The contemporary artist who has thought most deeply about these questions is Robert Morris, whose work and writing have also been central to the articulation of what might now be called "High Postmodernism," the mounting of a direct challenge to and continuation of the modernist tradition of *ut pictura theoria*. In the sixties, Morris was the principal antagonist of Michael Fried's "great refusal" of new antimodernist work in "Art and Objecthood": he served as the major exemplar of theatricality, mixtures of media, and a new kind of obdurate, objectlike sculpture that seemed to deny any possibility of optical, pictorial, or figural incident, while drawing quite explicitly on a theoretical discourse for which the works seemed to function as demonstrations. I'm less interested in positioning Morris within the familiar narratives of postmodernism, however, than in tracing his inquiry into the relations of images, objects, and words, especially those words that allow us to label artistic objects and thus to tell stories about them, including stories about "modernism" and "postmodernism."[1] My aim, in short, is to examine the way Morris's

1. Among the numerous studies of postmodernism, I have found most stimulating and reliable Fredric Jameson's *Postmodernism, or the Cultural Logic of Late Capitalism* (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 1991), and

work complicates and contests the labels that make his objects intelligible.

The appearance of Morris's work in a major Guggenheim retrospective in 1994 ought to have settled the question of his status. The label of "Major Artist" could now be safely inscribed over the entrance to the exhibition, and the works could be safely labeled as masterpieces, no matter how unprepossessing their visual appearance. All that remained was the packaging of Morris's work in a canonical history that would position him in the contexts of modernism and postmodernism and unpack the meanings of his objects in the terms provided by poststructuralist theories of art.

> *The wall label disturbed my sleep. It grew to threatening proportions, entwined itself around me, babbled in my ear, wrapped itself over my eyes. It was a tangled, suffocating shroud of seething words in my dream. But in dreams begin responsibility, as the insomniac poet said. Have I had a dream of warning? I get up edgy.*[2]

It is a tribute to both the intransigence of the art-viewing public and the resilience of Morris's art that the labeling, packaging, and securing of both the Work and the works is not likely to proceed without some trouble. More than any American artist of his generation, "Morris" (considered as the name of a total oeuvre) has managed to remain unpredictable, hard to classify, and difficult to label in the terminology of styles, artistic movements, and periods. And yet, if one had to produce a "representative" American artist for the period from 1960 to 1990, one could hardly do better than Morris. One of the complaints about his work, in fact, is that it is *too* representative, that it merely holds up a mirror to the art of its time, working across all the genres of postmodern artistic practice (minimalist and conceptual sculpture, performance art, land art, scatter pieces, felt works, painting, drawing, photography, ready-mades, image-text composites, procedural works) without committing itself to any single mode or style.

David Harvey, *The Condition of Postmodernity* (Cambridge, MA: Blackwell, 1990). Harvey and Jameson share a refusal to accept postmodernism on its own terms (that is, as a collapse of metanarratives, the search for a new ensemble of artistic styles, or a mere negation of modernism) and an insistence on strategic gestures of totalizing (as distinct from presumed "totalities"). While Pop Art (and typically the work of Andy Warhol) has become canonical for the historical periodization of nascent postmodernism in the sixties, the role of American minimalism seems to me equally crucial.

2. Dream journal entry by Robert Morris, 10/28/90.

Morris's work both invites and resists labeling, lending itself to instant (mis)recognition in terms of the generic labels endemic to postmodernism, while refusing the overall label of the individual artistic style or "look." There is no way to identify "a Morris" by its visual appearance from across a room, no way to predict with any certainty what his new work will look like, and yet his work never seems to appear without inviting ready-made labels.[3] His turn in the late eighties to works that look like monumental paintings (the Holocaust and firestorm series; the blind time drawings; the Wittgenstein drawings and the associated series of large encaustic paintings on aluminum panels) could hardly have been predicted from his previous work. Those who had defined Morris's career as a practitioner within specific media had grown used to labeling him as a sculptor and (more important) as a sculptor who saw his medium as expressing concerns "not only distinct but hostile to those of painting."[4] The reaction of critics to his "shift" to painting was predictable. There was, on the positive side, a rush to certify his credentials as a painter by bringing out his early exercises in abstract expressionism.[5] On the negative side, he was accused (as so often before) of being a merely eclectic experimentalist and imitator of prevailing fashion. The large encaustic paintings with their enigmatic stenciled texts were seen as belated attempts to capitalize on the fashion for image-text composites pioneered by younger American artists in the late eighties.[6]

My own insomnia begins. What have I previously ignored, not wished to think about? A mere wall label? An institutional excrescence, a blurt

3. One notable exception to this generalization might be his use of flat gray paint on the minimalist objects of the sixties. As David Antin noted, this gray became "a signature and to that extent, perhaps, somewhat independent of any individual work, like Newman's stripes" (*ArtNews* 65:2 [April 1966]: 56). At the same time, the paradoxical implications of using a neutral colorless color like gray as a signature of a personal style can hardly be ignored. The noncommittal character of grayness is more like a mask for any personal identity, a kind of coloristic "John Doe" signature that signals Morris's refusal to underwrite his works with claims to authentic or personal self-revelation.

4. Robert Morris, "Notes on Sculpture I," *ArtForum* 4:6 (February 1966): 42.

5. See the essays by Barbara Rose and Terrie Sultan in *Inability to Endure or Deny the World*, the catalog of the Corcoran Gallery's 1990–91 Morris retrospective.

6. See Roberta Smith, "A Hypersensitive Nose for the Next New Thing," *New York Times*, 20 January 1991, p. 33.

of public relations jargon, a mere supplement? Ah, there's the rub. Beware of supplements.

The problem of labeling Morris is, I want to suggest, not merely a pragmatic or curatorial issue concerned with the management of an unusually large and diverse oeuvre. It reflects a whole set of issues internal to Morris's work and characteristic of the shifting relation of art and language in the era for which he is such an apt representative. Thus, on the one hand, Morris's work has consistently engaged itself not just with the elaboration of a verbal program that lies "behind" the art, as a theoretical scaffolding or prop for the objects, but with the exploration of art itself as language, of the object or image as a complex intersection of the seeable, the sayable, and the palpable. Morris's writing and his art have staged this intersection, not as a settled boundary between words and images, words and objects, but as a site of anxiety, play, and disruption. That we do not know what a Morris will "look like," that he offers no consistent visual style, is at once cause and consequence of the difficulty with labeling, of mustering an adequate, much less authoritative, descriptive language for his work.

The wall label disturbed my sleep. It raises the insomniac's cold sweat. This wall label begins to throb with ambiguous threat, refusing its repressed status as linguistic blurb. This institutional, tautological annoyance slithers and coils in the shadows. It begins to grow larger than the works proper in my dream galleries; a snarling, looming, hypnagogic presence.

This difficulty with labeling is, moreover, not simply a problem with Morris, but reflects a central obsession of postmodernism, which has itself consistently been labeled as the exploration of a new relation between art and language. Modernism—at least in Clement Greenberg's classic formulation—sought to evacuate language, literature, narrative, and textuality from the field of visual art.[7] Postmodern art, not surprisingly, has been defined as the negation of this negation, "an eruption of language into the aesthetic field."[8] From a

7. See Clement Greenberg's "Towards a Newer Laocoon," (1940), reprinted in *The Collected Essays and Criticism,* edited by John O'Brian (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1986), pp. 23–37, and the discussion of abstraction and language in chapter 7.

8. Craig Owens, "Earthwords," *October* 10 (Fall 1979): 125–26.

gridlike art of "purity" and opticality expressing what Rosalind Krauss calls a "will to silence,"[9] we have (so the story goes) moved to an art of noise, discourse, and speechifying, characterized by impure, hybrid forms that couple the visual and the verbal, or erase the difference between image and text. The de-purifying of artistic opticality has been accompanied by a de-throning of the notion of the artist as the creator of an original *image*, a novel visual gestalt that bursts fully formed from the mind of the artistic "seer" to dazzle and fixate the spectator. In the place of this art of the purified and original image, postmodernism has offered pastiche, appropriation, ironic allusion, an art addressed to spectators who are more likely to be puzzled than dazzled and whose thirst for visual pleasure often seems deliberately thwarted.

Like all art-historical master narratives, this one is a myth, a compound of half-truths and oversimplifications that nevertheless has a certain power to frame the production and reception of art. It is a story to which Morris himself has contributed, both as narrator and actor, writer and artist.[10] It is, in short, a story whose historical effects must be reckoned with, even by those who want to resist them or who want to situate this story in relation to larger, longer, or more nuanced histories. A larger historical frame, for instance, would ask us to consider the relation of this (mainly American) story of art to the fortunes of American culture in the era of the Cold War and the nuclear nightmare, a period that, in the very moment of Morris's retrospective, seems now to be clearly "behind" us, replaced by the quite different concerns of a post-nuclear, post–Cold War "New World Order," and the final victory of capitalism as a world system.[11] A longer view would ask whether the changing relation of art and language central to postmodernism was not already occurring in its basic forms in early European modernism (notably in dadaism, surre-

9. Rosalind Krauss, "Grids," in *The Originality of the Avant-Garde and Other Modernist Myths* (Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 1985), p. 8.

10. See Morris's essay, "Words and Images in Modernism and Postmodernism," *Critical Inquiry* 15:2 (Winter 1989): 337–47, and my article, "*Ut Pictura Theoria*: Abstract Painting and the Repression of Language," pp. 348–71, for a discussion of this history.

11. For a discussion of Morris's work in the context of the late Cold War culture of the 1980s, see O. K. Werckmeister, *Citadel Culture* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1991), especially the chapter entitled "Lucas, Morris."

alism, and in the work of the various historical avant-gardes).[12] From this standpoint, the cult of visual purity and the will to silence might look more like a temporary aberration, an interlude associated with the removal of modern art, especially abstract painting, from its European context into the purified spaces of the Museum of Modern Art. The "eruption of language into the aesthetic field" might seem less transgressive and look more like the restoration of a basic condition of art, which has, after all, been impure for most of its history. A more nuanced view, finally, would have to address the ways in which the cults of both visual purity and visual-verbal hybridity intersect with transformations in visual and textual culture more broadly considered. If Clement Greenberg's "kitsch" became the impure negative foil for his purist "avant-garde" at a certain cultural moment around World War II, we would have to notice that this dialectic between mass and elite culture takes on a variety of other forms in other places and times, both before and after the moment of high modernist abstraction in the United States. However much minimalism may have departed from some of the pictorialist and expressivist tendencies of formal abstraction, there is no doubt that it continued this tradition in its search for purity and its aesthetic elitism. In this respect, minimalist visual art, especially sculpture, seems quite antithetical to the sort of decorative, patterned musical minimalism of Steve Reich or Phil Glass. John Cage's 4′33″ of "silence" provides the appropriate musical setting for Morris. Duchamp, not the mass media, provides the model for the hybrid visual/verbal character of his objects: "One foot in images, the other in language, this is the least immediate and most discursive form of art-making."[13]

> *Now I am awake, yet the label refuses to shrink. Here beneath the dim lamp its rectangularity seems to pulsate, its language groans and threatens. This blot of words screeches and sobs and finally recedes to a menacing tell-tale tick of mumbling under the floor boards.*

The relation of art and language, object and label, is one of the principal paradoxes of minimalist sculpture. On the one hand, the beholder is confronted by simple, spare, elemental, usually "untitled"

12. See Morris's discussion of writer-artists like Kandinsky, Malevich, Gabo, and Mondrian who "contributed to a growing body of theoretical texts, some in the form of manifestos, which grew up alongside the material production of the images. . . . " in "Words and Images," p. 341.

13. Robert Morris, "American Quartet," *Art in America* (December 1981): 104.

objects that seem deliberately "inexpressive," "deadpan," and "inarticulate."[14] What can objects labeled "Slab," "Beam," and "Box" say to us? What can we possibly say about them? The labels seem to say it all, to exhaust the object and the visual experience of the object. The whole situation of minimalism seems designed to defeat the notion of the "readable" work of art, understood as an intelligible allegory, an expressive symbol, or a coherent narrative. On the other hand, minimalism is often characterized as an unprecedented intrusion by language—especially critical and theoretical language—into the traditionally silent space of the aesthetic object. As Harold Rosenberg put it: "No mode in art has ever had more labels affixed to it by eager literary collaborators. . . . No art has ever been more dependent on words than these works pledged to silent materiality. . . . The less there is to see, the more there is to say."[15] Even worse than the "literary collaborators" and the chatter of the ever-helpful critics, according to Rosenberg, is the fact that the minimalist artists themselves became writers. All the traditional divisions of labor in the art/language game were confused. The mute, inarticulate sculptor who was supposed to make infinitely expressive images for the delectation of the infinitely receptive (and articulate) aesthete, has been replaced by the articulate sculptor who makes mute objects for a puzzled beholder.

> *Then with a certain trembling it strikes me, there is no such thing as a 'mere wall label.' The phrase ratchets through my feverish brain. This label, this mutter of slurred information has a secret ambition. No doubt about it, its aim is nothing less than dominating my images there on the wall. Its linguistic hysteria begins to erode the encaustic from my panels.*

In one sense this paradox has now been prematurely resolved by institutional art history. The canonizing of minimalism, the stabilizing of its label as a fixture in the succession of twentieth-century styles, has now made these mute objects, once so strange and silent, seem

14. Rosalind Krauss, *Passages in Modern Sculpture* (Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 1977), pp. 236, 199.

15. Harold Rosenberg, "Defining Art," in *Minimal Art: A Critical Anthology,* edited by Gregory Battcock (New York: Dutton, 1968), p. 306. See also Michael Fried's characterization of the minimalist object as "literalist" (understood as a hypostatizing of objecthood) and dependent upon an "ideological" position, "one that can be formulated in words, and in fact has been formulated by some of its leading practitioners" ("Art and Objecthood," *ArtForum* (June 1967), reprinted in Battcock, pp. 116–17).

full of memorable association and anecdote for those in the know. The writings and conversation of the artists, most notably of Morris—"the most subtle of the Minimalist dialecticians," according to Rosenberg (p. 305), have now become inseparable from the experience of the knowledgeable beholder. But what about the ignorant beholder, the one who walks into the gallery or museum cold and experiences minimalism as a shock of deprivation and disappointment? We can't even console ourselves that this shock is something like that of the original puzzled beholder (for example, Rosenberg) in the sixties, because the context now is quite different. The jury is no longer out. The works have the authority of canonical labeling. If you don't get the point, it is a judgment on you, not on the works. What do we say to the innocent viewer now? What is the present availability of these works? Do they have any fate beyond canonization in a system of labels and myths?

> *The wall label has disturbed my sleep. I must get a grip on myself, or at least on the label. I must squeeze it back to its true ignoble proportions. But it is elusive as it gleams there in the dark with its Poe-like atmospherics of linguistic threat and verbal iconoclasm.*

Morris himself seems unsure on this point, noting already in 1981 that minimalism had run out of steam: "As the dialectical edge of minimalism grew dull, as it had to in time, and as the radicality of its imagery, contexts or processes became routine, its options dwindled to a formula; use more space."[16] But Morris was only a drop-in minimalist in the first place, albeit its most articulate spokesman. His interest from the first was much more complex and general than any work within a style or movement "look." He had been concerned with nothing less than the philosophical task of art, the employment of sculpture, understood as a hybrid grafting of word, image, and object, as the vehicle for a reflection on art.[17] This makes Morris unpopular and impolitic. He is an "artist's artist," not in the usual sense of technical, stylistic virtuosity (despite his reputation as a perfectionist craftsman), but in the depth of his intervention into the basic issues of aesthetics, and particularly the history of sculpture in

16. Robert Morris, "American Quartet," p. 96.

17. See Annette Michelson's important essay, "Robert Morris—An Aesthetics of Transgression," for the catalog of the 1969 show at the Corcoran Gallery of Art for the first serious treatment of Morris as a philosophical sculptor.

what Krauss aptly calls its "expanded" field.[18] Morris makes philosophical objects that need not have any *visual* family resemblance, no "look" that can be labeled. What they have in common is strictly not visible, not representable, and difficult to label except perhaps as something like "philosophy." It is a body of questions and decisions, some rational, others arbitrary; a series of concerns, experiments, concepts, procedures, attitudes—in short, a discursive field or grid, like a card file, a catalog of the considerations and topics that might come up in the making of an art object labeled "Card File" (figure 36). This means his work is hard to consume, much less digest, at the level of visual pleasure. The objects don't even do us the courtesy of "illustrating" Morris's discourse in any straightforward way. One might think of his objects less as examples or illustrations than as *cases* to be opened, pondered, and (sometimes) closed,[19] specific word/image/object assemblages that, when successful, exceed and explode (or incorporate) the labels that accompany them.[20]

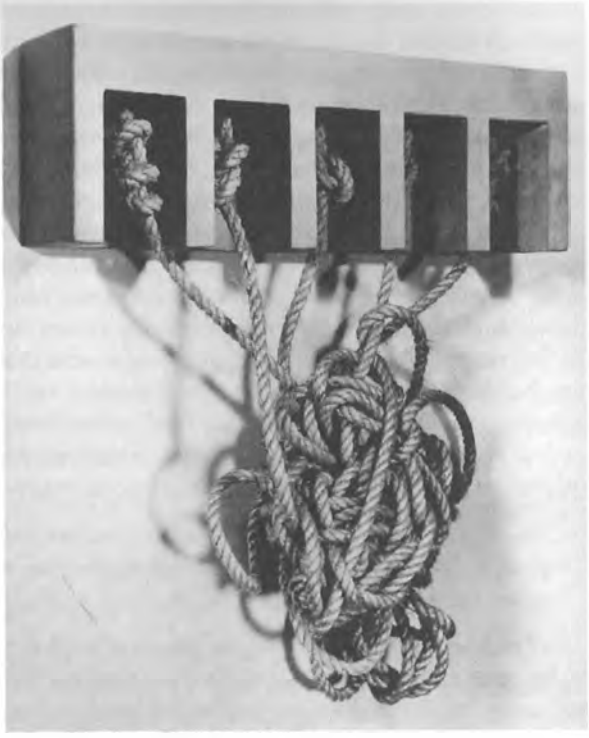
> *Show yourself in the light, wall label. Come out of the shadows of the gallery. But this protean linguistic monster hides behind the institutional leadenness of its prose.*

In short, one actually has to do some hard thinking, some serious talking to oneself or a friend in the presence of this work. One has to understand the dialogue provoked by the objects *in situ* as part of

18. Rosalind Krauss, "Sculpture in the Expanded Field," in *The Originality of the Avant-Garde,* pp. 276–90.

19. Sometimes, of course, Morris's "cases" cannot be opened. We may know that the minimalist pieces of the sixties are hollow, but the impossibility of looking inside them is part of the point. Morris's cabinet with lock and key and inscription, "Leave key on hook inside" suggests another situation—a case that could be "looked into" one and only one time, and then would be closed forever.

20. I'm thinking here of the "case" as the concept is used in sociology and psychology (case "studies" and case "histories") and the concomitant ambiguity about the theoretical/empirical status of the elementary units of research. For an outline of the basic concept of the sociological "case," see Charles C. Ragin and Howard S. Becker, *What Is A Case?* (New York: Cambridge University Press, 1992), p. 9. The literal and material figure of the "case" as a hollow container and its figurative extension to hermeneutics (the secret or solution to a mystery hidden inside a case) is also relevant here. I'm grateful to James Chandler for bringing the sociological analysis of the case to my attention.



37. Robert Morris, *Untitled ("Knots")*, 1963. Wood box, 5⅛ × 15¼ × 3½" (overall height with rope approximately 20 inches.

what the works are. The objects take time, much more time than a label allows, certainly more time than we have (though John Cage, reportedly, sat and listened for three and one-half hours to the entire tape loop of *Box with the Sound of Its Own Making*). And this time is not a hermeneutic duration, a process of interpretation and description that leads to the hidden truth or meaning, but a movement from apparent order to a labyrinth of knots, unsolved problems, conundrums, and disagreeable absences.[21] (As an emblem of this movement, one might consider Morris's notched wooden bar with knots [figure 37], which displays a rational, machine-tooled object as the "support" for a chaotic tangle, or his various "ruler" pieces that display the

21. Michael Fried accurately gauged, I think, the peculiar temporality involved in minimalist sculpture, contrasting it with the sense of "instantaneousness" he associates with modernist painting and sculpture. See "Art and Objecthood," in Battcock, pp. 144–46.

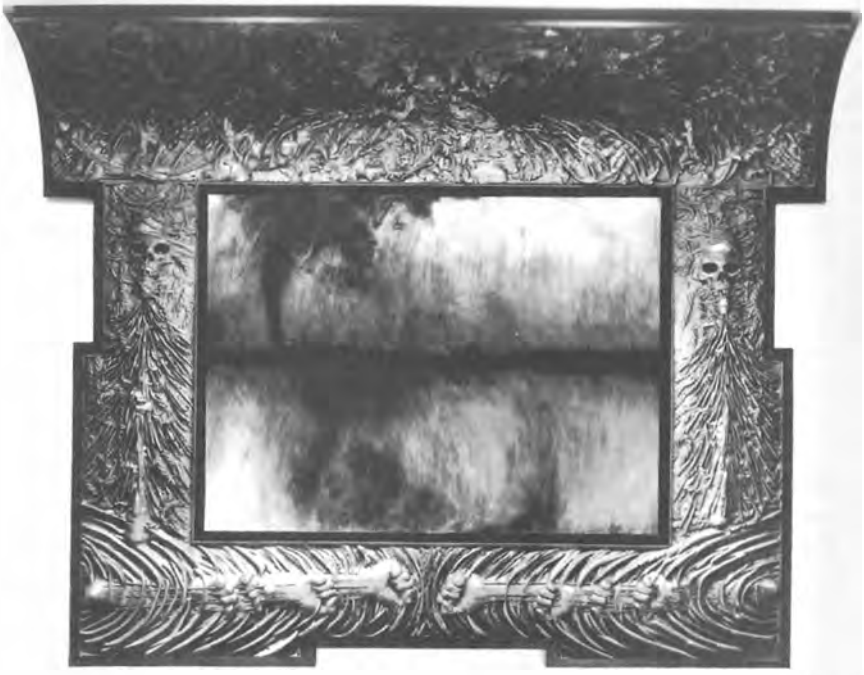
constructed, conventional, and arbitrary character of rational measurement.)

Morris couples the purism of the abstract formalist tradition with the relentless, corrosive irony of Duchamp to produce a "rational" or at least "systematic" art that aims at perfect lucidity about the possibility that art and history (not to mention art history) might be nightmares from which we can never awake. Like Walter Benjamin, he asks us to contemplate his objects as "dialectical images," documents of civilization that insist on being seen simultaneously as documents of barbarism.[22] The cool, gray formalism of the polyhedrons and the chaotic anti-form of the scatter pieces are incompatible within the short circuit of "look" and "label," but rigorously connected within a dialectics of the object. Morris's "baroque" phase of firestorm and holocaust paintings in the 1980s is, at the level of "look" and "label" a regression to expressionist painting (figure 38). And their look and scale is surely appropriate to a meditation on the monumentalization of death and annihilation in the eighties, the Decade of Greed, Star Wars, and Reaganomics—the final glorious days of triumph over the "Evil Empire," the transition from the prospect of sudden nuclear catastrophe to slow environmental destruction. No wonder they look like ornaments suitable for Darth Vader's boudoir.[23] They are not "expressions" of this period, however, but quotations of neoexpressionism enframed within sculptural counterquotations. In these works, the sculptor confronts the painter, insisting on the *frame* as an equal partner in the work "proper," not a mere supplement or neutral setting for the picture. The hydrocal frames with their imprinted body parts and post-holocaust detritus stand as the framing "present" of the works, trophies or relics encrusted around the past event, the catastrophe that left the fossils as the imprints in which it is enframed.[24] Frame is to image as body is to the destructive element, as present is to past. Or (to be literal about it)

22. Walter Benjamin, "Theses on the Philosophy of History" (1940), in *Illuminations*, edited by Hannah Arendt (New York: Schocken, 1969), p. 256.

23. I owe this analogy to Janice Misurell Mitchell. See also O. K. Werckmeister's provocative discussion of Morris's firestorm and Holocaust paintings in *Citadel Culture,* especially the juxtaposition of Morris's "pre-war" paintings with the *Star Wars* trilogy by George Lucas, pp. 142–63.

24. Morris's inscriptions to these works move across the temporal dimensions suggested by the relation of frame to image. Thus "none *will be* ready when it touches down. Yet we *have seen* it gathering all these years. You *said* that there was nothing that could be done."



38. Robert Morris, *Untitled*, 1984. Painted cast Hydrocal, pastel on paper. Inscription: "None will be ready when it touches down. Yet we have seen it gathering all these years. You said there was nothing that could be done."

frame is to image as a remote possible future is to a less remote future. Someday, the works suggest, the past will be enframed in a present that makes these works look natural.

The "knot" arises when one realizes that this future would be one in which these paintings could never exist. Morris makes them look as if they were meant to survive a nuclear holocaust, but he (and we) are well aware that survivors of such a scene would have little interest in his or anybody else's art. This is art for a possible future in which art would not exist, monuments to a time beyond monuments. They critique a world in which, as Benjamin put it, "mankind . . . can experience its own destruction as an aesthetic pleasure of the first order."[25]

An anonymous editorial comment appended to Morris's 1981 *Art*

25. Walter Benjamin, "The Work of Art in the Age of Mechanical Reproduction" (1936), in *Illuminations*, p. 242.

in America essay, "American Quartet," accused the artist-writer of a kind of ghoulishness and gloom in his meditations on the aesthetic monumentalizing of death and destruction. The editor's polemic drew a picture of the relation between words and images, visual monuments and critical commentary in Morris's own essay, that locates the artist's "cultural charnel house" in the present of 1981, not in a projected future:

> For it suggests the image of works we deem significant, those which elicit extensive critical interpretation and even incite perpetual reinterpretation, as some sort of cultural carcasses, swarming and half-buried with seething words which, like the movement of a mass of maggots, impart both a certain disgusting motion and transformation to dead things. ("American Quartet," p. 105)

The very structure of this art critical hoax (the "editor" was Morris himself) epitomizes a typical Morris procedure. The essay is structured around the flagrantly minimalist image of a *table,* whose four corners represent Morris's canonical "grid," his picture of the four major figures and tendencies of American art (Pollock's abstract expressionism, Duchamp's metasystems, Hopper's mimetic realism, and Joseph Cornell's decorative surrealism): "considered as a totality, the model suggested here has three distinct levels: the upper grid, like a table-top, which locates positions and orientations; the four key paradigmatic lines (or legs) which form foci and boundaries as well as indicate a vertical dimension of enduring traditions; and at the roots of these traditions we pass into a theoretical realm" (p. 95). Morris evokes the tradition of the *tavola* and the historical/conceptual *tableau,* the classic rationalist device for spatializing a discursive totality, treating his "polygon" as a stage for art critical gestures that mimic the characteristic gestures of its four "key points" or "lodestones." Thus, his own prose (as the outraged editorial commentary complains) "wander[s] around a great deal," like the tracks of Pollock; it portrays the artist in the "sealed space of alienation" in the style of Hopper; it stuffs the virtual "box" of its conceptual grid with fragments of the entire history of modern art in the manner of Cornell. Then it turns, in the manner of Duchamp, and deconstructs the entire structure as "the ghoulish image of critics mumbling and chewing their dead artifacts on the table of commentary" (p. 105).

> *Are you innocence, sincerity? Are you but a few simple guiding words, a soothing "orientation"? Ah, but I catch your sneer, your twitching suspect words, your double meanings, your dominating strategies dis-*

guised beneath your platitudes. You wish to triumph once again (endlessly and forever) over the imagistic. Your agendas are always hidden.

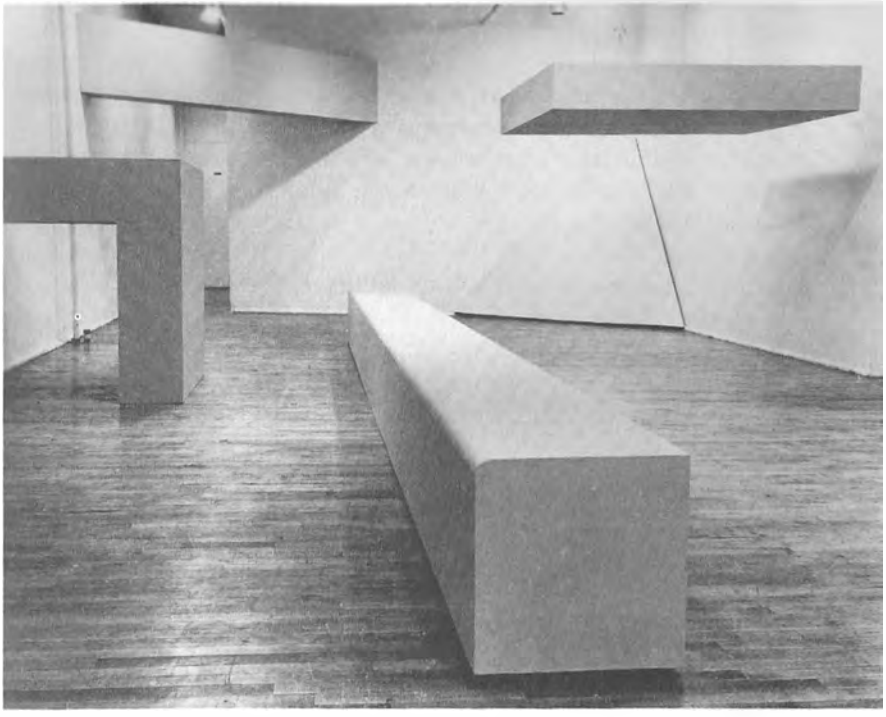
Morris's ambivalence about the adequacy of the visible form, then, does not imply any complacency or certainty about the place of philosophical language or critical discourse. You can't run from the objects to the labels or narratives provided by Morris's own writings. "American Quartet" is a self-devouring imagetext; it eats itself alive. Neither the image nor the word nor the object can be relied on to stabilize experience or meaning. Or perhaps it would be better to say: the stabilizing of relations among words, images, and objects is exactly what Morris's work tries to resist: "the only authenticity is one which has refused every identity conferred by an institution, a discourse, an image or a style, as well as every delight and oppression offered by that gulag called the autobiographical."[26] The rude blocks and beams of minimalism are, in Morris's usage, neither allegories of cultural totalities or figures of Platonic perceptual foundations:[27] they are better seen as something like the bricks that Ignatz the Mouse hurls at Krazy Kat whenever he has uttered some profound moral truism.[28] That is why the minimalist objects don't really reward an analysis that looks for phenomenological foundations as opposed to phenomenological *process* and contradiction. The choice of extraordinarily clear elementary polyhedrons, executed in specific materials at a precise scale in relation to the human body is aimed at revealing the disjunctions in the perceptual process, not at establishing elemental foundations (see installation view, figure 39). As the viewer moves in relation to the object, or the object moves into new situations, its "open and neutral" shape undergoes infinite variation:

> Even its most patently unalterable property—shape—does not remain constant. For it is the viewer who changes the shape constantly by his change in position relative to the work. Oddly, it is the strength of the constant, known shape, the gestalt, that allows this awareness to become so much more emphatic in these works than previous sculpture.

26. Robert Morris, interview with Robert Denson, forthcoming in *Critical Inquiry*.

27. See *Iconology*, pp. 93 and 158, however, for a discussion of the Platonic concept of the "provocative" and its relation to the concept of the dialectical image.

28. See Morris's unpublished interview with Robert Denson (forthcoming in *Critical Inquiry*), in which the artist recapitulates his entire career as a series of Krazy Kat dialogues, with minimalist objects as Ignatzian bricks.



39. Robert Morris, Installation view with assorted polyhedrons.

> A Baroque figurative bronze is different from every side. So is a six-foot cube. The constant shape of the cube held in the mind but which the viewer never literally experiences, is an actuality against which the literal changing, perspective views are related. There are two distinct terms: the known constant and the experienced variable. Such a division does not occur in the experience of the bronze.[29]

The terms here go back at least as far as Plato's division between the "intelligible" and the "visible," rephrasing them in the nominalist distinction between the "literal" and the "actual," a shift from an epistemological frame to a poetics or metaphysics of experience.[30] The question raised by Plato is how one distinguishes a "provocative" or

29. "Notes on Sculpture," in Battcock, p. 234.

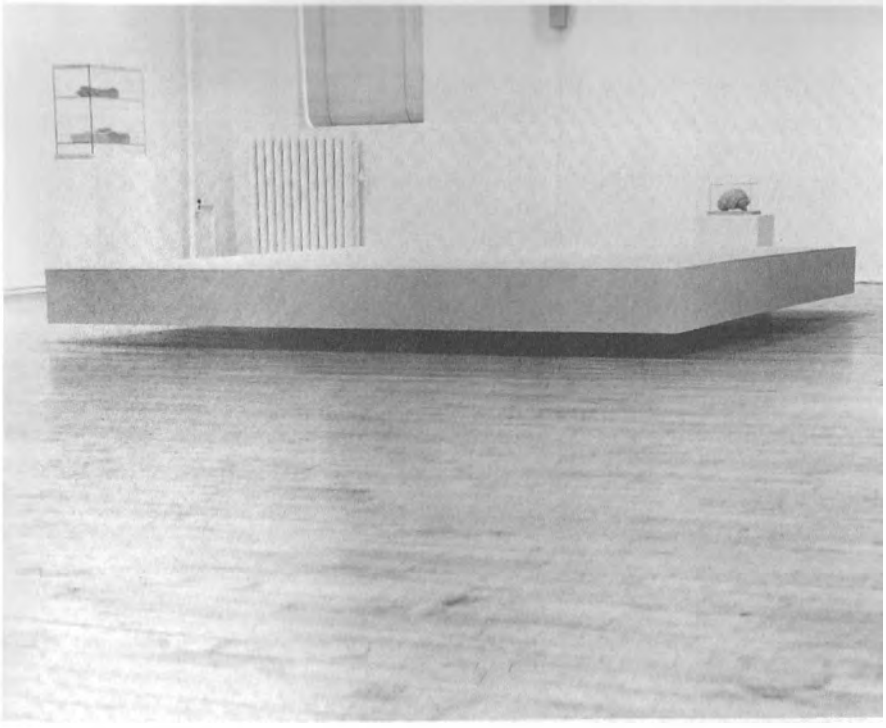
30. See Nelson Goodman on the "literal" and the "actual" in *Languages of Art* (Indianapolis, IN: Hackett, 1976), p. 68.

"dialectical" object—"things that are provocative of thought"—from things that are not. His answer is that "provocative things . . . impinge upon the senses together with their opposites."[31] That is what makes them dialectical—namely, occasions for the experience of difference and contradiction and thus provocatives to dialogue. The staging of the object, its insertion into a space and an institutional context that invites aesthetic reflection is, obviously, a necessary but not sufficient condition for the provocation to dialogue. The object itself—its specific materials, facture, lighting, color, orientation—offers factors that must be taken into account. Above all, its *scale* (especially in relation to the norm of the human body) invites "the intelligence . . . to contemplate," in Plato's words, "the great and small, not thus confounded but as distinct entities" (p. 159). In Morris's terms, the goal is to explore the delicate intermediate realm "between the monument and the ornament," between the private sphere of intimacy and the gigantic proportions of mass perception, an in-between space that Morris consistently associates with a "public mode" of perception.[32]

Another way to define the delicate intermediate zone opened up by this sort of object is to ask exactly how valuable or important the object is, what sort of claims it puts on the beholder. It's clear, for instance, that Morris's polyhedrons are not unique objects, but material realizations of three-dimensional concepts, open to indefinite reproduction. Many of his "original" minimal objects have been lost or destroyed and have been refabricated in other (often more expensive and durable) materials than the original plywood constructions. The decision to refabricate many of these objects in plywood for his retrospective, rather than to borrow them from the collections where they now reside, illustrates the peculiar chameleon quality of the pieces. On one hand, this choice would seem to reflect a certain historicist nostalgia for the "original" materials and feel of the objects in the sixties; on another, it cheerfully flouts the cult of the original by substituting mere copies that will certainly not be fabricated by the hand of the artist, negating the world with his Skilsaw. The materiality, visual presence, and autographic identity of the objects is not unimportant, but it is not everything. Of equal importance is their mobility, reproducibility, and textual/pictorial/legal identity in draw-

31. Plato, *Republic,* Book VII:8, translated by Paul Shorey (Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 1935), p. 159.

32. "Notes on Sculpture," in Battcock, p. 233. See also Fried on the question of scale in relation to the human body, "Art and Objecthood," in Battcock, pp. 128–29.

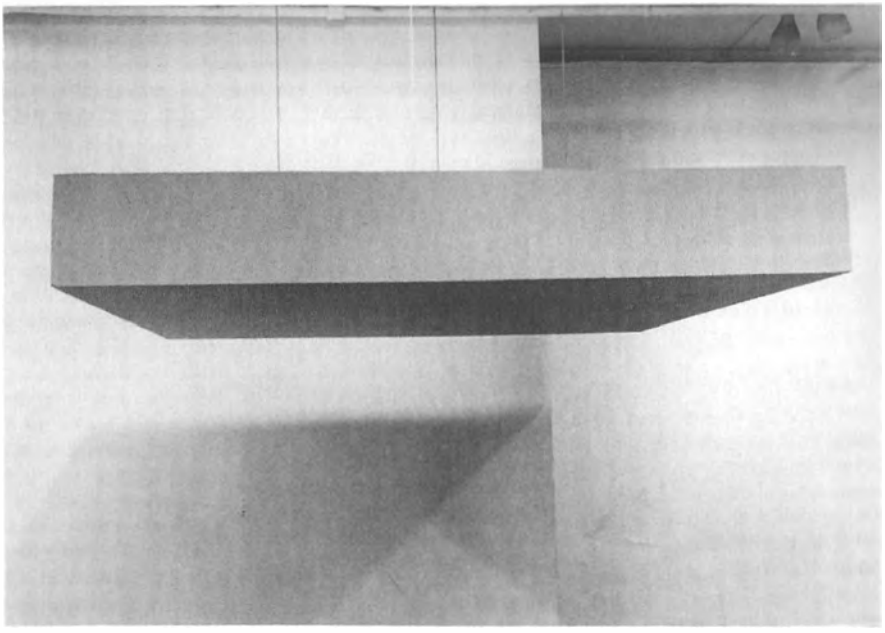


40. Robert Morris, *"Slab,"* 1963.

ings, specifications, and considerations of "intellectual property."[33] The objects themselves, as Morris put it in "Notes on Sculpture," are "important, but perhaps not quite so self-important" as traditional *objets d'art*.

An early and (apparently) simple example may help to clarify these issues. The work called *SLAB* (figures 40 and 41) presents at least three disjunctive identities: (1) it is a literal object, a hollow

33. The "existence" of numerous minimalist works as nothing more than folders full of documents, "blueprints or certificates that confer title to conceptual items," makes them especially problematic for critics who remain fixed on the notion that a work of art is nothing if it is not a material object. See John Richardson's attack on the Guggenheim for overinvesting in this sort of paper currency, "Go Go Guggenheim," in *The New York Review of Books*, 16 July 1992, p. 19.



41. Robert Morris, *"Slab (Cloud),"* 1963.

square plywood box painted gray, 8 by 8 feet wide by 8 inches high; (2) it is an *image* of a slab, a hollow, painted simulacrum whose look and label suggests gray stony solidity, not hollowness; (3) it is a work of art with a title, a provenance, a set of labels and descriptive terms for its materials, dimensions, construction and placement, open to any number of refabrications and language games (traditional responses to form, beauty, and emotional association; the game of artspeak and historical labeling; the game of philosophical meditation on the relation of objects, images, and words). *SLAB* is public in the sense that it is open to all these language games (and others as well). Or, more precisely, it is like a door into a public sphere, one that can be left closed and labeled with a look (like a restroom), or opened into a philosophical gaze and inquiry that may have no determinate outcome, no systematic payoff.[34]

34. I am using the term "public sphere" in the sense made familiar by the critical tradition associated with Jurgen Habermas, particularly his historical study of publicity, *The Structural Transformation of the Public Sphere* (1962), translated by Thomas Burger (Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 1989). The term

Read as a text rather than a label the word "SLAB" is the key that opens the object as a case of philosophical provocation. In particular, it opens the object to reflection on one of the most ancient and durable theories of the relation between language and objects, the theory that language itself is a system of labels, that

> individual words in language name objects—sentences are combinations of such names.—In this picture of language we find the roots of the following idea: Every word has a meaning. This meaning is correlated with the word. It is the object for which the word stands.[35]

This "picture of language" is so ancient and pervasive that it hardly needs the authority of Wittgenstein (or St. Augustine, to whom Wittgenstein attributes it) to be a public commonplace. What "SLAB" does, however, is to materialize this picture, to stage it for public reflection. Morris is following Wittgenstein's instructions to "imagine a language for which the description given by Augustine is right," a scene that turns out to be something like an exhibition of minimalist sculpture being put to use or employed as props to a performance.[36] In Wittgenstein's language game, the minimal objects are imagined as functional elements in a practical activity:

> The language is meant to serve for communication between a builder A and an assistant B. A is building with build-stones; there are blocks, pillars, slabs and beams. B has to pass the stones, and that in the order in which A needs them. For this purpose they use a language consisting of the words "block," "pillar," "slab," "beam." A calls them out;—B brings the stone which he has learnt to bring at such-and-such a call.—Conceive this as a complete primitive language.[37]

Wittgenstein then proceeds to demonstrate that the Augustinian model of the word as name or label for an object is radically incom-

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is not to be confused with the notion of "public art" in its legal or bureaucratic sense. For more on this subject, see *Art and the Public Sphere*, edited by W. J. T. Mitchell (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1992).

35. Ludwig Wittgenstein, *Philosophical Investigations* (1953), translated by G. E. M. Anscombe (New York: Blackwell, 1958), p. 2.

36. The importance of Wittgenstein's philosophy to Morris's art would require a separate study in its own right and would probably take its key from the remarkable series of drawings connected with texts from the *Philosophical Investigations* that Morris executed in 1990.

37. Wittgenstein, *Philosophical Investigations*, p. 3.

plete and that even in a primitive scene like the one he has imagined, the words do a great deal more than name or label the objects. They function in a "language game," one in which the meanings of words are not given by the objects they designate, but by their practical use in a form of life. "SLAB" signifies, not just the object, but something like "bring me a slab." It is a token in a system of exchange, a command, an index of a social relationship: "is the call 'Slab!' . . . a sentence or a word?—If a word, surely it has not the same meaning as the likesounding word of our ordinary language. But if a sentence, it is surely not the elliptical sentence: 'Slab!' of our language."[38]

Wittgenstein's language game turns "SLAB" from a label into an imperative declaration in a form of life we might call "work" (specifically, the social division of labor between a master-builder and his workers). Morris's *SLAB* is an invitation to transform a curatorial label into a perceptual and intellectual form of public work. The "work," therefore, does not encrypt its skill, time, and effort in the traditional model of the "case" whose inside/outside structure unites the "work of art" with the commodity fetish as a container of hidden value and meaning—what Marx called "congealed labor power" and Freud diagnosed as the fetishism of objects concealing the labor of the unconscious.[39] The objects are better described in the terms of Freud's "uncanny," that is, as "cases" that are simultaneously strange and familiar.[40] We do not stand in fixated admiration of Morris's "work" (either his object, or its significance as a trace of his skill, time, and labor), but find ourselves placed in relation to the object as a co-worker, a potential collaborator. The work (both the object and its making) are disseminated, made exoteric, public, even "broadcast"

38. Ibid., p. 8.

39. See my discussion of the parallel between the romantic conception of the work of art and Marx's concept of the commodity fetish in *Iconology*, chapter six. Fried's remarks on the "hollowness of most literalist work . . . as though the work in question has an inner, even secret life," are useful here, though I think insufficiently *literal*. The hollowness of Morris's objects is, in my view, an index of their insistence that they have "nothing to hide," and (as Cage might have said) "they are hiding it." This antihermeneutic openness about the hidden interior, the mockery of the sealed, hermetic "case," is the precise phenomenological basis for Morris's effort to produce objects that have the ability to activate a public sphere.

40. See Freud's essay, "The 'Uncanny,'" (1919), in *The Complete Psychological Works of Sigmund Freud*, edited by James Strachey (London: Hogarth Press, 1955), vol. 17, pp. 219–52.

(in the case of the *Box with the Sound of Its Own Making*). This is not "self-reference" to the artist's ego, his autobiography, or even his objectified work, but a de-crypting of the hidden "creative process" that parodies the cult of secrecy associated with romantic expressivist creation and the associated production of cult objects.

Morris's *SLAB* (as word, image, or object) does not tell us what to do: its grammatical mood is interrogative, not imperative. It invites the contemplation of a simple, primitive object in relation to a straightforwardly unambiguous label, the Augustinian model of the relation between words and things, language and the world. This work can be invisible, effortless, and reassuring: there is the object, there is the label, perfectly coordinated, end of story. But the slightest hesitation opens the beholder to a labyrinth of knots. If "SLAB" is an expression in a language game, should we translate it as "This is a slab"? or as "This is 'SLAB'"? Is "SLAB" a proper name or a generic label? Is it to be written as *SLAB* or "SLAB"? Is the object it refers to a type or a token, a unique individual work or a concept to be replicated in an indefinite series of objects? Is this object (whether type or token) really "simple," and are "simples" what names really designate?[41]

> But what are the simple constituent parts of which reality is composed?—What are the simple constituent parts of a chair?—The bits of wood of which it is made? Or the molecules, or the atoms?—"Simple" means: not composite. And here the point is: in what sense 'composite'? It makes no sense at all to speak absolutely of the simple parts of a chair'. (*Philosophical Investigations*, p. 21)

The rejection of "composite" objects, the construction of a sculpture without "syntax," internal relations of parts, in favor of simple elementary forms is generally taken to be the central program of minimalism. But the real point of this program is not to reify a notion of the absolutely simple, but to explore the complexity and compositeness of the simple, to crack the atomic structure of both common sense and rational positivism.[42] Perhaps we should translate the simple

41. Richard Wollheim's classic essay, "Minimal Art," was the first, I believe, to see the fruitfulness of the type-token distinction for the description of minimalist objects. See his essay in Battcock, pp. 387–99.

42. Wittgenstein's remarks on the "simple" and the "composite" must also be understood as attempts to shatter the atomic concept of the "simple" associated with his own earlier work in the *Tractatus* and with the work of Bertrand Russell and the logical positivists.

word "SLAB," then, as a Wittgensteinian imperative like "look at this slab and say the word aloud or to yourself"; or a Wittgensteinian question: "How do you see this object? What do you see it *as*? What does the name have to do with what you see?" In either case, the "translation" of the label is clearly not the end of the process, the solution to a puzzle or allegory. It is only the opening move in a language game that has no determinate outcome. (John Cage went to the first show where *SLAB* was exhibited and reported that he didn't see any works of art in the gallery, just a slab on the floor.) Wittgenstein urges us not to be troubled by the simple, primitive, and incomplete character of these kinds of games:

> If you want to say that this shows them to be incomplete, ask yourself whether our language is complete;—whether it was so before the symbolism of chemistry and the notation of the infinitesimal calculus were incorporated in it; for these are, so to speak, suburbs of our language. (And how many houses or streets does it take before a town begins to be a town?) Our language can be seen as an ancient city; a maze of little streets and squares, of old and new houses, and of houses with additions from various periods; and this surrounded by a multitude of new boroughs with straight regular streets and uniform houses. (*Philosophical Investigations*, p. 8)

Are Morris's minimal objects better seen as the postmodern suburbs of the language game of art or as primitive building blocks deployed in its oldest districts, provocatives to the ancient questions about words, images, and objects posed by Plato and Augustine? This question might also be thought of as a translation of what it means to say "SLAB?" in the presence of this object.

In retrospect, then, the attempts to divide the work of Morris and the minimalists from traditional forms of art with categories like "literalness" and "figurality" and "objecthood" versus "artifice" begin to look more like temporary rhetorical strategies than durable categories. As so often in the history of art, the new is defined as a negation of the old, and both the acceptance and the refusal of the new are expressed in exactly the same terms, with the valences of value reversed. Both the indictment of minimalism (chiefly by Michael Fried in "Art and Objecthood") and its canonization by defenders of the American avant-garde in the sixties are conducted in the language of absolute breaks with the past, undialectical negations of a reified "tradition." This is not to say that there was nothing new, original, or transgressive about minimalism, but that the terms in which its newness might best be articulated are still open to inquiry and are

not to be settled by a merely historicist recapitulation of the debates of the sixties and the "verdict of history." The objects themselves are now in a new situation, awakening to find themselves somewhere near the "end of postmodernism," if that word has any meaning as the designation of a period. Their provocation today cannot be what it was in the sixties, though it cannot be separated from it either. The provocation of "SLAB" carries all the way out to the historical situation of its first production and reception, and its current exhibition in a blockbuster show, where (one hopes) it will continue to burst various kinds of mental blocks. (Another kind of language game that might be played with "SLAB" and its brethren would reflect on its position within the history of sculpture, the relation between machine and handmade objects, and the importance of the base. In a very real sense, Morris is simply asking us to look at the foundations of sculpture *as* sculpture: the plinth or pedestal—which is sculpture's equivalent of a frame or support—is itself put on display.)[43] Perhaps, like the monolith of *2001: A Space Odyssey,* Morris's slab is an extraterrestrial teaching machine whose shuttling aspects can now be switched on. Its simplicity, blankness, muteness is inseparable from, yet antithetical to, its eloquence, wit, and complexity. Its rational purity and flaunting of radical renunciation is inseparable from its flirtation with scandal, fraud, and boredom (at least in relation to traditional notions of artistic propriety, authenticity, and interest). Insofar as the label "minimalism" provides a way to stabilize the object, to enframe it ideologically, to deny boredom and demand interest, to defeat skepticism and compel conviction, it dulls the edge of the dialectical image presented by the object, and the brick misses its mark.

> *In the light you seem so small there on the wall and straightforward in your brief rectangularity and nearly prim in your crisp paragraphs. You wish to appear luminous with the innocence of your cogent facts.*

Perhaps the best indication of Morris's desire to keep these objects free of minimalist doctrine, to keep the shuttle in motion, is his insistence on a certain intermediate scale between the private and the public work, the intimate and the monumental. The exhaustion of minimalism came, in his view, when it seemed to have nowhere to go but up and out: "as the radicality of its imagery, contexts or processes

43. See Jack Burnham, *Beyond Modern Sculpture* (New York: Braziller, 1967), chapter one, for a discussion of the foregrounding of the base.

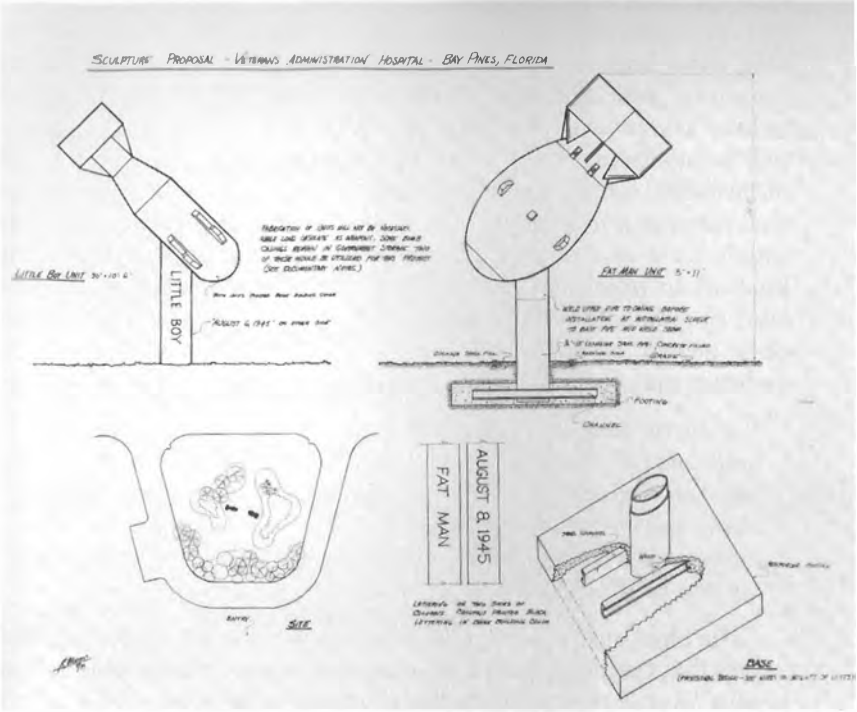
became routine, its options dwindled to a formula: use more space."[44] This is why Morris finds the employment of a minimalist vernacular in the Vietnam Veteran's Memorial so offensive, for the VVM is, in his view, a one-sided, nondialectical appropriation of the vanguard style of the sixties to bandage over a wound that would better be kept open: "Could there ever be a more ingenious act of substituting private grief for public guilt? Has political criminality ever been more effectively repressed than by this weeping wound to the will of the critical? Has there ever been a more svelte Minimal mask placed over governmental culpability?"[45]

Morris's own work has, in general, been devoted to procedures of unmasking, which means of course that it has to both construct and remove various kinds of masks—the labels affixed to objects, the fetishistic character of images and visual pleasure, and (most fundamentally) the mask of the "object itself," the notion of the irreducibly elemental thing. Morris's proposed sculptural tribute to veterans of World War II was a piece of ready-made minimalism, the casings of the atomic bombs dropped on Japan to be installed in the plaza of a Florida VA hospital (figure 42). The proposal was doubly decorous in its evocation of tradition and populist American ideology: what more appropriate war memorial than the weapons of the last war? (cp. the cannon on the courthouse lawn). What more appropriate image for a veterans' *hospital* than the objects which (we are told) "saved American lives" in World War II? There is even a certain "svelteness" in the perfect fit of these hollow casings with the traditional hollowness of minimalist sculpture and Morris's own habit of treating the object as what I have called a "case" rather than an example or illustration. But these cases/casings offered the sort of mask that slipped off all too easily to reveal the merry wink and the death's head grin beneath to representatives of a "public" that wants its memorials to erase guilt and historical memory. *Bomb Sculpture* remains in the archive of "rejected proposals," perhaps as a time bomb waiting to go off.

Morris's early minimalist pieces may now be, in the space of a retrospective, bombs that have already gone off or that have been

44. Robert Morris, "American Quartet," p. 96. On the question of scale, see also "Notes on Sculpture," and Fried, footnote 32 above.

45. Denson interview, forthcoming *Critical Inquiry*. My own view is that the Vietnam Veterans' Memorial succeeds precisely because it keeps the wound open and enables national mourning as well as private grief and public amnesia. See chapter 12 for more discussion.



42. Robert Morris, *Bomb Sculpture Proposal* (artist's archives, Guggenheim Museum).

defused by the labels of canonization and art historical explanation. Once one "gets the concept" of *SLAB* or *BEAM,* we must ask, what need is there to actually *look* at the pieces? Hasn't their material and visual presence been made superfluous by the welter of discourse that surrounds them? Don't we already know, as a staple of everyday common sense, that simple polyhedrons take on different appearances from different angles? Why do we have to look at *these* constructions to test or confirm that knowledge? What might we learn by actually beholding *Box with the Sound of Its Own Making* that isn't already contained in its label and what might be inferred from it? We can certainly understand this object's parodying of the expressionist "action-painting" aesthetic without ever actually seeing it.

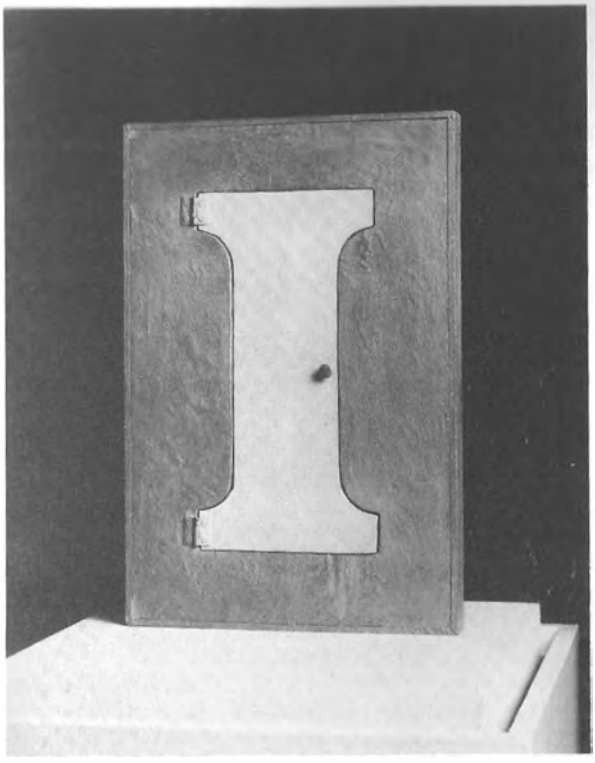
The occasion of a retrospective is, in Morris's case, a thoroughly experimental event, for it cannot know the answers to these questions beforehand. Insofar as the blockbuster show has become a mass cul-

tural spectacle in recent years, an occasion for rapid consumption of vast quantities of visual pleasure, these objects will not feel comfortable, either with themselves or their beholders. What sort of "Morris souvenirs" will make it to the museum store? What's to see? What's to like? The audience has to do all the work. And what sort of perceptual or intellectual work can it be expected to do, trooping through in busloads, listening to taped commentaries, swimming toward the wall labels as if they were so many life preservers? Morris's work may simply serve as a reminder of the austere elitism that divides certain kinds of art from mass culture. As a "historical" figure defined by the label of minimalism, he represents an aspect of the sixties that many of us missed, bedazzled by Pop and Op and neoexpressionism. The audience may feel reproached, the critics defensive.

> *You are the paragon of gentleness as you tell them what to think. You proto and pre-critical patch of writing. You totalitarian text of totalizing. You linguistic grenade. You footnoteless, illustrationless, iconoclastic epitome of generic advertizing. You babbling triumph of the information byte. You, labelless label, starched and washed and swinging that swift and fatal club of "education" to the head.*

The blockbuster show is supposed to provide artistic fetishes and totems that can be inserted into mass circulation—that is, objects that acquire "aura" through their incarceration in the gulag of the artist's or beholder's autobiography (the source of fetishistic "intimacy") or through their monumentalization as the sacred totems of mass culture. Morris's work consistently steers between these alternatives, seeking the "delicate situation" of the philosophical object, a dialectical imagetext that is materialized in a specific constructed thing, with a relation to specific human bodies in a particular situation. This delicate situation is also something like a "public sphere," in the sense of an open, relatively uncoerced speech situation. The only way I know of conveying this sense of Morris's openness is to dwell on a few specific, perhaps typical objects in a relatively common language (I've suggested that Wittgenstein's vocabulary and his willingness to pause over the obvious as an appropriate, though by no means exclusive, model).

I-Box (figures 43 and 44), for instance, activates a kind of infinite labyrinthine circuit among the elementary questions: what is an image? what is a word? what is an object? What sort of creature weaves its world, and its model for itself, out of this specific assemblage: a box with a door shaped like the letter "I"; a photographic image of the maker of the box naked behind the door? The first gesture of the

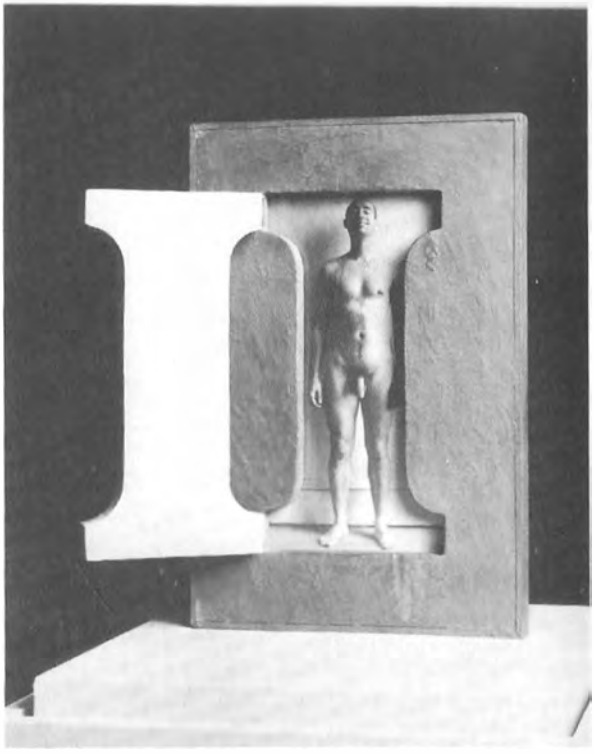


43. Robert Morris, *I-Box*, (closed), 1962. Plywood cabinet, sculptmetal, photograph, 19 × 13¼ × 1⅜". Collection of Leo Castelli.

opened box is to flaunt the impasse of the short-circuit, the joke that is too easy and obvious, the puzzle that is solved without effort, as easy as opening a single door. Like Magritte's "This Is Not a Pipe," it invites us to say, "of course" or "so what?" and move on. Magritte's pipe is only an image, not an object. The I-Box is even simpler. It doesn't even offer a paradoxical gesture like Magritte's "contradiction" between the words and the image. Morris's image of himself naked is unequivocally labeled by the word "I." Word and image are apparently redundant, capturing the self in a double cipher.[46] As David Antin says, "You don't know anything you didn't know before. . . . Everything that is revealed is concealed."[47] But the I-Box is also

46. See Michel Foucault, *This Is Not a Pipe* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1982), chapter 2 on the "calligram" as "double cipher."

47. David Antin, in *ArtNews* 65:2 (April 1966).



44. Robert Morris, *I-Box*, (open).

like Magritte's pipe in insinuating a hesitation: is there not something more?

The answer, of course, is that there is as much more as an observer is willing to invest. If one takes *I-Box* as a *case* for meditation on the fundamental elements it isolates for attention (not merely as an example to be labeled "artistic self-reference"), one risks being lost in a labyrinth of questions. What is the word "I" that it makes sense used in this way? What sense does it make in this case? Does it actually *refer* to something? To the photographic image of Morris, or to the body to which the image refers, or to the box in which it serves as a door and a proper name? If it is a label, to what does it apply? What model of the relation between words, images, and objects does this little assemblage construct?

We might begin by interrogating the "I" of the I-Box, noting that the equivocal character of its reference (to the artist, the artist's image, the box) straightforwardly illustrates the impossibility of fixing the

reference of "I." The "I" has no firmer relation to the invisible "self" or visible body of the artist than it does to the box or to the material shape of an I-Beam. It is revealed as what linguists call a "shifter," an indexical sign whose referent can only be determined with respect to the relation of interlocutors in a specific speech situation (thus the first person designates the speaker, the second person the listener or addressee).[48] Like the words "here" and "now" its meaning shifts with time and the flow of discourse, the give and take of conversation. The word "I," in short, is like a door, swinging on the hinge of dialogue, now open to use by anyone, now closed by someone's appropriation of it to themselves. When the door of the I-Box is closed, its reference is open, unfixed; when the door is open, its reference closes in on and enframes the image of the artist.

Is the I-Box merely an example or illustration of a linguistic commonplace then? Or does its materiality and visual presence make it a *case* of self-reference, a kind of metapicture of a whole language game?[49] A better question might be: What kinds of mind-language-perception games can be played with this object? Four immediately suggest themselves: (1) a fort-da game of concealment and revelation of a "self," a peek-a-boo game as simple as the opening and shutting of an "I/Eye," a shuttling between privacy and publicity, the secret and the disclosure—one which seems to show everything (the naked photographic truth) and nothing (the empty verbal sign) in very rapid succession; (2) a game of allusions to genres and prototypes within the media of painting, sculpture, and photography—the linkages of this object with self-portraiture, pornography and scandal; with surveillance (this looks like a police photo); with the encrypting of sacred icons, and fetishes in protective niches, arks, tabernacles, or casements—in this case wood encased in gray metal; with the calligraphic tradition of the letter as work of art, the historiated initial, fusing the body with the verbal sign of what hides inside the body—a self that can say "I," inside a body enframed as the written character "I";[50] (3) a game of metaphors, analogies for the way we think of the self and the body as an inside-outside structure with the senses (especially

48. "Shifter" is Roman Jakobson's term. See the entry on "Deictics" in Oswald Ducrot and Tzvetan Todorov, *Encyclopedic Dictionary of the Sciences of Language,* translated by Catherine Porter (Baltimore, MD: Johns Hopkins University Press, 1979), p. 252.

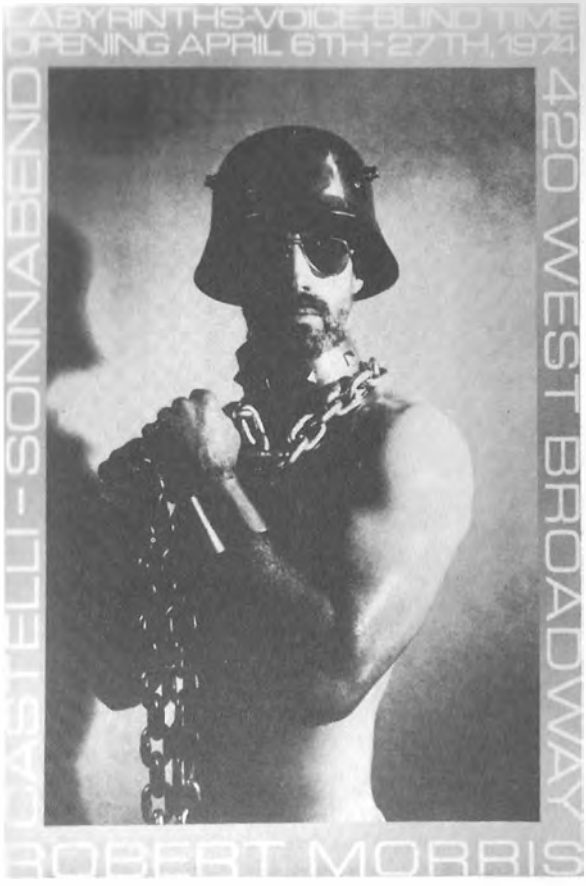
49. For more on this concept, see my essay, "Metapictures," chapter 2 of this volume.

50. See the section of chapter 4 on "Human Letters."

the eye) conceived as apertures or thresholds like windows and doors; the relation of visual and verbal signs, showing and speaking, seeing and reading, to a self that speaks and writes versus the self that displays itself and looks back; (4) a game of "signifying," in which a whole set of pieties about art and the self (and the selves of artists) are mocked and parodied: the fetishism of the art object as an effluence of its divine creator is laid bare, the tabernacle is opened and desecrated. *I-Box* mocks a form of life in which we talk of the self as an invisible presence concealed behind an opaque surface, inside a hollow case or body. Wittgenstein argued that "the human body is the best picture of the human soul." Morris literalizes this claim, opening the case to show us that inside there is nothing but another outside. The label on the surface conceals nothing but another surface to trap the look.

What does it mean that this inner surface is that of a naked male body, displaying its manhood with a facial expression that can only be described as "cocky"? How would it change the meaning of the I-Box if it revealed a naked female body? A full consideration of these questions would take us into a whole new essay on the language games of gender as an intersection of body, image, and label in Morris's art. One might begin the inquiry by noting that most of Morris's works seem designed to neutralize all traces of autobiography and personal identity, to treat the sexually labeled body of both the artist and the beholder as a theatrical role or a site of experimentation. And yet Morris's work could hardly be described as "gender-neutral," insofar as the contingent fact of his own gender and the historical gendering of the artistic role are irreducible material and cultural givens, like the materials of wood, photographic paper, and sculpt-metal.[51] Certainly Morris's "cockiness" in the I-Box can be read as a parodic mockery of the phallic male genius that had become institutionalized by abstract expressionism, just as his *SLAB* mocks the subordination of the sculptural support to the phallic verticality of the statue. (Compare, in this regard, the scandalous portrait of Morris in a fascist sado-masochistic get-up in the poster for the Castelli-Sonnabend Gallery exhibition of 1974 [figure 45] and his performance piece, *Site,* which stages Carolee Schneemann as Manet's Olympia,

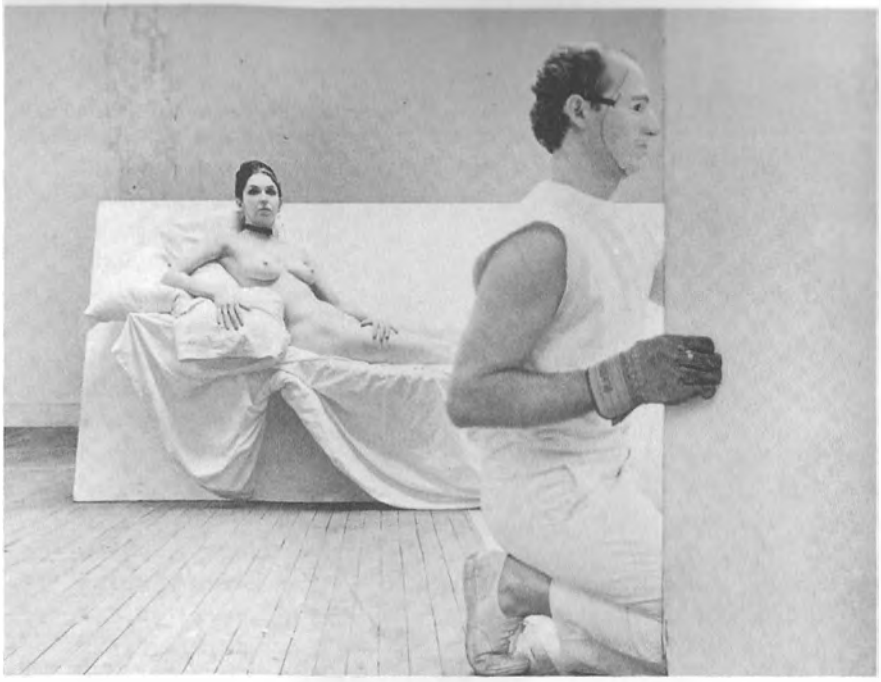
51. In this context I must disagree with Hal Foster's suggestion that "the minimalist delineation of perception . . . is somehow before or outside history, language, sexuality power—that the perceiver is not a sexed body, that the gallery or museum is not an ideological apparatus" ("The Crux of Minimalism," in *Individuals* [Los Angeles Museum of Contemporary Art, 1986], p. 172).



45. Robert Morris, Poster for Castelli-Sonnabend Gallery Exhibition, 6–27 April 1974.

with Morris playing the role of minimalist stagehand [figure 46]). Along with Cage, Rauschenberg, Johns, and the emergent American avant-garde of the sixties, Morris seems consistently to undermine the notion of a foundational identity in gender and to treat sexual categories as labels that circulate in the exchanges of bodies, images, and discourses.[52]

52. See Caroline Jones's discussion of the reaction by the Cage generation against the macho cult of abstract expressionism in her essay, "Finishing School: John Cage and the Abstract Expressionist Ego," *Critical Inquiry* 19:4 (Summer 1993): 628–65.



46. Robert Morris and Carolee Schneemann performing in Morris's *Site*, May 1965. Photograph by Hans Namuth, 1965; © Hans Namuth 1991.

In the fall of 1990, Robert Morris had a nightmare about a wall label. His account of this nightmare has been a counterpoint to my own attempt to write about his work without relying on labels. I don't offer the text of this dream as the unique key to Morris's meanings, nor the occasion for any psychoanalytic decoding of his work. In fact, I'm very skeptical about the authority of this dream. It strikes me as flagrantly literary, with its echoes of Poe's "Tell-Tale Heart" and the scene of Eve's temptation in *Paradise Lost* ("it babbled in my ear"). It is the sort of dream one makes up (perhaps unconsciously) for one's analyst. The simultaneously phallic and "labial" images associated with the label (it "entwines" itself, "slithers and coils in the shadows," and "seems to pulsate" like an uncontrollable erection that Morris must "get a grip on"; yet it is devouring, loquacious, "prim" and "chaste") suggest a highly conscious fantasy about the image of a Medusalike phallic female whose "aim is nothing less than dominating my images there on the wall." The particular images that Morris refers to in this dream are the encaustic paintings on aluminum

47. Robert Morris, *Prohibition's End or the Death of Dutch Schulz*, 1989. Encaustic on aluminum panel. Collection of Leo Castelli.

panels he executed in the spring and summer of 1990 and first exhibited at the Corcoran Gallery in December of that year (figures 47 and 48) Morris suspects that the label's "linguistic hysteria" will "erode the encaustic from my panels."

This series of paintings does not appear in the Guggenheim retrospective. That is regrettable, if only because these paintings, produced under the foreshadowing prospect of a major retrospective, are themselves a retrospective not only of Morris's own artistic career, but of the fortunes of art and language, the look and the label, in what Arthur Danto has called this "Post-Historical Period of Art."[53] The paintings are very much of a piece with the Gothic phantasmagoria

53. Arthur Danto, *Beyond the Brillo Box* (New York: Farrar, Straus, Giroux, 1992), p. 10. I hope it is clear, however, that I regard any notion of the present as having gone "beyond history" as quite premature.

48. Robert Morris, *Improvident/Decisive/Determined/Lazy . . .*, 1990. Encaustic on aluminum panel 143¼ × 94¼". Collection of Leo Castelli.

of Morris's nightmare, employing gloomy, lurid colors and iconography that evoke a range of art historical reference from Mantegna's *Dead Christ* to Holbein's anamorphic skull to Goya's black paintings. Most notable, however, are the texts in stenciled lettering on the surface of the images. Like the wall labels of Morris's dream, they are "elusive as [they] gleam there in the dark with its Poe-like atmospherics of linguistic threat and verbal iconoclasm." Morris's command to "show yourself in the light, wall label" has not been heeded, even in his own paintings. The letters swim in and out of legible focus, refusing either to disappear or to come into the light to explain the images.

We can, of course, label the labels on these paintings as references

(along with the encaustic medium) to Jasper Johns's employment of stenciled lettering in his early paintings, just as we can label virtually every image in the paintings as an allusion to some art historical or popular source. My impression is that hunting down these allusions is not the point, or at least not the *immediate* point of these works. The point is rather more simple and superficial and can be grasped just by recognizing that these paintings are networks of allusion to previous art and popular imagery without necessarily being able to identify every iconographic and stylistic reference. In conversations about these pieces at the time of their production, it became clear to me that Morris was indifferent to the identification of sources as keys to meaning and that he had forgotten many of them himself. The immediate subject of the paintings is the process of artistic retrospection itself, more specifically the relation between image, object, and label in memory. The first thing one has to note about Morris's labels is that many are almost unreadable; the second is that they are almost uninterpretable. The labels do not label the images; they only look like labels, functioning more like stray bits of associative language that (like the elusive pictorial allusions) flicker in and out of verbal recognition. It's impossible even to label the labels as some single generic type of verbal expression: they include proverbial sayings reminiscent of Goya's enigmatic *Caprichos* ("Rotten With Criticism"; "Memory is Hunger"), Nietzschean echoes ("Slave Morality"), fragmentary descriptions of states of being ("Inability to Endure or Deny the World"), associative puns ("Horde/Hoard/Whored"), and fantastic verbal collages like the conflation of the transcript of Dutch Schultz's death ravings with phrases from Derrida in "Prohibition's End," appended as the "text" for a recognizable rendering of Mantegna's *Dead Christ*.

These image-text composites are *nearly* unreadable, but of course we do finally read them; their obscurity invites interpretation, and I have no doubt that future scholars will drag both the images and their labels into the light of art historical analysis. When that is done, however, my hunch is that everything revealed will remain concealed (not that this devalues the process of revelation). Take as an instance one of the more transparent compositions in this series, the magnificent tribute to Jackson Pollock labeled *Monument Dead Monument/ Rush Life Rush* (figure 49). This painting is based on the famous Hans Namuth photograph of Jackson Pollock at work (figure 50). Morris has doubled the Namuth image and assembled it as a vertical diptych, the upper and lower panels appearing as inverted, mirror images of one another. The lower (upside down) panel is more clearly

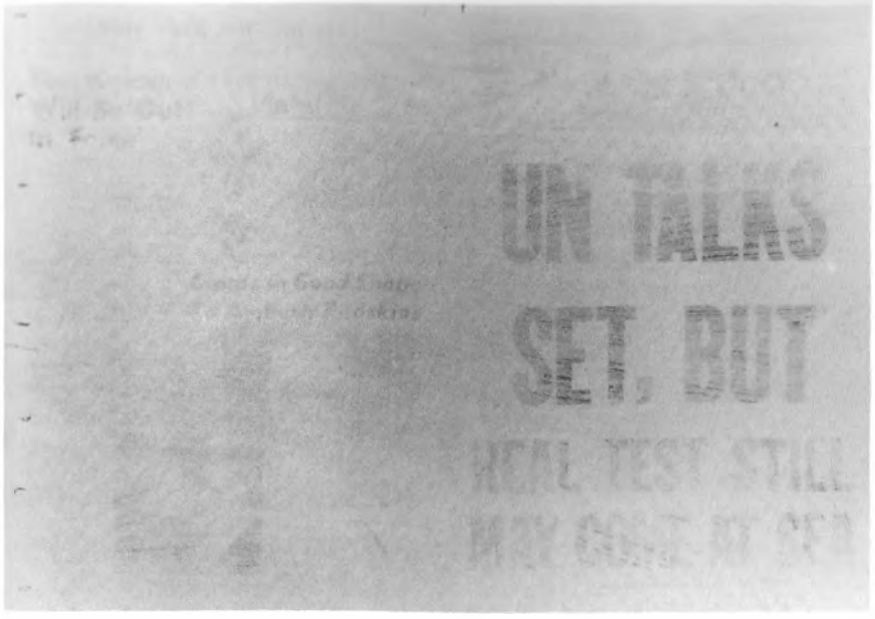
49. Robert Morris, *Monument Dead Monument/Rush Life Rush*. Encaustic on aluminum panel. Collection of Leo Castelli.

50. Hans Namuth, photograph of Jackson Pollock at work. Photograph © Hans Namuth 1991.

delineated, the upper having been subjected to heat which caused the encaustic to melt on the aluminum support, blurring the contours of the image. The mirrorlike, vertical (a)symmetry of the images is matched laterally by the labels that run up and down its margins: on the left, "Monument Dead Monument" ascends; on the right "Rush Life Rush" descends.

What tribute does this painting pay to Jackson Pollock, the man who has been called "the greatest American painter of the twentieth century," the painter whose work was a decisive influence on Morris's earliest work and the epitome of the expressionist aesthetic against which early minimalism set its face? A highly equivocal tribute, I would say, one which refers us back to—even re-enacts—the original pouring process of "action painting," the figure of the artist merging with his art, his life rushing out in paint, at the same time it refers us back to the monumentalizing of this process into an artistic dead end—the myth of the macho, expressionist creator whose private fetishes become public totems. Morris's picture is like a hall of verbal-visual mirrors in which the reflected object is the genesis, production, reproduction, and consumption of art itself. The asymmetry of this artistic life-cycle, its tendency to "advance" by processes of devolution and negation, remembering, forgetting, and disremembering, is articulated verbally by the labels, visually by the dissolving reflection that surmounts the more focused "original," and materially by the processes enacted in the object. If Pollock showed us that the primary material fact about paint is that it pours, Morris shows us that the primary material fact about wax (encaustic) is that it melts. What we are left with is not merely a tribute to Pollock's rushing life, nor a sardonic commentary on his subsequent monumentalization, but a vision of the birth and death of a monument, its vital origin, its fixing as a memorable icon, and its melting down in forgetfulness and chaotic oblivion.

These retrospective paintings look radically different from most of the sculptural productions that will enjoy pride of place in the Guggenheim retrospective. But their deepest concerns are all of a piece with the earlier work. They share the same concern for investigating the identity of the work of art as a nexus of vision, language, and objecthood. They seek to occupy the same precarious threshold between form and anti-form, between the private fetish and the public totem. Above all, they play the same game of philosophical provocation and psycho-poetic experimentation that has characterized Morris's work from the first. We would not be far wrong in calling them "conversation pieces," occasions for debate on a whole series



51. Robert Morris, *Cuban Missile Crisis*. Gray paint on newsprint. 1963. Artist's collection.

of artistic and nonartistic issues, from the nature of looking at and labeling objects, to the historical character of artistic production, to the institutional history and discourse that makes these conversations possible. On the "issues of the day," whatever they will be in autumn of 1993, these works will be almost inaudible and unreadable, like those gray paintings Morris executed on newspapers covered with headlines about the Cuban Missile Crisis in 1963 (figure 51). On the fundamental questions of what art is for, what it might attempt, and what our relation to it might be, these may be bombs re-fused by popular disrespect, bricks flying in the night toward an unknown destination.

Nine

THE PHOTOGRAPHIC ESSAY: FOUR CASE STUDIES

Three questions:

1. *What is the relation of photography and language?*
2. *Why does it matter what this relation is?*
3. *How are these questions focused in the medium known as the "photographic essay"?*

Three answers:

1. *Photography is and is not a language; language also is and is not a "photography."*
2. *The relation of photography and language is a principal site of struggle for value and power in contemporary representations of reality; it is the place where images and words find and lose their conscience, their aesthetic and ethical identity.*
3. *The photographic essay is the dramatization of these questions in an emergent form of mixed, composite art.*

What follows is an attempt to connect these questions and answers.

Photography and Language

The totality of this relationship is perhaps best indicated by saying that appearances constitute a half-language.
—John Berger, *Another Way of Telling*

The relationship of photography and language admits of two basic descriptions, fundamentally antithetical. The first stresses photography's difference from language, characterizing it as a "message without a code," a purely objective transcript of visual reality.[1] The second

1. The phrase "message without a code" is from Roland Barthes's essay, "The Photographic Message," in *Image/Music/Text*, translated by Stephen Heath (New York: Hill and Wang, 1977), p. 19. I am grateful to David Antin

turns photography into a language, or stresses its absorption by language in actual usage. This latter view is currently in favor with sophisticated commentators on photography. It is getting increasingly hard to find anyone who will defend the view (variously labeled "positivist," "naturalistic," or "superstitious and naive") that photographs have a special causal and structural relationship with the reality that they represent. Perhaps this is due to the dominance of linguistic and semiotic models in the human sciences or to the skepticism, relativism, and conventionalism which dominates the world of advanced literary criticism. Whatever the reason, the dominant view of photography is now the kind articulated by Victor Burgin when he notes that "we rarely see a photograph *in use* which is not accompanied by language" and goes on to claim that the rare exceptions only confirm the domination of photography by language: "even the uncaptioned 'art' photograph," argues Burgin, "is invaded by language in the very moment it is looked at: in memory, in association, snatches of words and images continually intermingle and exchange one for the other."[2] Indeed, Burgin carries his argument well beyond looking at photography to "looking" as such, deriding the "naive idea of purely retinal vision," unaccompanied by language, a view which he associates with "an error of even greater consequence: that ubiquitous belief in 'the visual' as a realm of experience totally separated from, indeed antithetical to, 'the verbal' " (p. 53). Burgin traces "the idea that there are two quite distinct forms of communication, words and images" from the neoplatonic faith in a "divine language of things, richer than the language of words" to Ernst Gombrich's modern defense of the "natural" and "nonconventional" status of the photograph. "Today," concludes Burgin, "such relics are obstructing our view of photography" (p. 70).

What is it that troubles me about this conclusion? It isn't that I disagree with the claim that "language" (in some form) usually enters the experience of viewing photography or of viewing anything else. And it isn't the questioning of a reified distinction between words and images, verbal and visual representation; there seems no doubt that these different media interact with one another at numerous levels in

and Alan Trachtenberg for their many intelligent suggestions and questions about an earlier version of this essay.

2. Victor Burgin, "Seeing Sense," in *The End of Art Theory: Criticism and Post-Modernity* (Atlantic Highlands, NJ: Humanities Press, 1986), p. 51; further page references will be cited in the text.

cognition, consciousness, and communication. What troubles me, I suppose, is the confidence of tone, the assurance that we are able "today" to cast off certain "relics" that have mystified us for over two thousand years in favor of, presumably, a clear, unobstructed view of the matter. I'm especially struck by the figure of the "relic" as an obstructive image in contrast to the unobstructed view, since this is precisely the opposition which has (superstitiously) differentiated photography from more traditional forms of imagery and which formerly differentiated perspectival representation from "pre-scientific" modes of pictorial representation. Burgin's conclusions, in other words, are built upon a figurative opposition ("today/yesterday"; "clear view/obstructive relic") he has already dismissed as erroneous in its application to photography and vision. This return of an inconvenient figure suggests, at a minimum, that the relics are not quite so easily disposed of.

I'm also troubled by Burgin's confidence that "our view" can so easily be cleared up. Who is the "we" that has this "view"? It is implicitly divided between those who have overcome their superstitions about photography and those naifs who have not. "Our view" of photography is, in other words, far from homogeneous, but is the site of a struggle between the enlightened and the superstitious, moderns and ancients, perhaps even "moderns" and "postmoderns." Symptoms of this struggle emerge in Burgin's rhetoric when he speaks of the photograph as "invaded by language" (p. 51); what he seems not to consider is that this invasion might well provoke a resistance or that there might be some value at stake in such a resistance, some real motive for a defence of the nonlinguistic character of the photograph. Burgin seems content to affirm the "fluidity" (p. 52) of the relation between photography and language and to treat photography as "a complex of exchanges between the verbal and the visual" (p. 58).

But why should we suppose this model of free and fluid "exchanges" between photography and language to be true or desirable? How do we account for the stubbornness of the naive, superstitious view of photography? What could possibly motivate the persistence in erroneous beliefs about the radical difference between images and words and the special status of photography? Are these mistaken beliefs simply conceptual errors, like mistakes in arithmetic? Or are they more on the order of ideological beliefs, convictions that resist change by ordinary means of persuasion and demonstration? What if it were the case that the "relics" which "obstruct" our view of photography also *constitute* that view? What if the only adequate formula-

tion of the relation of photography and language was a paradox: photography both is and is not a language?

This, I take it, is what lies at the heart of what Roland Barthes calls "the photographic paradox," "the co-existence of two messages, the one without a code (the photographic analogue), the other with a code (the 'art', or the treatment, or the 'writing', or the rhetoric of the photograph)."[3] Barthes works through a number of strategies to clarify and rationalize this paradox. The most familiar is the division of the photographic "message" into "denotation" and "connotation," the former associated with the "mythical," nonverbal status of the photograph "in the perfection and plenitude of its analogy," the latter with the readability and textuality of the photograph. Barthes sometimes writes as if he believes that this division of the photographic message into "planes" or "levels" may solve the paradox:

> how, then, can the photograph be at once 'objective' and 'invested,' natural and cultural? It is through an understanding of the mode of imbrication of denoted and connoted messages that it may one day be possible to reply to that question. (p. 20)

But his more characteristic gesture is to reject easy answers predicated on a model of "free exchange" of verbal and visual messages, connoted or denoted "levels": "structurally," he notes, "the paradox is clearly not the collusion of a denoted message and a connoted message . . . it is that the connoted (or coded) message develops on the basis of a message *without a code*" (p. 19). To put the matter more fully: one connotation always present in the photograph is that it is a pure denotation; that is simply what it means to recognize it as a photograph rather than some other sort of image. Conversely, the denotation of a photograph, what we take it to represent, is never free from what we take it to mean. The simplest snapshot of a bride and groom at a wedding is an inextricably woven network of denotation and connotation: we cannot divide it into "levels" which distinguish it as a "pure" reference to John and Mary, or a man and a woman, as opposed to its "connotations" of festivity. Connotation goes all the way down to roots of the photograph, to the motives for its production, to the selection of its subject matter, to the choice of angles and lighting. Similarly, "pure denotation" reaches all the way up to the most textually "readable" features of the photograph: the photograph is "read" *as if it were* the trace of an event, a "relic" of an occasion

3. Roland Barthes, "The Photographic Message," in *Image/Music/Text*, p. 19; further page references will be cited in the text.

as laden with aura and mystery as the bride's garter or her fading bouquet. The distinction between connotation and denotation does not resolve the paradox of photography; it only allows us to restate it more fully.

Barthes emphasizes this point when he suggests that the "structural paradox" of photography "coincides with an ethical paradox: when one wants to be 'neutral', 'objective', one strives to copy reality meticulously, as though the analogical were a factor of resistance against the investment of values" (pp. 19–20). The "value" of photography resides precisely in its freedom from "values," just as, in cognitive terms, its principal connotation or "coded" implication is that it is pure denotation, without a code. The persistence of these paradoxes suggests that the "mode of imbrication" or overlapping between photography and language is best understood, not as a structural matter of "levels" or as a fluid exchange, but (to use Barthes's term) as a site of "resistance." This is not to suggest that resistance is always successful or that "collusion" and "exchange" between photography and language is impossible or automatically undesirable. It is to say that the exchanges which seem to make photography just another language, an adjunct or supplement to language, make no sense without an understanding of the resistance they overcome. What we need to explore now is the nature of this resistance and the values which have motivated it.

The Photographic Essay

The immediate instruments are two: the motionless camera and the printed word.

—James Agee, *Let Us Now Praise Famous Men*[4]

The ideal place to study the interaction of photography and language is in that subgenre (or is it a medium within the medium?) of photography known as the "photographic essay." The classic examples of this form (Jacob Riis's *How the Other Half Lives,* Margaret Bourke-White and Erskine Caldwell's *You Have Seen Their Faces)* give us a literal conjunction of photographs and text—usually united by a documentary purpose, often political, journalistic, sometimes scien-

4. James Agee and Walker Evans, *Let Us Now Praise Famous Men* (Originally published, 1939; New York: Houghton Mifflin, 1980), p. xiv; further page references will be cited in the text.

tific (sociology). There is an argument by Eugene Smith that the photographic series or sequence, even without text, can be regarded as a photo-essay,[5] and there are distinguished examples of such works (Robert Frank's *The Americans*).[6] I want to concentrate, however, on the kinds of photographic essays which contain strong textual elements, where the text is most definitely an "invasive" and even domineering element. I also want to focus on the sort of photo-essay whose text is concerned, not just with the subject matter in common between the two media, but with the way in which the media address that subject matter. Early in Jacob Riis's *How the Other Half Lives* he describes an incident in which his flash powder almost set a tenement on fire. This event is not represented in the photographs: what we see, instead, are scenes of tenement squalor in which dazed subjects (who have often been roused from their sleep) are displayed in passive bedazzlement under the harsh illumination of Riis's flash powder (figure 52). Riis's textual anecdote reflects on the scene of production of his images, characterizing and criticizing the photographer's own competence, perhaps even his ethics. We might say that Riis allows his text to subvert his images, call them into question. A better argument would be that the text "enables" the images (and their subjects) to take on a kind of independence and humanity that would be unavailable under an economy of straightforward "exchange" between photographer and writer. The photographs may be "evidence" for propositions quite at odds with the official uses that Riis wants to put them. The beholder, in turn, is presented with an uncomfortable question: is the political, epistemological power of these images (their "shock" value) a justification for the violence that accompanies their production? (Riis worked as a journalist in close collaboration with the police; many of these photos were taken during nighttime raids;

5. See Tom Moran, *The Photo Essay: Paul Fusco and Will McBride*, in the Masters of Contemporary Photography series (Los Angeles, CA: Alskog, Inc., 1974). Eugene Smith's remarks on the genre of the photo-essay were made in conversation with the editors of this book and appear on pages 14–15.

6. Robert Frank, *The Americans* (1st edition, 1959; rev. and enlarged ed., New York: Grossman Publishers, 1969). Frank's book is not entirely free of text, however. All the photographs are accompanied by brief captions, usually a designation of subject, time, or location, and there is an introduction by Jack Kerouac that emphasizes the implicit verbal coding of Frank's photographs: "What a poem this is, what poems can be written about this book of pictures some day by some young new writer . . . " (p. iii).

52. Jacob Riis, *Lodgers in Bayard St. Tenement . . .* Page spread from *How the Other Half Lives* (1890). Photo reproduced courtesy of the Museum of the City of New York.

these are, in a real sense, surveillance photographs; they also had a profound effect on reform efforts in the New York slums.) Riis's joining of an inconvenient, disruptive text foregrounds this dilemma, draws us into it. A resistance arises in the text-photo relation; we move less easily, less quickly from reading to seeing. Admittedly, this resistance is exceptional in Riis, whose general practice is to assume a straightforward exchange of information between text and image. But its emergence even in this relatively homogeneous photo-essay alerts us to its possibility, its effect and motivations.

Another way to state this dilemma is as a tension between the claims of the ethical and the political, the aesthetic and the rhetorical. Photo-essays have been, by and large, the product of progressive, liberal consciences, associated with political reform and leftist causes. But the best of them, I want to suggest, do not treat photography or

language simply as instruments in the service of a cause or an institution. Nor are they content to advertise the fine moral or artistic sensitivities of their producers. The problem is to mediate these disparate claims, to make the instrumentality of both writing and photography and their interactions serve the highest interests of "the cause" by subjecting it to criticism while advancing its banner. Agee distinguishes between the "immediate instruments" of the photo-essay, "the still camera and the printed word," and the "governing instrument—which is also one of the centers of the subject—[which] is individual, anti-authoritative human consciousness" (p. xiv). The production of the photo-essay, the actual labor that goes into it, should not be, in Agee's view, simply an instrumental application of media to politics, ideology, or any other subject matter. The "taking" of human subjects by a photographer (or a writer) is a concrete social encounter, often between a damaged, victimized, and powerless individual and a relatively privileged observer, often acting as the "eye of power," the agent of some social, political, or journalistic institution. The "use" of this person as instrumental subject matter in a code of photographic messages is exactly what links the political aim with the ethical, creating exchanges and resistances at the level of value that do not concern the photographer alone, but which reflect back on the writer's (relatively invisible) relation to the subject as well and on the exchanges between writer and photographer.[7]

One last question about the genre: why should it be called the "photographic *essay*"? Why not the photo novel or lyric or narrative or just the "photo text"? There are, of course, examples of all these forms: Wright Morris has used his photographs to illustrate his fiction; Paul Strand and Nancy Newhall link photographs with lyric poems in *Time in New England;* Jan Baetens has analyzed the emergent French genre of the "photographic novel." What warrant is there for thinking of the "photo-essay" as an especially privileged model for the conjunction of photography and language? One reason is simply the dominance of the essay as the textual form that conventionally accompanies photography in magazines and newspapers. But there are, I think, some more fundamental reasons for a decorum that seems to link the photograph with the essay in the way that history painting was linked to the epic or landscape painting to the lyric poem. The

7. For an excellent account of the way writers address the ethical issues of "approach to the subject" made visible by the photographic apparatus in action, see Carol Schloss, *In Visible Light: Photography and the American Writer: 1840–1940* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1987), p. 11.

first is the presumption of a common referential reality: not "realism" but "reality," nonfictionality, even "scientificity" are the generic connotations that link the essay with the photograph.[8] The second is the intimate fellowship between the informal or personal essay, with its emphasis on a private "point of view," memory, and autobiography, and photography's mythic status as a kind of materialized memory trace imbedded in the context of personal associations and private "perspectives." Third, there is the root sense of the essay as a partial, incomplete "attempt," an effort to get as much of the truth about something into its brief compass as the limits of space and writerly ingenuity will allow. Photographs, similarly, seem necessarily incomplete in their imposition of a frame that can never include everything that was there to be, as we say, "taken." The generic incompleteness of the informal literary essay becomes an especially crucial feature of the photographic essay's relations of image and text. The text of the photo-essay typically discloses a certain reserve or modesty in its claims to "speak for" or interpret the images; like the photograph, it admits its inability to appropriate everything that was there to be taken and tries to let the photographs speak for themselves or "look back" at the viewer.

In the remainder of this essay I want to examine four photo-essays that, in various ways, foreground the dialectic of exchange and resistance between photography and language, the things that make it possible (and sometimes impossible) to "read" the pictures, or to "see" the text illustrated in them. I will limit myself to four main examples: the first, Agee and Evans's *Let Us Now Praise Famous Men,* generally acknowledged as a "classic" (and a modernist) prototype for the genre, will be used mainly to lay out the principles of the form. The other three, exemplifying more recent and perhaps "postmodern" strategies (Roland Barthes's *Camera Lucida,* Malek Alloula's *The Colonial Harem,* and Edward Said and Jean Mohr's *After the Last Sky*), will be analyzed in increasing detail to show the encounter of principles with practice. The basic questions to be addressed with each of these works are the same: what relationship

8. Recall the classic photo-essays based in scientific discourse such as geological surveys (Timothy O'Sullivan, for instance) and sociological studies (the work of Dorothea Lange and Paul Taylor). The modern discipline of art history is inconceivable without the illustrated slide lecture and the photographic reproduction of images. Any discourse that relies on the accurate mechanical reproduction of visual evidence engages with photography at some point.

between photography and writing do they articulate? What tropes of differentiation govern the division of labor between photographer and writer, image and text, the viewer and the reader?

Spy and Counter-spy: Let Us Now Praise Famous Men

> Who are you who will read these words and study these photographs, and through what cause, by what chance and for what purpose, and by what right do you qualify to, and what will you do about it.
>
> —James Agee

The central formal requirements of the photographic essay are memorably expressed in James Agee's introduction to *Let Us Now Praise Famous Men*: "The photographs are not illustrative. They and the text, are coequal, mutually independent, and fully collaborative" (p. xv). These three requirements—equality, independence, and collaboration—are not simply given by putting any text together with any set of photographs, and they are not so easily reconcilable. Independence and collaboration, for instance, are values that may work at cross-purposes, and a "co-equality" of photography and writing is easier to stipulate than it is to achieve or even to imagine. Agee notes, for instance, that "the impotence of the reader's eye" (p. xv) will probably lead to an underestimation of Evans's photographs; it is not hard to imagine a deafness or illiteracy underestimating the text as well—a fate that actually befell *Let Us Now Praise Famous Men* when it reached the editors of *Fortune* magazine, who had commissioned it.[9] Agee's generic requirements are not only imperatives for the producers of an art form that seems highly problematic, they are also prescriptions for a highly alert reader/viewer that may not yet exist, that may in fact have to be created.

It is easy enough to see how *Famous Men* satisfies the requirements of independence and co-equality. The photographs are completely separate, not only from Agee's text, but from any of the most minimal textual features that conventionally accompany a photo-essay: no captions, legends, dates, names, locations, or even numbers are provided to assist a "reading" of the photographs. Even a rela-

9. For a good account of the reception of Agee and Evans's work, see William Stott, *Documentary Expression and Thirties America* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1973), pp. 261–66.

53. Robert Frank, *Parade—Hoboken, New Jersey* (1955–1956), from *The Americans* (1958). Copyright © Robert Frank. Courtesy, Pace/MacGill Gallery, New York.

tively "pure" photographic essay like Robert Frank's *The Americans* provides captions telling the subject and the location. Frank's opening image, for instance, of shadowy figures at the window of a flag-draped building (figure 53), is accompanied by the caption "Parade—Hoboken, New Jersey" which immediately gives us informational location not provided by the photograph and names a subject which it does not represent. Evans allows us no such clues or access to his photographs. If we have studied Agee's text at some length, we may surmise that the opening photograph is of Chester Bowles, and we may think we can identify three different tenant families in Evans's pictures based on their descriptions in Agee's text, but all of these connections must be excavated; none of them are unequivocally given by any "key" that links text to images. The location of Evans's photos at the front of the volume is an even more aggressive declaration of photographic independence. In contrast to the standard practices of interweaving photos with text or placing them in a middle or concluding section where they can appear in the context provided by the text, Evans and Agee force us to confront the photographs without context,

before we have had a chance to see a preface, table of contents, or even a title page. When we do finally reach the contents, we learn that we are already in "Book Two" and that the photographs are the "Book One," which we have already "read."

The "co-equality" of photos and text is, in one sense, a direct consequence of their independence, each medium being given a "book" of its own, each equally free of admixture with the other—Evans providing photos without text, Agee a text without photos. But equality is further suggested by the feeling that Evans's photos really do constitute, in W. Eugene Smith's phrase, an "essay" in their own right.[10] The sequence of Evans's photos does not tell a story but suggests rather a procession of general "topics" epitomized by specific figures—after the anomalous opening figure (figure 54) whose rumpled sport coat suggests a wealth and class somewhat above those of the tenant farmers, a survey of representative figures: Father (figure 55), Mother (figure 56), Bedroom (figure 57), House (figure 58), and Children (Girl-Boy-Girl) of descending ages (figures 59, 60, 61).[11] It is possible to construct a master-narrative if we insist on one. Agee provides one some eighty pages later if we are alert to it: "a man and a woman are drawn together upon a bed and there is a child and there are children" (p. 55). We can even give these figures proper names: George and Annie Mae Gudger, their house, their children. But these text-image "exchanges" are not *given* to us by either the text or the images; if anything, the organization of the volume makes this difficult; it resists the straightforward collaboration of photo and text. And this resistance is not overcome by repeated readings and viewings, as if a secret code linking the photos to the text were there to be deciphered. When all the "proper" names and places are identified, we are reminded that these are fictional names: the Gudgers, Rickettses, and Woodses do not exist by those names. We may feel we "know" them through Evans's images, through Agee's intimate meditations on their lives, but we never do, and we never will.

What is the meaning of this blockage between photo and text? One answer would be to link it with the aesthetics of a Greenbergian

10. Eugene Smith argues that photojournalists tend to work within narrative conventions, producing "picture stories": "that's a form of its own, not an essay" (*The Photo Essay,* p. 15).

11. This "topical" and nonnarrative format persists throughout the sequence of Evans's photos. The photos are divided into three sections, the first concentrating on the Gudgers and Woodses, the second on the Rickettses, and the third on the towns in their neighborhood.

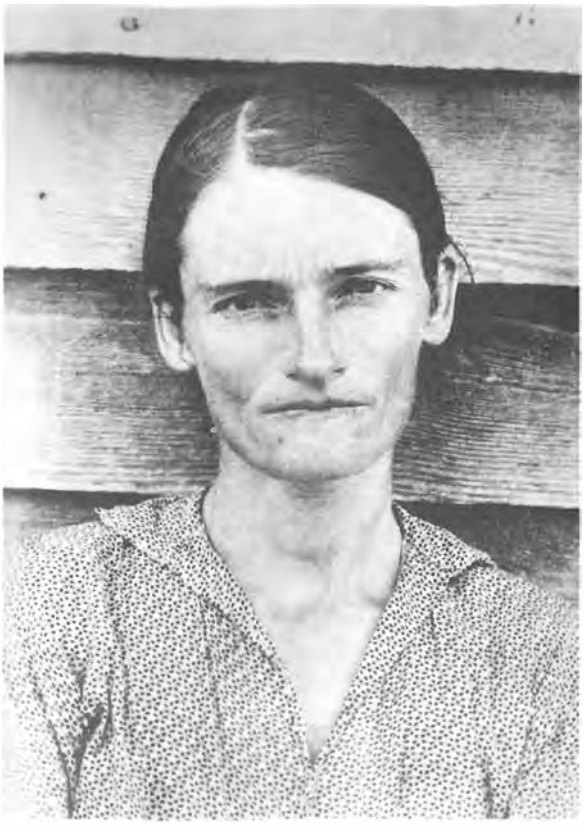
54. Walker Evans, photograph from *Let Us Now Praise Famous Men* (1939) by James Agee and Walker Evans. Photograph courtesy of the Library of Congress.

modernism, a search for the "purity" of each medium, uncontaminated by the mixing of pictorial and verbal codes. Evans's photos are like aggressively untitled abstract paintings, bereft of names, reference, and "literary" elements. They force us back onto the formal and material features of the images in themselves. The portrait of Annie May Gudger (see figure 56), for instance, becomes a purely formal study of flatness and worn, "graven" surfaces: the lines of her face, the weathered grain of the boards, the faded dress, the taut strands of her hair, the gravity of her expression all merge into a visual complex that is hauntingly beautiful and enigmatic. She becomes an

55. Walker Evans, photograph from *Let Us Now Praise Famous Men* (1939) by James Agee and Walker Evans. Photograph courtesy of the Library of Congress.

"icon," arguably the most famous of all the anonymous men and women captured by Evans's camera, a pure aesthetic object, liberated from contingency and circumstance into a space of pure contemplation, the Mona Lisa of the Depression.

There is something deeply disturbing, even disagreeable, about this (unavoidable) aestheticizing response to what after all is a real person in desperately impoverished circumstances. Why should we have a right to look on this woman and find her fatigue, pain, and anxiety beautiful? What gives us the right to look upon her, as if we were God's spies? These questions are, of course, exactly the sorts of hectoring challenges Agee's text constantly confronts us with; they are also the questions that Evans's photos force on us when he shows us the tenant farmers as beautiful, formal studies filled with mystery, dignity, and presence. We cannot feel easy with our aesthetic appreciation of Annie Mae Gudger any more than we can pronounce her true name. Her beauty, like her identity, is held in reserve from us, at a



56. Walker Evans, *Annie Mae Gudger*, photograph from *Let Us Now Praise Famous Men* (1939) by James Agee and Walker Evans. © Copyright, Estate of Walker Evans.

distance: she looks back at us, withholding unreadable secrets. She asks as many questions of us as we of her: "who are you who will read these words and study these photographs?"

The aestheticizing separation of Evans's images from Agee's text is not, then, simply a formal characteristic but an ethical strategy, a way of preventing easy access to the world they represent. I call this an "ethical" strategy because it may well have been counterproductive for any political aims. The collaboration of Erskine Caldwell and Margaret Bourke-White in the representation of tenant farmers provides an instructive comparison. *You Have Seen Their Faces* offers unimpeded exchange between photos and text: Bourke-White's images interweave with Caldwell's essay; each photo is accompanied by a "legend" locating the shot and a "quotation" by the central figure.

57. Walker Evans, photograph from *Let Us Now Praise Famous Men* (1939) by James Agee and Walker Evans. Photograph courtesy of the Library of Congress.

Consider *Hamilton, Alabama*/"We manage to get along" (figure 62).[12] The photograph restates the legend in its pictorial code, creating with its low-angle viewpoint and wide-angle lens an impression of monumentality and strength (note especially how large the figures' hands are made to seem). This sort of rhetorical reinforcement and repetition is by far the more conventional arrangement of the photo-essay, and it may explain the enormous popular success of *You Have Seen Their Faces*.

12. The reader who supposes that these quotations have some documentary authenticity, or even an expressive relation to the photographic subject, should heed Bourke-White's opening note: "the legends under the pictures are intended to express the authors' own conceptions of the sentiments of the individuals portrayed; they do not pretend to reproduce the actual sentiments of these persons." The candor of this admission is somewhat offset by the

58. Walker Evans, photograph from *Let Us Now Praise Famous Men* (1939) by James Agee and Walker Evans. Photograph courtesy of the Library of Congress.

It also illustrates vividly the kind of rhetorical relation of photo and text that Evans and Agee were resisting. This is not to say that Evans and Agee are "unrhetorical," but that their "collaboration" is governed by a rhetoric of resistance rather than one of exchange and cooperation. Their images and words are "fully collaborative" in the project of subverting what they saw as a false and facile collaboration with governmental and journalistic institutions (the Farm Security Administration, *Fortune* magazine).[13] The blockage between photo and

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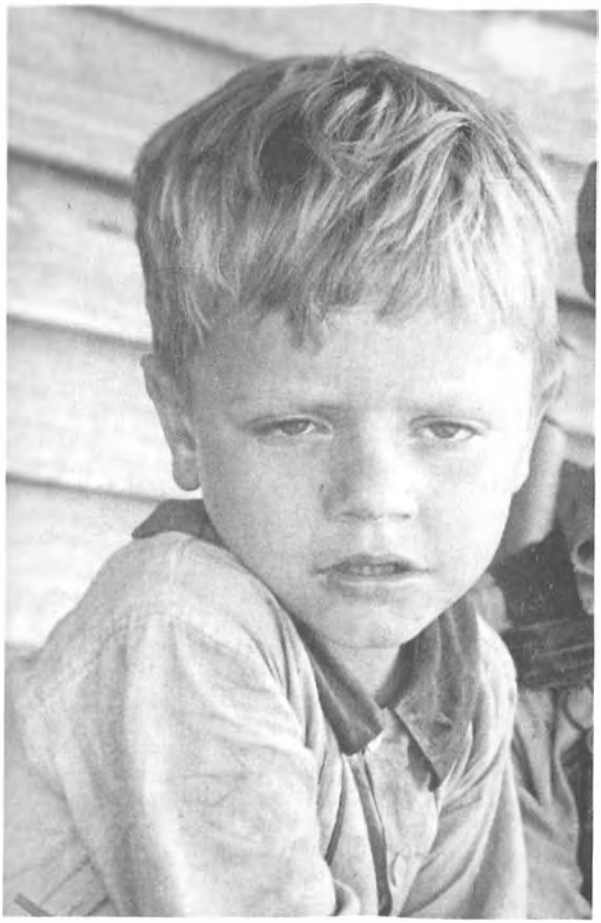
persistent fiction of the "quotation" throughout the text. This manipulation of verbal material is quite in keeping with Bourke-White's penchant for rearranging the objects in the sharecroppers' households to conform with her own aesthetic tastes.

13. Jefferson Hunter's book, *Image and Word: The Interaction of Twentieth Century Photographs and Texts* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1987) notes this resistance but sees it merely as an "affront" to convention that made *Famous Men* "unsuccessful in 1941" and "uninfluential now"

59. Walker Evans, photograph from *Let Us Now Praise Famous Men* (1939) by James Agee and Walker Evans. Photograph courtesy of the Library of Congress.

text is, in effect, a sabotaging of an effective surveillance and propaganda apparatus, one which creates easily manipulable images and narratives to support political agendas. Agee and Evans may well have agreed with many of the reformist political aims of Caldwell and Bourke-White and the institutions they represented: where they parted company is on what might be called the "ethics of espionage." Agee repeatedly characterizes himself and Evans as "spies": Agee is "a spy, traveling as a journalist"; Evans "a counter-spy, traveling as a photographer" (p. xxii). The "independence" of their collaboration is the strict condition for this spy/counter-spy relation; it is their way of

on the practice of photo-text collaboration. Hunter takes the "stylistic consistency" of Bourke-White and Caldwell as a model for the way "collaborative efforts succeed" (p. 79).



60. Walker Evans, photograph from *Let Us Now Praise Famous Men* (1939) by James Agee and Walker Evans. Photograph courtesy of the Library of Congress.

keeping each other honest, playing the role of "conscience" to one another. Evans exemplifies for Agee the ruthless violence of their work and the possibility of doing it with some sort of honor. The visibility of the photographic apparatus brings their espionage out into the open, and Agee admires the openness of Evans at work, his willingness to let his human subjects pose themselves, stage their own images in all their dignity and vulnerability, rather than treating them as material for pictorial self-expression. Agee, for his part, is all self-expression, as if the objectivity and restraint of Evans's work had to be countered by the fullest subjectivity and copiousness of confession. This division of labor is not just an ethics of production affecting the

61. Walker Evans, photograph from *Let Us Now Praise Famous Men* (1939) by James Agee and Walker Evans. Photograph courtesy of the Library of Congress.

work of the writer and photographer;[14] it is, in a very real sense, an ethics of form imposed on the reader/viewer in the structural division of the photos and text. Our labor as beholders is as divided as that of Agee and Evans, and we find ourselves drawn, as they were, into a vortex of collaboration and resistance.[15]

14. For an excellent account of what I'm calling an "ethics of production," see Carol Schloss's chapter on Agee and Evans in her *In Visible Light*.

15. I use the word "vortex" here to echo Agee's allusions to the Blakean vortex and to the presence of Blake as a presiding genius in *Famous Men*. I do not know how familiar Agee was with Blake's work as a composite artist, but if he knew the illuminated books, he must have been struck by the oft-remarked independence of Blake's engravings from his texts, an independence

62. Margaret Bourke-White, *HAMILTON, ALABAMA. "We manage to get along."* From *You Have Seen Their Faces,* by Erskine Caldwell and Margaret Bourke-White. Courtesy of the Estate of Margaret Bourke-White.

Labyrinth and Thread: Camera Lucida

A labyrinthine man never seeks the truth, but only his Ariadne.
—Nietzsche (quoted by Barthes)[16]

The strong, "agonistic" form of the photographic essay tends, as we have seen, to be as concerned with the nature of photography, writing,

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which is coupled, of course, with the most intimate collaboration. For more on Blakean text-image relations, see my *Blake's Composite Art* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1977), and chapter 4 above.

16. Roland Barthes, *Camera Lucida* (French original, 1981; New York: Hill and Wang, 1981), p. 73; further page references will be cited in the text.

and the relation of the two, as with its represented subject matter (tenant farming, New York tenements, migrant workers, etc.). But most essays on photography (including this one) are not "photographic essays" in the sense I am giving the term here. Walter Benjamin's "A Short History of Photography" is not a photographic essay for the obvious reason that it is not illustrated. But even if it were, the photos would only be there to illustrate the text; they would not have the independence or co-equality that permits collaboration in a truly composite form.

One of the few "essays on photography" that approaches the status of a photographic essay is Barthes's *Camera Lucida*. The "independence" and "co-equality" of the photographs in Barthes's text is achieved, not by grouping them in a separate "book" where their own syntactical relations may emerge, but by a consistent subversion of the textual strategies that tend to incorporate photographs as "illustrative" or evidentiary examples. We open *Camera Lucida* to a frontispiece (figure 63), a color polaroid by Daniel Boudinet that never receives any commentary in the text. The only words of Barthes that might be applied to it are equivocal or negative ("Polaroid? Fun, but disappointing, except when a great photographer is involved" [p. 9]; "I am not very fond of Color . . . color is a coating applied *later on* to the original truth of the black-and-white photograph . . . an artifice, a cosmetic (like the kind used to paint corpses)" [p. 81]. Are we to suppose, then, that Barthes simply "likes" this photograph and admires Boudinet's art? These criteria are continually subverted in Barthes's text by his seemingly capricious preferences, his refusal to assent to canonized masterpieces and masters: "there are moments when I detest Photographs: what have I to do with Atget's old tree trunks, with Pierre Boucher's nudes, with Germain Krull's double exposures (to cite only the old names)?" (p. 16). The Boudinet polaroid stands independent of Barthes's text: the best "reading" we can give it is perhaps simply as an emblem of the unreadability of photography, its occupation of a site forever prior to and outside Barthes's text. The photo presents an image of a veiled, intimate *boudoir*, simultaneously erotic and funereal, its tantalizingly partial revelation of light gleaming through the cleavage in the curtains like the secret at the center of a labyrinth. Barthes tells us that "it is a mistake to associate Photography . . . with the notion of a dark passage (*camera obscura*). It is *camera lucida* that we should say" (p. 106). But the darkened chamber of Barthes's frontispiece refuses to illustrate his text. If there is a *camera lucida* in this image it resides beyond the curtains of this scene,

or perhaps in the luminous opening at its center, an evocation of the camera's aperture.[17]

Most of the other photographs in Barthes's text seem, at first glance, purely illustrative, but a closer reading subverts this impression. Barthes's commentaries are doggedly resistant to the rhetoric of the "*studium,*" the "rational intermediary of an ethical or political culture" (p. 26) that allows photographs to be "read" or that would allow a scientific theory of the photograph to emerge. Instead, Barthes emphasizes what he calls the "*punctum,*" the stray, pointed detail that "pricks" or "wounds" him. These details (a necklace, bad teeth, folded arms, dirt streets) are accidental, uncoded, nameless features that open the photograph metonymically onto a contingent realm of memory and subjectivity: "it is what I add to the photograph and *what is nonetheless already there*" (p. 55), what is more often remembered about a photograph than what is seen in its actual presence.[18] The effect of this rhetoric is to render Barthes's text almost useless as a semiological theory of photography, while making it indispensable *to* such a theory. By insisting on his own personal experiences of photographs, by accepting the naive, primitive "astonishment," "magic," and "madness" of photography, Barthes makes his own experience the raw material or experimental data for a theory—a

17. The *camera lucida,* as Barthes knew, is not properly translated as a "light room" in opposition to a "dark room." It is "the name of that apparatus, anterior to Photography, which permitted drawing an object through a prism, one eye on the model, the other on the paper" (p. 106). The opening in the curtains, as optical aperture, plays precisely this role.

18. "I may know better a photograph I remember than a photograph I am looking at, as if direct vision oriented its language wrongly, engaging it in an effort of description which will always miss its point of effect, the *punctum*" (p. 53). The opposition between *studium* and *punctum* is coordinated, in Barthes's discussion, with related distinctions between the public and the private, the professional and the amateur. The captions further reinforce what Barthes calls "the two ways of the Photograph," dividing themselves into a scholarly, bibliographic identification of photographer, subject, date, etc. and an italicized quotation registering Barthes's personal response, the *punctum.* This practice of double captioning is, I think, a pervasive convention in photographic essays, often signaled by hyphenation (as in Robert Frank's *The Americans*), or contrasting type-styles (as in *You Have Seen Their Faces*): *Hamilton, Alabama*/ "We manage to get along."

63. Daniel Boudinet, *Polaroid, 1979*, in Roland Barthes, *Camera Lucida* (1981). © 1993 ARS, New York/SPADEM, Paris.

data, however, that is filled with consciousness of a skepticism about the theories that will be brought to it.[19]

The photograph that is of most importance to Barthes's text, a "private" picture of his mother taken in a glassed-in conservatory or "Winter Garden" when she was five years old, is not reproduced. "Something like the essence of the Photograph," says Barthes, "floated in this particular picture." If "all the world's photographs

19. Victor Burgin regards the antiscientific rhetoric of *Camera Lucida* with dismay: "The passage in *Camera Lucida* where Barthes lambasts the scientist of the sign (his own other self) has become widely quoted amongst precisely the sorts of critics Barthes opposed" ("Re-reading *Camera Lucida*," in *The End of Art Theory*, p. 91). Burgin's reduction of this to a straightforward political clash ignores the fact that the "sorts of critics" Barthes "opposed" included *himself*, and this opposition is precisely what gives his criticism ethical and political force.

64. Nadar, *The Artist's Mother (or Wife)* (n.d.), in Roland Barthes, *Camera Lucida* (1981). © 1993 ARS, New York/ SPADEM, Paris.

formed a Labyrinth, I knew at the center of this Labyrinth I should find nothing but this sole picture" (p. 73). But Barthes cannot take us into the center of the labyrinth except blindfolded, by ekphrasis, leading us with the thread of language. Barthes "cannot reproduce" the photograph of his mother because it "would be nothing but an indifferent picture" for anyone else. In its place he inserts a photograph by Nadar of *The Artist's Mother (or Wife)* (figure 64), which one "no one knows for certain" (p. 70).[20] This photograph receives

20. Joel Snyder informs me that these identifications are confused. The photograph was taken by Paul Nadar, the artist's son, and is of his mother, Nadar's wife. Given the use Barthes makes of the photograph, the confusion of father and son, wife and mother, is hardly surprising. The manifest uncertainty of the caption and its misquotation of Barthes's own text suggest that Barthes was deliberately attaching a confused "legend" to this photo.

only the most minimal, even banal commentary ("one of the loveliest photographs in the world" [p. 70]) and an equally banal caption which pretends to be quoted from the text, but (characteristically) is misquoted or constructed especially for this image: "'Who do you think is the world's greatest photographer?' 'Nadar'" (p. 68). Barthes's substitution of this maternal image for his own mother launches him into a series of increasingly general associative substitutions: this photograph becomes "*the* Photograph" becomes "*the* Image"; Barthes's mother becomes "The Artist's Mother" becomes "*the* Mother." The link between "Image" and "Mother" is then summarized as a universal cultural complex which has been reproduced in the particularity of Barthes's own experience of photography:

> Judaism rejected the image in order to protect itself from the risk of worshipping the Mother. . . . Although growing up in a religion-without-images where the Mother is not worshipped (Protestantism) but doubtless formed culturally by Catholic art, when I confronted the Winter Garden photograph I gave myself up to the Image, to the Image-Repertoire. (pp. 74–75).

Barthes is not a photographer; he made none of the photographs in his book, his only responsibility being to collect and arrange them within his text. He therefore has no collaborator in the usual sense. His collaborator is "Photography" itself, exemplified by an apparently miscellaneous collection of images, some private and personal, most the work of recognized masters from Niepce to Stieglitz to Mapplethorpe and Avedon.[21] "All the world's photographs" are treated by Barthes as a labyrinth whose unrepresentable center conceals the Mother, *his* mother. A mother who, like the subjects of all photographs, "is dead and . . . is going to die" (p. 95) unites all the photographs in Barthes's text, endowing them with the independent unity that enables them to look back at us while withholding their secrets. The Nadar portrait, its maternal figure gazing abstractedly out of the photo, mouth discreetly covered by the rose she kisses, is the closest we come to an emblem of this self-possession and reserve.

21. The twenty-five European and American photos in *Camera Lucida* range from journalism to art photos to personal family photographs and include examples of "old masters" (the "first photograph"—by Niepce; Charles Clifford, "The Alhambra"; G. W. Wilson, "Queen Victoria") from the nineteenth century as well twentieth-century works. The effort is clearly to suggest "Photography" in its full range without making any effort to be comprehensive or systematic.

The relation of the photographs to Barthes's text is, then, that of labyrinth and thread, the "maternal image-repertoire" and the umbilical cord of language. His role as a writer is not to master the photos, but to surrender himself as captivated observer, as naive subject of the idolatrous magic of images. The whole project is an attempt to suspend the appropriate "scientific" and "professional" discourse of photography in order to cultivate photography's resistance to language, allowing the photographs to "speak" their own language—not "its usual blah-blah: 'Technique,' 'Reality,' 'Reportage,' 'Art,' etc." but making "the image speak in silence" (p. 55). Barthes dismisses, therefore, much "sophisticated" commentary on photography, his own included:

> It is the fashion, nowadays, among Photography's commentators (sociologists and semiologists), to seize upon a semantic relativity: no "reality" (great scorn for the "realists" who do not see that the photograph is always coded) . . . the photograph, they say, is not an *analogon* of the world; what it represents is fabricated, because the photographic optic is subject to Albertian perspective (entirely historical) and because the inscription on the picture makes a three-dimensional object into a two-dimensional effigy. (p. 88)

Barthes declares this argument "futile," not just because photographs, like all images, are "analogical" in their coded structure, but because realism must be located in a different place: "the realists do not take the photograph for a 'copy' of reality, but for an emanation of *past reality*: a *magic,* not an art." This lost "magic" of photography, based in its naive realist stage (also its place in modernism), is what Barthes's text attempts to recover and why it must seem to efface itself, "give itself up to" its photographs, even as it weaves them into a labyrinth of theory and desire, science and autobiography.[22]

Voyeurism and Exorcism: The Colonial Harem

It is as if the postcard photographer had been entrusted with a social mission: *put the collective phantasm into images.* He is the first to benefit from what he accomplishes through the delegation

22. This respect for the "naive realism" of photography is also a crucial feature of Agee's text. Agee notes "how much slower white people are to catch on than negroes, who understand the meaning of a camera, a weapon, a stealer of images and souls, a gun, an evil eye" (p. 362).

of power. The true voyeurism is that of the colonial society as a whole.

—Malek Alloula

The "magic" of photography can be the occasion of mystification as well as ecstasy, a point that is made by Malek Alloula's photographic essay on French colonial postcards of Algerian women.[23] Alloula dedicates his book to Barthes and adopts his basic vocabulary for the description of photographic magic, but he inverts Barthes's textual strategies in order to confront a body of images that exercised a detestable, pernicious magic over the representation of Algeria:

> What I read on these cards does not leave me indifferent. It demonstrates to me, were that still necessary, the desolate poverty of a gaze that I myself, as an Algerian, must have been the object of at some moment in my personal history. Among us, we believe in the nefarious effects of the evil eye (the evil gaze). We conjure them with our hand spread out like a fan. I close my hand back upon a pen to write *my* exorcism: *this text.* (p. 5)

There is no nostalgia here for a lost "primitive" or "realist" stage; there is no room for the "*punctum*" or ecstatic "wound" Barthes locates in the accidental detail. There is only the massive trauma of the "degrading fantasm" legitimating itself under the sign of photographic "reality." These photographs exclude all the "accidents" Barthes associates with the subversive "white magic" of the image. They stage for the voyeuristic French consumer the fantasy of "Oriental" luxury, lust, and indolence, as the unveiled "booty" before the colonial gaze. The critical text is counter-magic, a contrary incantation, repetitiously intoning its execrations on the filthy European pornographers with their ethnographic alibis.

Alloula's text fulfills the three conditions of the photographic essay in a quite unsuspected manner: his text is obviously independent of the images, that independence a direct result of Algeria's revolutionary independence of the French empire (Barbara Harlow's introduction places the book quite explicitly in the framework of Pontecorvo's film, *The Battle of Algiers*). There is "equality" of text and image in at least two senses. First, the text offers a point-by-point

23. Malek Alloula, *The Colonial Harem*, translated by Myrna and Wlad Godzich (French edition, 1981; English edition, Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 1986); further page references will be cited in the text.

critical refutation of the implicit "argument" of the images. Second, it attempts to realize a contrary visual image or "staring back" into the face of the predatory colonial gaze. Alloula's text presents itself as a kind of substitute for a body of photographs that should have been taken, but never were:

> A reading of the sort that I propose to undertake would be entirely superfluous if there existed photographic traces of the gaze of the colonized upon the colonizer. In their absence, that is, in the absence of a confrontation of opposed gazes, I attempt here . . . to return this immense postcard to its sender. (p. 5)

Finally, there is "collaboration" in the sense that the postcards must be reproduced along with the text and thus forced to collaborate in their own deconstruction, their own "unveiling," much as the *algérienne* were forced to collaborate in the misrepresentation of Algerian women and their images forced to collaborate in a false textualizing—their insertion into a staged fantasy of exotic sexuality and unveiling, the colonial "chit-chat" (full of crude jokes) written on their backs, the colonial seal stamped across their faces, canceling the postage and their independent existence in one stroke.

Alloula's project is clearly beset on every side by contradictory impulses, the most evident being the necessity of reproducing the offending postcards in a book which may look to the casual observer like a coffee-table "collector's item" of exactly the sort he denounces. Occasional "classics" and "masterpieces" emerge, even in a pornographic genre:

> It is on "accomplishments" of this sort that a lucrative business of card collecting has been built and continues to thrive. It is also by means of this type of "accomplishment" that the occultation of meaning is effected, the meaning of the postcard that is of interest to us here. (p. 118)

"Aestheticization," far from being an antidote to the pornographic, is seen as an extension of it, a continuing cover-up of evil under the sign of beauty and rarity. This problem was also confronted by Agee, who dreaded the notion that his collaboration with Evans would be mystified by notions of special expertise or authority, chief among these the authority of the "artist": "the authors," he said, "are trying to deal with it not as journalists, sociologists, politicians, entertainers, humanitarians, priests. or artists, but seriously" (p. xv). "Seriousness" here means something quite antithetical to the notion of a canonical "classic" stamped with "aesthetic merit" and implies

a sense of temporary, tactical intervention in an immediate human problem, not a claim on the indefinite future. That is why Agee wanted to print *Let Us Now Praise Famous Men* on newspaper stock. When told that "the pages would crumble to dust in a few years," he said, "that might not a bad idea" (Stott, p. 264).

Let us add, then, to the generic criteria of the photographic essay a notion of seriousness which is frequently construed in anti-aesthetic terms, as a confrontation with the immediate, the local and limited, with the un-beautiful, the impoverished, the ephemeral, in a form that regards itself as simultaneously *indispensable* and *disposable*. The text of Alloula's *The Colonial Harem* sometimes reads as if it wanted to shred or incinerate the offending postcards it reproduces so well, to disfigure the pornographic beauty of the colonized women. But that would be, like most shreddings of historical documents, only a cover-up that would guarantee historical amnesia and a return of the repressed. Although Alloula can never quite say this, one feels that his essay is not simply a polemic against the French evil, but a tacit confession and purgation. Alloula reproduces the offending images, not just to aggressively "return an immense postcard to its sender," but to repossess and redeem those images, to "exorcise" an ideological spell that captivated mothers, wives, and sisters, as well as the "male society" that "no longer exists" (p. 122) in the colonial gaze. The rescue of women is an overcoming of impotence; the text asserts its manhood by freeing the images from the evil eye.

Barthes found the secret of photography in an image of his prepubescent mother at the center of a labyrinth. His text is the thread that takes us toward that center, a ritual surrender to the maternal image-repertoire. Alloula drives us out of the mystified labyrinth constructed by European representations of Arab women. He avenges the prostitution not only of the Mother, but of Photography itself, seeking to reverse the pornographic process.

What are we left with? Are the images redeemed, and if so, in what terms and for what sort of observer? How do we see, for instance, the final photograph of the book (figure 65), which Alloula only mentions in passing, and whose symmetry approaches abstraction, reminiscent of an art nouveau fantasy. Can an American observer, in particular, see these photographs as anything more than quaint, archaic pornography, hauntingly beautiful relics of a lost colonial era, "collector's items" for a coffee-table book? I don't have a simple answer to this question, but my first impulse is to register a feeling of *impotence* in the face of these women, whose beauty is now mixed with danger, whose nakedness now becomes a veil that has

65. *Scenes and Types: Arabian woman with the Yachmak* (n.d.), from *The Colonial Harem* (1986) by Malek Alloula, translated by Myrna and Wlad Godzich (French edition, 1981; English edition, Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 1986).

always excluded me from the labyrinth of their world.[24] I feel exiled from what I want to know, to understand, or (more precisely) what I want to acknowledge and to be acknowledged by. In particular,

24. This impotence is perhaps nothing more than the familiar liberal guilt of the white male American becoming conscious of complicity in the ethos of imperialism. But it is also a more personal reaction which stems from a not altogether pleasant failure to react "properly" to the pornographic image, a failure which I can't take credit for as a matter of moral uprightness (morality, I suspect, only enters in when the proper reaction is there to be resisted). I had registered this feeling at the first perusal of the photographs in *The Colonial Harem*. Needless to say, a sensation of the uncanny attended my reading of the final paragraph of Alloula's text: "Voyeurism turns into an obsessive neurosis. The great erotic dream, ebbing from the sad faces of the wage earners in the poses, lets appear, in the flotsam perpetuated by the postcard, another figure: that of *impotence*" (p. 122).

Alloula's text forces these acknowledgments from me: that I cannot read these photographs; that any narrative I might have brought to them is now shattered; that the labyrinth of photography, of the maternal image-repertoire, defies penetration and colonization by any textual system, including Malek Alloula's. The photographs, so long exchanged, circulated, inscribed, and traded, now assert their independence and equality, looking at us as they collaborate in the undoing of the colonial gaze.

Exile and Return: After the Last Sky

But I am the exile.
Seal me with your eyes.
—Mahmoud Darwish

Feelings of exile and impotence in the face of the imperial image are the explicit subject of Edward Said and Jean Mohr's photographic essay on the Palestinians. But instead of the aggressive "return of the repressed" in the form of degraded, pornographic images, *After the Last Sky*[25] projects a new set of images, self-representations of the colonized and dispossessed subjects, representations of their views of the colonizers: "our intention was to show Palestinians through Palestinian eyes without minimizing the extent to which even to themselves they feel different" (p. 6). The text is (as in *Camera Lucida*) a thread leading the writer and his readers back into the labyrinth of otherness and the self-estrangement of exile. Its task is to see that the "photographs are not" seen as "the exhibition of a foreign specimen" (p. 162), without, on the other hand, simply domesticating them. Said's text is not, then, like Alloula's, a scourge to drive Western eyes out the labyrinth. If Alloula treats the collaboration of text and image as a violent, coercive confrontation, Said and Mohr create a dialogical relation of text and image that is collaborative in the classic (that is, modernist) sense articulated by Agee and Evans, a cooperative endeavor by two like-minded and highly talented professionals, writer and photographer.

The results of this "positive" collaboration are anything but straightforward. The independence of text and image is not asserted directly, as in Agee and Evans, by a strict physical separation. Said

25. Edward Said and Jean Mohr, *After the Last Sky* (London: Pantheon, 1986); further page references will be cited in the text.

and Mohr follow something closer to the mode of *Camera Lucida*'s dialectical, intertwined relation of photos and essay, a complex of exchange and resistance.[26] Writer and photographer both refuse the stereotyped division of labor that would produce a "text with illustrations" or an "album with captions." Said's text oscillates between supplementary relations to the images (commentary, meditations, reflections on photography) and "independent" material (the history of the Palestinians, autobiographical anecdotes, political criticism). Mohr's photographs oscillate between "illustrative" relations (pictures of boys lifting weights, for instance, document the "cult of physical strength" Said describes among Palestinian males) and "independent" statements that receive no direct commentary in the text, or play some kind of ironic counterpoint to it. An example: Said's discussion of his father's lifelong attempt to escape memories and material mementos of Jerusalem is juxtaposed (on the facing page) with an image that conveys just the opposite message and which receives no commentary, only a minimal caption: "the former mayor of Jerusalem and his wife, in exile in Jordan" (figure 66). Behind them a photographic mural of the Mosque of Omar in Jerusalem occupies the entire wall of their living room. The collaboration of image and text here is not simply one of mutual support. It conveys the anxiety and ambivalence of the exile whose memories and mementos, the tokens of personal and national identity, may "seem . . . like encumbrances" (p. 14). The mural seems to tell us that the former mayor and his wife *cherish* these encumbrances, but their faces do not suggest that this in any way reduces their weight.

The relation of photographs and writing in *After the Last Sky* is consistently governed by the dialectic of *exile* and its overcoming, a double relation of estrangement and re-unification. If, as Said claims, "exile is a series of portraits without names, without context" (p. 12), return is figured in the attachment of names to photographs, contexts to images. But "return" is never quite so simple: sometimes the names are lost, unrecoverable; too often the attachment of text to an image can seem arbitrary, unsatisfactory. Neither pole in the dialectic of exile is univocally coded: estrangement is both imposed from without by historical circumstance and from within by the painfulness of memory, the will to forget and shed the "encumbrance" of Palestinian

26. Mohr's earlier collaborations with John Berger are clearly an important precedent also. See especially *The Seventh Man* (Originally published, Penguin, 1975; London: Writers and Readers, 1982), a photographic essay on migrant workers in Europe.

66. Jean Mohr, *Mayor of Jerusalem*, page spread from *After the Last Sky*, by Edward W. Said. Copyright © 1986 by Edward W. Said. Reprinted by permission of Pantheon Books, a division of Random House, Inc.

identity. "Re-unification," similarly, is the utopian object of desire and yet an object of potential aversion in its utopian impracticality. "Homecoming," says Said, "is out of the question. You learn to transform the mechanics of loss into a constantly postponed metaphysics of return" (p. 150). Where does the exile go "after the last sky" has clouded over, after Beirut, Cairo, Amman, the West Bank have failed to provide a home? What attitude do the physically exiled Palestinians take to the "exiles at home," the "present absentees" who live in "The Interior," inside Israel? The ambivalence expressed in these questions is also inscribed in the delicate, intricate, and precarious relations of text and image—the inside and outside, as it were, of this book.

The casual "Outsider," the beholder who takes this simply as an album of photographs, will have no difficulty grasping the major polemical point of the book, which is to counter the usual visual representation of Palestinians as menacing figures with *kaffiyas* and ski-masks. Anonymous "terrorists" are displaced by a set of visual facts that everyone knows in theory, but rarely acknowledges in practice—that Palestinians are also women, children, businessmen, teachers, farmers, poets, shepherds, and auto mechanics. That the representation of Palestinians as ordinary human beings, "capturable" by ordinary, domestic sorts of snapshots, should be in itself remarkable is a measure of how extraordinarily limited the normal image of the Palestinian is. There is an acceptable "icon" of the Palestinian, as Said puts it, and the images in *After the Last Sky*—domestic, peaceful, ordinary—do not fit this decorum, as anyone will find who attempts to insert this book among the other photographic texts that adorn the typical coffee-table.

The history of this particular set of photographs suggests that this decorum is not simply natural or empirical but has to be reinforced by the most stringent prohibitions. Jean Mohr was commissioned to take the pictures for an exhibition at the International Conference on the Question of Palestine held by the United Nations in Geneva in 1983. "The official response," as Said notes

> was puzzling. . . . You can hang them up, we were told, but no writing can be displayed with them. No legends, no explanations. A compromise was finally negotiated whereby the name of the country or place (Jordan, Syria, West Bank, Gaza) could be affixed to the much-enlarged photographs, but not one word more. (p. 3)

The precise motives for this bureaucratic "prohibition on writing" never become clear. Said speculates that the various Arab states who participated in the conference (Israel and the United States did not) found the Palestinian cause "useful up to a point—for attacking Israel, for railing against Zionism, imperialism, and the United States," but the notion of considering the Palestinians *as a people* (that is, with a story, a text, an argument) was unacceptable. The prohibition on writing was perhaps a way of keeping these disturbing images from taking on an even more disturbing voice. Context, narrative, historical circumstances, identities, and places were repressed in favor of what might be seen as a parody of the abstract and "modernist" space of visual exhibition: minimal captions, no "legends," pure vi-

sual display without reference or representation. Exile is a series of photographs without texts.

After the Last Sky, then, is a violation of a double prohibition against a certain kind of image (nonbellicose, nonsublime) and against a writing joined to these images. This might seem an excessively formalistic point. But Said notes that "most literary critics . . . focus on what is said in Palestinian writing . . . [its] sociological and political meaning. But it is the *form* that should be looked at" (p. 38). This "form" is not something distinct from content; it *is* the content in its most material, particular sense, the specific places it carves out as the site of Palestinian existence. As such, it resists the reduction of the Palestinian question to a political issue, insisting on the ethical as well as aesthetic relation of text and image. The collaboration of photographer and writer in *After the Last Sky* cannot be seen, then, simply as corrective to the prohibition which segregates the Palestinian image from the Palestinian text. This collaboration is also embedded in a complex field of heterogeneities that can never quite be accommodated to traditional dialectical forms of aesthetic unity. We don't find a Coleridgean "multeity in unity" in this book, but something more like a multeity of glimpses of unity, seen as if through a pair of spectacles, one lens of which is shattered. (This image, drawn from one of the most striking photographs in the book, is one I will return to later.)

The two lenses of this book are writing and photography, neither understood abstractly or generically but as constructions of specific histories, places, and displacements. The photographer, a German born in Geneva, naturalized as a Swiss citizen in 1939, has had concrete experience of intra-European exile. The writer is a Palestinian Christian born in Jerusalem, exiled to Lebanon, Egypt, the United States. From one point of view the writer is the insider, the clear, intact lens who can represent through his own experience a focused image of "the Palestinian"; the photographer is the alien, unable to speak the languages of Palestine or Israel, "seeing" only the mute, inarticulate fragments of lives that the camera allows (thus, many of the people in Mohr's photographs are anonymous, unidentified, and photography re-doubles the exile of image from referent). From another point of view, the photographer is the clear, intact lens. His Swiss neutrality allows him what was denied to the writer in the 1980s, the freedom to travel throughout Israel and the West Bank, to go "inside" Palestine and represent it with the transparent accuracy of photography. The writer is the alien, the outsider, estranged from

a land he dimly remembers as a child, a land in which he would have been, as an urbane, Christian intellectual, estranged from the rural, local culture of the Palestinian masses. The writer acknowledges that he himself is the "cracked lens," unable to see, quite literally, the native country he longs for except in fragmentary glimpses provided by others.

The divisions of labor we have traced between writer and photographer—spy and counter-spy, thread and labyrinth, voyeur and exorcist—are consistently undermined by the tightly woven collaboration of *After the Last Sky*. But there is one vestige of traditional divisions of labor in the way Said's meditations on gender difference suggest the collaboration of a male text with a body of female images. Like Barthes, Said installs Woman at the center of the photographic matrix. The section of the book called "Interiors" (concerned with Palestinians who live inside Israel, with domestic spaces and the theme of privacy) is mainly devoted to images of women. Said also follows Barthes in finding that the primal scene of the photograph involves his mother. A British customs official rips up her passport, destroying her legal identity and (presumably) her photographic image in the same gesture. Like Alloula, Said is vindicating the disfigured image of his mother; like Barthes, he is trying to re-assemble the fragments of her identity. But he also portrays the women as the real preservers of this identity, associated with "the land" and the idea of home, portrayed as clinging irrationally, stubbornly, to "memories, title deeds, and legal claims" (p. 81). The women are also the keepers of images in the Palestinian interior, the ones who hang up too many pictures too high on the walls, who save the photograph albums and mementos that may encumber the male Palestinian who wants to travel light. (Recall that Said's father "spent his life trying to escape these objects" [p. 14].) Yet Said acknowledges a "crucial absence of women" (p. 77) in the representation of Palestinians. The official icon is one of "automatic manhood," the macho terrorist who may feel himself both goaded and reproached by the "protracted discipline" (p. 79) of women's work.

Like Barthes, Said wants to preserve the feminine mystique of the image, its difference from the male writer's "articulate discourse" (p. 79). Thus, it sometimes seems as if he would prefer to leave the female images unidentified and therefore mysterious. Like Barthes, he does not reproduce an image of his mother, but substitutes an image of an elderly woman, generalized as an emblem—"a face, I thought when I first saw it, of our life at home" (p. 84). But six months later

67. Jean Mohr, *Amman, 1984. Mrs. Farraj.* In *After the Last Sky,* by Edward W. Said. Copyright © 1986 by Edward W. Said. Reprinted by permission of Pantheon Books, a division of Random House, Inc.

Said is reminded by his sister that this woman (figure 67) is actually a distant relative whom he met in the forties and fifties, a reminder that produces mixed emotions:

> As soon as I recognized Mrs. Farraj, the suggested intimacy of the photograph's surface gave way to an explicitness with few secrets. She is a real person—Palestinian—with a real history at the interior of ours. But I do not know whether the photograph can, or does, say things as they really are. Something has been lost. But the representation is all we have. (p. 84)

The uncharacteristic awkwardness of Said's writing here is, I think, a tacit acknowledgment of his ambivalence toward the associative complex, Woman/Image/Home, a confession of his complicity in the sentimentalizing of women and of the lost pastoral homeland that fixates the imagination of the Palestinian male.[27] His candor about

27. "I can see the women everywhere in Palestinian life, and I see how they exist between the syrupy sentimentalism of roles we ascribe to them

68. Jean Mohr, *Elderly Palestinian Villager. Ramallah, 1984.* In *After the Last Sky,* by Edward W. Said. Copyright © 1986 by Edward W. Said. Reprinted by permission of Pantheon Books, a division of Random House, Inc.

this ambivalence, his recognition that the photographic image has a life beyond the discursive, political uses he would make of it, allows the photograph to "look back" at him and us and assert the independence we associate with the strong form of the photo-essay. The poetic secrecy and intimacy he had hoped to find in this image is replaced by a prosaic familiarity and openness.

Jean Mohr provides Said with a striking emblem of his own ambivalence in a photograph which comes closer than any other in this book to supplying a portrait of the writer. Once again, the photo is an unidentified portrait, exiled from its referent, an image of an "elderly Palestinian villager" with a broken lens in his glasses (figure 68). The photograph reminds Said of Rafik Halabi, "a Palestinian-Druze-Israeli" whose book, *The West Bank Story,* is highly critical of Israeli occupation, but "who writes from the viewpoint of a loyal Israeli"

(mothers, virgins, martyrs) and the annoyance, even dislike that their unassimilated strength provokes in our warily politicized, automatic manhood" (p. 77).

who served in the army and "subscribes to Zionism." Said finds Halabi's position impossibly contradictory. Either he is "deluded" or "up to some elaborate rhetorical game" which Said does not understand. Either way, "the result is a book that runs on two completely different tracks" (p. 127). It occurs to Said, of course, that there is something of himself, and perhaps of his own book, in this image: "Perhaps I am only describing *my* inability to order things coherently, sequentially, logically, and perhaps the difficulties of resolution I have discerned in Halabi's book and in the old man with broken glasses are mine, not theirs" (p. 130). First, the image is a double portrait of the Other as Insider, "a symbol, I said to myself, of some duality in our life that won't go away—refugees and terrorists, victims and victimizers, and so on" (p. 128). Not a bad reading, but Said is unhappy with it, as he is generally with emblematic readings that reduce the photograph to convenient verbal formulas. The man's face is "strong and gentle," the "blotch is on the lens, not in him" (p. 128). He has agreed to be photographed this way, so he can watch the camera and exert some control over his own image.

The resulting visual field (both for the wearer of the glasses and the beholder), Said notes, will always disclose a "small disturbance," a "curiously balanced imbalance" which is "very similar to the textual imbalance in Halabi's book" and, clearly, in Said and Mohr's. The Palestinians, a people without a geographic center and with only the most fragile cultural and historical identity have "no one central image," no "dominant theory," no "coherent discourse"; they are "without a center. Atonal" (p. 129). At moments like this, one glimpses Said's allegiance to the musical aesthetics of modernism, to that combination of pessimism and formalism we associate with Adorno. Said's composite, decentered, shifting, imbalanced collaboration with Mohr is nonetheless a shapely, congruent, and formal creation, a material embodiment of the reality he wants to represent, built out of a refusal to simplify, to sentimentalize or settle for polemic. Both writer and photographer could see themselves in this anonymous portrait, itself in exile from its subject: exile is indeed "a series of portraits without names, without contexts" (p. 12). But if photographs sundered from texts portray exile, photographs *with* text are images of return, sites of reconciliation, accommodation, acknowledgment. The delicate balancing act of a book "on two different tracks" may be a rhetorical game Said does not understand even as he is compelled to play it, but then he remarks that Palestinians sometimes "puzzle even ourselves" (p. 53).

The "central image" of the Palestinians is, for the moment, a double vision of just this sort—secular, rational, yet deeply involved in the emotions of victimage—figures in a rhetoric of paranoia which constructs them as the enemy of the victims of the Holocaust or as mere pawns in geopolitical schemes. Said and Mohr cannot be content, therefore, with a propaganda piece to "pretty up the image" of the Palestinians; they must work as well for an *internally directed* representation and critique, chiding not only the Arab and Israeli and Big Power interests, but the Palestinians themselves, Said included. The Palestinians' failings—their pursuit of inappropriate revolutionary models such as Cuba and Algeria, their impatient, macho romanticism, their failure to organize properly with the "protracted discipline" of women, their lack of a coherent history—are all part of the picture. The idea of the book, then, is ultimately to help bring the Palestinians into existence for themselves as much as for others; it is that most ambitious of books, a nation-making text.

Texts that make nations are, of course, what we call "classics," the worst fate (according to Agee) that can befall a book. It was a fate that befell *Let Us Now Praise Famous Men* after a period of neglect and misunderstanding. Our understanding of the thirties, particular the Depression, is often seen as a product of Evans's and Agee's collaboration, and it helped to form an image of a nation in poverty, presented with dignity, sympathy, and truth. But Evans and Agee could never hope, as Said and Mohr do, to address the people they represent, to help bring them into being as a people. Whether this book fulfills such a hope is a question that will be settled beyond its pages: "there is no completely coherent discourse adequate to us, and I doubt whether at this point, if someone could fashion such a discourse, we could be adequate for it" (p. 129). It is at such moments of inadequacy, perhaps, that a mixed, hybrid discourse like that of the photographic essay emerges as a historical necessity.

Insofar as my own remarks here have been essays toward the definition of a genre or a medium, an attempt to articulate the formal principles of the photographic essay, they might be seen as a betrayal of the anti-aesthetic, anticanonical experimentalism of this form. Why attempt to "classicize" by classifying and formalizing a medium that is so young and unpredictable? The photographic essay occupies a strange conceptual space in our understanding of representation, a place where "form" seems both indispensable and disposable. On the one hand, it seems to participate in what Stanley Cavell has described as the tendency of "modernist painting" to "break down the concept

of genre altogether,"[28] as if the medium were not given naturally, but had to be re-invented, re-evaluated in each new instance; this is the tendency I've associated with the mutual "resistance" of photography and writing, the insistence on the distinctive character of each medium, the search for a "purity" of approach that is both aesthetic and ethical. On the other hand, the roots of the photo-essay in documentary journalism, newspapers, magazines, and the whole ensemble of visual-verbal interactions in mass media connect it to popular forms of communication that seem quite antithetical to modernism in their freedom of exchange between image and text and their material ephemerality. Perhaps this is just a way of placing the photographic essay at the crossroads between modernism and postmodernism, understanding it as a form in which the resistance to image-text exchange is (in contrast to painting) most crucial precisely because it has the most to overcome.[29] If this crossroads occupies a real place in our cultural history, it is one we cannot leave unmapped. To take literally the antiformalist rhetoric of the photographic essay would be to empty it of its specific, historical materiality as a representational practice and to neglect those labors of love in which we are enjoined to collaborate.

28. Stanley Cavell, *The World Viewed: Reflections on the Ontology of Film*, enlarged edition (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1979), p. 106.

29. I say "in contrast to painting" because the emancipation of painting from language, or at least the rhetoric of emancipation, has dominated the sophisticated understanding of painting for most of this century. For a fuller version of this argument, see chapter 7 above.

IV·····Pictures·and·Power

> But it is sensible to begin by asking the beginning questions, why imagine power in the first place, and what is the relationship between one's motive for imagining power and the image one ends up with.
>
> —Edward Said,
> "Foucault and the Imagination of Power"[1]

Let's begin our inquiry into the power of pictures by asking what sort of picture of power we are assuming. I say "picture" instead of "theory" of power, because (following Foucault and others) I don't imagine that we really can theorize power from the outside, and because any effort at theorizing power will necessarily involve some picture of its nature, its effects, its transmission, circulation, and the representative scenes of its exercise (domination and resistance, co-optation and evasive action, violence and suffering).

In a sense, every essay in this book has already been about pictures of power, and the power of pictures. "The Pictorial Turn" attempted to show why contemporary theoretical discourse has found it so difficult, and yet so necessary, to get the question of visual representation under control. "Metapictures" explored the way pictures reflect on themselves, depicting their own powers and their effects on spectators. "Beyond Comparison" introduced a series of redescriptions of the visible and verbal, not merely as instruments of power, but as internally divided force-fields, scenes of struggle indicated by the hybrid term of the "imagetext"—the power of the image understood as the "other"

1. See *Foucault: A Critical Reader*, edited by David Couzens Hoy (New York: Blackwell, 1986), p. 151.

or "slave" to the master's poetic and narrative voice, the power of the image to resist or collaborate with language.

Still, we have not yet attempted to give a picture of power as such, and perhaps no such picture can be given, except in the kind of heterogeneous and dialectical imagetexts we have already seen. Certainly the wrong picture is suggested by models of physical force which hypostatize some homogeneous, subtle fluid called Power and which some people (or systems) simply "have" while others do not.[2] "Power as such," says Foucault, "does not exist" (p. 786). Powerlessness, therefore, is not a mere absence or negation, but a site of action and force in its own right.[3] Foucault suggests as much when he says that one should approach power with the question "how?" rather than "what?" and "give oneself as the object of analysis power relations and not power itself" (p. 788). Power is not something one "has" but a relationship one enjoys or suffers. If we want to understand the power of pictures, we need to look at their internal relations of domination and resistance, as well as their external relations with spectators and with the world.

Foucault offers two basic pictures of power: "that which is

2. I rely here mainly on Foucault's essay, "The Subject and Power," *Critical Inquiry* 8:4 (Summer 1982): 777–95; further page references will be cited in the text. See also David Couzens Hoy, "Power, Repression, Progress: Foucault, Lukes and the Frankfurt School," in *Foucault: A Critical Reader,* pp. 123–47, for a useful account of the intersection between ideological criticism and the Foucauldian critique of power.

3. The unthinkability of absolute powerlessness is, I believe, what lies behind Foucault's statement that "slavery is not a power relationship when man is in chains" (p. 790).

exerted over things" and the ways "certain persons exercise power over others" (p. 786). These contrasting models underlie two of the most durable ways of thinking about the power of pictures, two intertwined traditions I will call "illusionism" and "realism."[4] Illusionism is the capacity of pictures to deceive, delight, astonish, amaze, or otherwise take power over a beholder; in the *trompe-l'œil,* or the special effects of cinema, for instance, the point is to provide a simulation of the presence of objects, spaces, and actions, to trigger a responsive experience in the beholder. Realism, by contrast, is associated with the capacity of pictures to show the truth about things. It doesn't take power over the observer's eye so much as it stands in for it, offering a transparent window onto reality, an embodiment of a socially authorized and credible "eyewitness" perspective. The spectator of the realist representation is not supposed to be under the power of the representation, but to be using representation in order to take power over the world. Seen as a composite imagetext, the realist representation might be understood as a picture accompanied by the tacit legend: "this is the way things are." The legend of illusionism is "this is how things look." Magritte's *Ceci n'est pas une pipe* might be understood as the collision of an illusionist image with a realist text.

4. David Freedberg's *The Power of Images: Studies in the History and Theory of Response* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1989) provides a compendium of "scenes" in which the power of pictures is illustrated. Freedberg considers mainly sexual and religious-magical-superstitious scenes of image-power, declining to engage with political or ideological issues. See p. xxiv: "above all I am conscious of the absence here of an approach to the problem of figurated propaganda and of arousal to political action."

In practice, of course, realism and illusionism are often used interchangeably. Nothing is more common than expressions that praise illusionistic representations for being "realistic" (to call them "illusory" would, in fact, be a sign of incapacity) or expressions that criticize realistic representations as nothing more than plausible illusions, merely an "effect of the real." But even these elisions of realism and illusionism suggest a subtle difference in the terms of praise or dispraise that accompany them and in the metapicture of power relations that underlies them. Illusionism involves power over subjects: it is an action directed at a free subject that has to be addressed, persuaded, entertained, deceived. Realism presents itself as power directed at objects, the kind of power Foucault calls "capacity." It may include representations of subjects, but it addresses them (and its beholders), as it were, "objectively."

An apt illustration of the difference between these two forms of pictorial power is the distinction between spectacle and surveillance.[5] It would make no sense to praise an aerial reconnaissance photograph for its beauty or lifelikeness, and if we commended the "realism" of film simulations of space combat in *Star Wars* we would really be talking about illusionistic spectacle, not about the narrative genre or the documentary status of the film. Taken

5. See Foucault's polemical declaration in *Discipline and Punish,* originally published in French in 1975, translated by Alan Sheridan (New York: Vintage Books, 1979): "Our society is not one of spectacle but of surveillance. . . . We are neither in the amphitheatre nor on the stage but in the Panoptic machine" (p. 217). Foucault's debunking of spectacle strikes me as a moment of narrow-mindedness that has more to do with French intellectual politics than with the real powers of visual culture.

together, spectacle and surveillance epitomize the basic dialectic between illusionism and realism in contemporary visual culture: they might be thought of as the "soft" and "hard" technologies for the formation of subjects in our time, whether we characterize that time as the age of mass culture, triumphant international corporate capitalism, or in familiar rubrics like the postindustrial and the postmodern. Spectacle is the ideological form of pictorial power;[6] surveillance is its bureaucratic, managerial, and disciplinary form.

One way of describing the "pictorial turn" in contemporary visual culture is the convergence of spectacle and surveillance in television news, film, and forms of art that address a public sphere.[7] I'll return to this subject in the final section of this book, but for now my purpose is to focus on theories (that is, pictures) of illusionism and realism. It should be clear that these are not just the names of types of pictures, but types of imagetexts, complex intersections of representation and discourse.[8] The discourse of illusionism seems inevitably to engage the sphere of nature, espe-

6. I am echoing here Guy Debord's classic formulation: "The spectacle is ideology par excellence." See *The Society of the Spectacle* (first published, 1967; Detroit: Black and Red, 1977), par. 215.

7. Jonathan Crary notes the way surveillance and spectacle can "coincide" in *Techniques of the Observer: On Vision and Modernity in the Nineteenth Century* (Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 1990), p. 18.

8. As heterogeneous imagetexts, there are of course internal power relations between kinds of pictures and the discourses attached to or denied by them. See, for instance, Jean Baudrillard on the way objects in a *trompe-l'œil* "have as it were eliminated the discourse of painting" ("The Trompe-L'œil," in *Calligram: Essays in New Art History from France,* edited by Norman Bryson [New York: Cambridge University Press, 1988]), p. 54.

cially the nature of the spectator understood as a body with sensory, perceptual, and emotional automatisms—"buttons" that may be pushed to activate the individual beholder. Realism, by contrast, aligns itself with the social, the rational, the scientifically skeptical, with the view of an ideal, interchangeable, public spectator understood as normative. The empirical study of illusion tends to engage cognitive science and animal behavior: I illustrate it here in the tradition that links Pliny to Gombrich, more specifically in the practice of "looking at animals looking" in order to get at the nature of the human beholder. The study of realism, on the other hand, intersects with philosophy (where it is also the name of an epistemological tradition) and with aesthetics and the social sciences. I illustrate it here with the attempt of Nelson Goodman to provide a rigorous formal account of realism from the standpoint of a general theory of symbol systems that combines aesthetics with the philosophy of science. Both Goodman and Gombrich cross over these boundaries, of course. Goodman's "irrealism" is densely informed by the assumptions of cognitive science, and Gombrich's characteristic gesture in *Art and Illusion* is to shuttle between realism and illusionism, between pictures understood as mechanisms of power over a real world of objects and as devices to manipulate the senses of beholders. Both theories, I will argue, fail at critical moments, but their failures are all the more interesting for the glimpses they provide of historical turns in the power of pictures.

ILLUSION: LOOKING AT ANIMALS LOOKING

The following theses are illustrated in this essay:

1. *Illusion is a natural, universal phenomenon, transcending cultural boundaries and historical epochs.*
2. *Illusionism is a specific cultural practice, valued only at certain special historical moments.*
3. *Illusion must be sharply distinguished from illusionism.*
4. *Illusion is to illusionism as*
   forgery is to imitation
   errore *is to* similitude
   delusion is to illusion
   "the real" is to realism
   realism is to surrealism
   ideology is to art
   machine is to (self)conscious being
   animal is to human
5. *Illusionism cannot be sharply distinguished from illusion: surrealism parodies realism; realism mocks the real; forgery is imitation; art is ideology; consciousness is a machine; humans are animals.*
6. *Illusionism is itself an illusion of play, freedom, and mastery of illusion.*
7. *Illusion is possible in all the senses and media. Optical illusion is the fetish of illusion-theory.*
8. *The notion of a theory of illusion is the last illusion of theory.*
9. *Illusion isn't everything; and vice versa.*

Illusion: An Illustration

The problem of aesthetic illusion may be brought into focus by an image that is neither illusory nor aesthetic (figure 69), a joke by cartoonist Roger Bollen that I'm not sure I understand.[1] We are shown

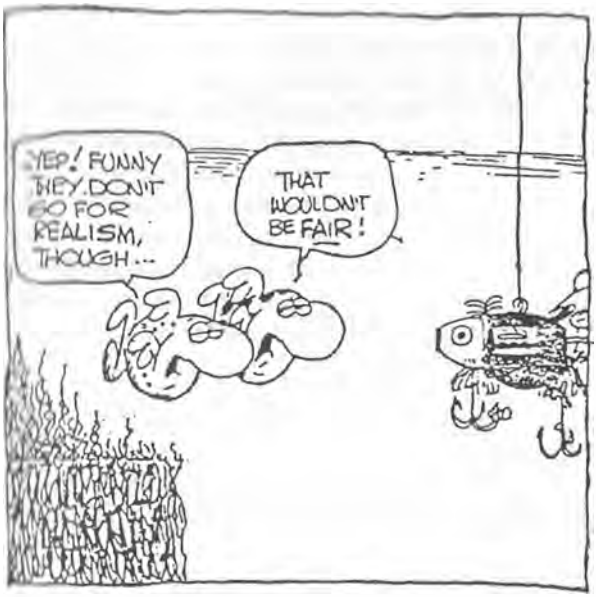
1. The cartoon ran in the *Chicago Tribune,* 17 February 1983.

a moment in the conversation of two rather bored looking fishes who are swimming past a highly ornamented lure. " . . . Yep! Funny they don't go for *realism,* though . . . " says the fish on the left. "That wouldn't be *fair*!" replies the fish on the right. The fish on the left is the art critic: he recognizes the lure for what it is, a sculptural representation in a particularly ineffective style (nonrealistic, nonillusionistic). The fish on the right is the moral philosopher. He says that realism wouldn't be "fair," that it would not, I suppose, be "sporting" to make a lure that was too accurate an image of a bait fish.

But what exactly is funny about this scene? Is it just the image of fish as intellectuals? Would it be as funny to reverse the metaphor and depict intellectuals as fish? Or is there something more, something in the content of what they are saying, something which takes the question seriously? Why is it "funny," that is, odd, strange that fishermen "don't go for realism"? What makes this remark truly odd is that, as any fisherman will tell you, they make every effort to go for realism. They don't want to give the fish a sporting chance, a chance to exercise choice, judgment, or intellectual discrimination of the kind we see here. They want the damn fish to bite, and they'll stop at nothing to tempt them—including the fabrication of highly artificial and expensive lures that look more like mobile chandeliers than fish. The baroque creation hanging in front of our two bored fish (who are themselves presented, by the way, with highly unrealistic eyelids) is some fisherman's conception of what he thinks will look realistic to a fish.

Bollen's cartoon is funny, I suspect, because it sends two absolutely contrary messages about visual communication and representational illusion. It says, on the one hand, that realism is universal and natural—that what looks like a fish to human beings will also look that way to fish and that a lure that isn't realistic enough to fool a person will have a tough time fooling a fish. On the other hand, it is saying that realism is absolutely conventional and artificial—that realism is a question of tricks, devices, and other lures and not of any universal standard. What is at issue in realism is how things appear, not how they are. Realism in this view becomes simply one style of representation, functionally related to a goal—in this case, the catching of fish.

Bollen's joke is hard to get, I suspect, because it is on *us* as beholders. It lures us into the trap of a paradox, revealing us to ourselves as caught in contradictory attitudes about images. If we take the "naive realist" view of the image and replace the ornamented lure with a



69. Roger Bollen, *Animal Crackers Cartoon.* Reprinted by permission: Tribune Media Services.

realistic imitation of a bait fish, we are "caught" violating the most ordinary, empirical commonsense lore of fishing—that fish have their own standards of realism, and those standards are not ours. (Try putting a realistic photograph of a worm on a hook and see how many fish bite at it.) If we take the "sophisticated conventionalist" view of the cartoon, we still have to explain why some conventions *work* and others don't. And that question takes us away from our own values and goals, right back into a realm we can only call "nature," a region which seems to impose independent constraints on our conventions.

Looking at Animals Looking

Roger Bollen is not the first to illustrate the paradoxes of pictorial illusionism by portraying animals looking at man-made images. Stories of animals responding to works of art are so widely disseminated that they seem to have a kind of legendary status, occupying a shadowy territory between fact and fiction that is uncannily like the problem of illusion itself. Leonardo da Vinci compiled a number of such stories to support his claim that painting is superior to poetry because it is a "natural" and scientific medium that produces true representa-

tions of the visible world. The proof of painting's "truth" is that it "even deceives animals, for I have seen a picture that deceived a dog because of the likeness to its master . . . likewise I have seen a monkey that did an infinite number of foolish things with another painted monkey."[2] The "truth" in painting is verified by its ability to deceive animals, a power which can also be exercised over human beings. "Men," Leonardo continues, "fall in love with a painting that does not represent any living woman," and they may be "excited to lust and sensuality" by the vivid illusion of lewd scenes. The most potent illusion of all is the ability of images to lure men into idolatry, a power which is unavailable, in Leonardo's view, to textual representation:

> If you, poet, describe the figure of some deities, the writing will not be held in the same veneration as the painted deity, because bows and various prayers will continually be made to the painting. To it will throng many generations from many provinces and from over the eastern seas, and they will demand help from the painting and not from what is written. (I:22)

The paradoxical relation of truth and error in visual images may seem to be unraveled by segregating the separate aspects of the image's activity. The "error," we want to say, is not the painter's, but the beholder's: the dog, not the master, is taken in by the illusion of the master. The monkey may do foolish things with a painted monkey, but it would take a more powerful illusion to make monkeys out of men.

The only problem with this distinction between the human painter's truth and the animal beholder's illusion is that the oppositions it relies on (human/animal; painter/beholder) are quite independent of the distinction between seeing an image truly (that is, "as such") and being "taken in" by an image. Being an artist is no defense against falling for an illusionistic representation, as the Pygmalion myth reminds us. What does seem to be secure, or at least stable, in the relation between pictorial truth and illusion, is its mapping onto a self/other relationship characterized by inequality in power, self-consciousness, or self-control. Leonardo's sequence of examples (dog versus master; monkeys versus men; lustful men versus chaste men) culminates in an implicit social distinction between the cosmopolitan Venetian and his others—the "foreigners" and "provincials" ("from many provinces and from over the eastern seas") who will be taken

2. Leonardo da Vinci, *Treatise on Painting,* translated by A. P. McMahon, 2 vols. (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1956), I:22.

in by the image and fall into idolatry. The paradoxical weave of truth and illusion is grounded in this structure of alterity: the Self is that which sees, not only the truth *in* an illusion, but that it is to be seen *as* an illusion; the Other is the one *taken in* by the illusion, failing to see it (truly) as an illusion and mistakenly taking it for the reality it (truly) represents.

I hope these examples have convinced you of at least two things: first, that the problem of illusion, aesthetic or otherwise, is not to be settled by a one-sided explanation based on either naturalistic or conventionalist accounts of perception and representation; second, that this problem is deeply interwoven with structures of power and social otherness. The centrality of animals to the examples suggests just how radical this otherness may be, how deeply linked with motives of domination, enslavement, and violence, as indicated by the frequent metaphors of illusionistic "capture" and "taking in." In his classic essay, "Why Look at Animals?" John Berger has argued that the relation of humans and animals is deeply inscribed in the mythical origins of both painting and metaphor: "The first subject matter for painting," he notes, "was animal. Probably the first paint was animal blood. Prior to that, it is not unreasonable to suppose that the first metaphor was animal."[3]

But what is the function of this painting and this metaphor, this doubling of visual and verbal likeness? At a minimum, the dominion of humanity over nature, figured in the animal-versus-human; at a maximum, the dominion of one human over another, expressed by the figure "man-*as*-animal." Animals stand for all forms of social otherness: race, class, and gender are frequently figured in images of subhuman brutishness, bestial appetite, and mechanical servility. Animals have endured, as Berger shows, a history of progressive marginalization which parallels the history of political economy. This reduction of the animal is part of the same process as that by which humans have been reduced to isolated productive and consuming units.

> Indeed . . . an approach to animals often prefigured an approach to man. The mechanical view of the animal's work capacity was later applied to that of workers. F. W. Taylor who developed the "Taylorism" of time-motion studies and "scientific management of industry" proposed that work must be "so stupid" and so phlegmatic that he (the

3. John Berger, *About Looking* (New York: Pantheon Books, 1980), p. 5; further page references will be cited in the text.

> worker) "more nearly resembles in his mental make-up the ox than any other type." Nearly all modern techniques of social conditioning were first established with animal experiments. (p. 11)

As figures in scenes of visual exchange, animals have a special, almost magical relation with humanity. Animals can see what we see; they can look us in the eye across a gulf unbridged by language: "a power is ascribed to the animal, comparable with human power, but never coinciding with it. The animal has secrets which, unlike the secrets of caves, mountains, seas, are specifically addressed to man" (p. 3). These secrets become accessible in the moment when the animal is caught in the act of looking at man-made illusions and responding to them as if they were real and natural. This moment provides humanity with a double revelation and reassurance—that human representations are true, accurate, and natural (the animals "agree" and "comprehend" them of their own accord), and that human power over others is secured by mastery of representations (the animals are *forced* to agree, not of their own accord, but automatically).

Most accounts of aesthetic illusion keep these rather atavistic matters at bay by insisting on the radical difference between animal and human responses to images.[4] Even Ernst Gombrich, who uses the conclusions of animal behaviorists extensively in his studies of illusion, always draws up short, denying indignantly that he is "reducing" the problem of illusion to the reaction of a fish snapping at a fly. But there is one writer I know of who is notoriously unembarrassed by the equation of animal and human responses to aesthetic illusion, and that is the Roman historian Pliny, who recorded probably the single most famous anecdote of animals looking at pictures. Parrhasius, a painter in Periclean Athens

> entered into a competition with Zeuxis, who produced a picture of grapes so successfully represented that birds flew up to the stage-buildings; whereupon Parrhasius himself produced such a realistic picture of a curtain that Zeuxis, proud of the verdict of the birds, requested that the curtain should now be drawn and the picture displayed; and when he realized his mistake, with a modesty that did him honor

4. Jacques Lacan's discussion of the mirror-stage, for instance, moves from a description of the behavior of a chimpanzee to that of a human child, but insists on the lack of a symbolic system in the animal. See *The Four Fundamental Concepts of Psychoanalysis,* translated by Alan Sheridan (Hammondsworth, England: Penguin Books, 1979), p. 107.

he yielded up the prize, saying that whereas he had deceived birds Parrhasius had deceived him, an artist.[5]

This scene is often cited as an example of what Norman Bryson calls "the Natural Attitude" toward images, a naive notion of mimesis that Bryson traces from "innocent or Plinian vision" right down to Ernst Gombrich.[6] This naive view of pictorial representation needs to be replaced, in Bryson's view, with a sophisticated, historical account based in semiotic conventionalism ("painting as an art of signs, rather than percepts" [p. xii]) and materialism (painting as a material practice rather than a system of ideal illusions). While I'm basically sympathetic to this agenda, I think it makes a crucial strategic error in bracketing off the tradition which links Pliny to Gombrich as a naive or innocent past to be supplanted by a sophisticated present and in figuring this methodological shift as a move from percepts to signs, idealizations to material practices. I suspect that this shift really isn't possible and that it has mainly a rhetorical function in the arguments of sophisticated commentators. More important, I think the commonplace notion of "Plinian vision" as "innocent" is based on a failure to attend to the nuances of the anecdote of the birds in the context of his *Natural History*.[7]

5. Pliny, *Natural History*, 10 vols., translated by H. Rackham (Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 1952), 9:310–11; [*descendisse hic in certamen cum Zeuxide traditur et, cum ille detulisset uvas pictas tanto successu, ut in scaenam aves advolarent, ipse detulisse linteum pictum ita vertate repraesenta, ut Zeuxis alitum iudicio tumens flagitaret tandem remoto linteo ostendi picturam atque intellecto errore concederet palmam ingenuo pudore, quoniam ipse volucres fefelisset, Parrhasius autem se artificem.*].

6. Norman Bryson, *Vision and Painting: The Logic of the Gaze* (New Haven, CT: Yale University Press, 1983), p. 34; further page references will be cited in the text. Bryson suggests that "the only significant difference between Pliny and Gombrich . . . is that whereas for Pliny the encounter [with visual reality] is continuous, for Gombrich it is intermittent."

7. Indeed, one might say that Pliny's *Natural History* has scarcely been "read" at all, except as a storehouse of anecdotes and bad Latin, or as a "literary monstrosity," in the words of A. Locher. This situation is now beginning to change, at least with regard to the scientific and literary, if not artistic, material in Pliny's text. See Locher's "The Structure of Pliny the Elder's Natural History," in *Science in the Early Roman Empire: Pliny the Elder, His Sources and Influence*, edited by Roger French and Frank Greenaway (Totowa, NJ: Barnes & Noble, 1986), pp. 20–29.

The anecdote is notable for the dignity afforded to those who fall into *errore* (illusion). Unlike Leonardo, for instance, Pliny presents "being taken in" as consistent with a kind of judgment. Zeuxis attributes to the birds a "verdict" (*iudicio*), and when he himself is taken in, he reacts judiciously, accepting defeat gracefully, with a "modesty that did him honor." Although Zeuxis suggests that there is an important difference between deceiving birds and deceiving an artist, there is no radical, incomprehensible gulf between the two deceptions: birds and men participate in the same contest, and the birds deliver a verdict. The difference between animal and human judgment is the difference between the grapes and the curtain: in the one case, the lure is what is depicted, the illusion of grapes presented by the painting; in the other, the lure is precisely what is *not* depicted, what remains invisible in the illusion, forever concealed behind the curtain. Zeuxis does not reach out to feel the curtain, to verify it by touch: he asks for its removal, for the display of the picture beneath. Animals may be taken in by the illusions of humans, but humans are animals capable of taking themselves in. Does this make humans superior or inferior to animals?[8] Zeuxis swells with pride (*tumens*) as he receives the verdict of the birds and yields with a "noble shame" (*concederet . . . ingenuo pudore*) at the discovery of his own error. The relation of artists to animals here is far too complicated to be summarized by the familiar oppositions of "brute" or "mechanical" nature to the self-consciousness of human beings, what Berger calls the "post-Cartesian" view of animals.

The dignity of the birds is consistent with their role as omens and prophetic signs in Roman culture (the word *avis* means "omen" or "portent" as well as "bird"), and Pliny will have them testify to the power of painting several times in his history. The birds not only fly up to Zeuxis' grapes, they try to alight on the roof tiles in Claudius Pulcher's scene-paintings, and they are frightened by the painted serpents of Lepidus. The most impressive display of animal judgment in Pliny is Apelles' triumph as a painter of Alexander the Great's horses. Apelles "had some horses brought and showed them their pictures one by one; and the horses only began to neigh when they saw the horse painted by Apelles" (9:331). This anecdote illustrates, not the

8. Lacan's reading of this fable reinforces the distinction between human and animal, between the *trompe l'œil* and the natural function of the lure. See *The Four Fundamental Concepts of Psychoanalysis*, pp. 111–12, and Mary Ann Doane's excellent discussion in "The Moving Image," *Wide Angle* 7:1 and 2 (1985): 42–57.

deception of horses, but their good judgment, a form of equine connoisseurship responsive to the dignity of the artist's identity as well as his skill. As a member of the Equestrian class, the second rank of Roman aristocracy, Pliny was in a position to understand the dignity of horses, both their own and the kind they confer on men.

I take it as axiomatic that there is no way to disprove these stories: they are presented as fact, but they could very well be folklore. There are animal behaviorists engaged, no doubt, at this very moment in trying to ascertain just what sorts of pictorial illusions will stimulate responses from various kinds of animals, and it wouldn't surprise me to learn that some animals respond to the objects in some pictures as if they were really there. Our only recourse with Pliny is to take the stories as undecidably true and untrue, that is, as rhetorical illusions which, like pictorial ones, inhabit a dialectical realm of illusion*ism*, on the boundary between fact and fiction. Our attention shifts, then, from the question of whether the stories are true, to the question of their function in Pliny's text. Why does he tell these stories? Are they supposed to support a view of the painter's work, as Bryson argues, exclusively oriented toward the "transcendent and immutable given" (p. 5) of nature, a realm that negates "history" (p. 3) and depicts that painter's work as "carried out in a social void" (p. 6)?

I think not. While Pliny suggests that painterly illusion may be *adjudicated* by the natural (in the form of animal testimony), its purpose and history is not determined by nature. Pliny repeatedly emphasizes the social and political function of illusionistic painting, its role in the continuity of the state and the social order. It is easy to forget that Pliny was writing about illusionistic painting as a cultural practice that had fallen into disuse and low esteem in his own time. "Painting," he says, is

> an art that was formerly illustrious, at the time when it was in high demand with kings and nations and when it ennobled others whom it deigned to transmit to posterity. But at the present time it has been entirely ousted by marbles, and indeed finally also by gold. (vol. 9, p. 261)

For Pliny, the chief purpose of illusionistic painting is not the deception of birds or men, but the bequeathing of illustrious "nobility" from one generation to the next through the accurate portrayal of the face:

> The painting of portraits, used to transmit through the ages extremely correct likenesses of persons, has entirely gone out. Bronze shields are

> now set up as monuments with a design in silver, with only a faint difference between the figures; heads of statues are exchanged for others, about which before now actually sarcastic epigrams have been current: so universally is a display of material preferred to a recognizable likeness of one's own self. And in the midst of all this people tapestry the walls of their picture-galleries with old pictures, and they prize the likenesses of strangers, while as for themselves they imagine that the honour only consists in the price. . . . Consequently nobody's likeness lives and they leave behind them portraits that represent their money, not themselves. (9:263)

For Pliny, the history of painting is not explained by its relation to the natural, but to the progress of political economy. Illusionism begins at a precise historical moment, at the height of Athenian imperial power. "The first artist to give realistic presentation of objects" is Apollodorus, a contemporary of Pericles. Illusionism declines in Pliny's own lifetime: the emperor Augustus is the last to observe "the dignity of this now expiring art," which has been replaced by what we would now call a fetishism of materials—a new kind of illusionism in which money replaces men. The development of illusionistic painting doesn't simply "reflect" the bygone era of national and imperial greatness; it is the medium or apparatus for reproducing political and social identity in the individual and the collectivity. Pliny continually stresses the public function of art, its role in political propaganda and mass spectacle. "The dictator Caesar . . . gave outstanding public importance to pictures"; Agrippa gives a speech "on the question of making all pictures and statues national property" (p. 279); Hostilius Mancinus wins election to a consulship by "displaying in the forum a picture" of his role in the siege of Carthage (p. 277). The "ungracious Tiberias" and the immoral Nero, by contrast, allow the art to fall into disuse or outright abuse. Nero commissions a portrait of himself on a linen sheet 120 feet high which promptly receives its own natural verdict: it is struck by lightning.

Pliny's sense of the political authority of painting goes well beyond the propagating of noble genealogy or state propaganda. Painting is presented as a restraint and discipline of power as well as an instrument of it, a way of introjecting the master-servant relationship into the sovereign. A painting by Protogenes saves the city of Rhodes from being burned to ground by King Demetrius, and Apelles has "so much power" (p. 325) over Alexander the Great ("who was otherwise of an irascible temper") that he teaches the monarch to "conquer himself" and (in a rather unmagical version of the Pygmalion story)

to give the painter his favorite mistress after she poses as his Aphrodite. So great is the painter's authority that it can be exercised, finally, without any actual deployment of illusionistic technique. The mere suggestion of the painter's power, as indicated in his characteristic line, mark, or signature, is even more potent than its actual exercise in a finished illusion. The most esteemed painting of Apelles is virtually empty:

> on its vast surface containing nothing else than the almost invisible lines, so that among the outstanding works of many artists it looked like a blank space, and by that very fact attracted attention and was more esteemed than any masterpiece. (9:323)

Given this sort of power over men and monarchs, it is no wonder that it was "forbidden that slaves be instructed" in the art, that it "consistently had the honour of being practised by people of free birth, and later on by persons of station" (9:319).

The relation between master and slave translates into social terms the basic power relations Pliny discovers in the contrast between human and animal responses to painting. Animals are "taken in" by the image, enslaved by it at the same time they are brought closer to humans; they are in a paradoxical state of illusion as *errore* and *iudicio,* a mistake which is simultaneously a true judgment, a slavery which is based in a free, natural judgment. Humans, by contrast, "take in" the image with self-conscious awareness that it is only an image. At rare moments a masterful artist like Parrhasius may "take in" his fellow artist with a *trompe-l'œil;* it is always possible for painting to turn humans into animals, to make them react to an illusion like slaves (or animals) to a master. But the proper use of painting among free citizens is as a "liberal science" (*liberalium*), an art of illusion*ism,* not illusion, which frees the beholder's faculties, transmits power to the beholder so that he may "conquer himself," enslave himself. This is what we would call "aesthetic illusion," or (in Murray Krieger's terms) "self-referential illusion."[9]

What tends to be forgotten in accounts of aesthetic illusion that celebrate its freedom and "autonomy" as a cultural practice is the connection between this freedom and social power. "Connection" is too weak a term: the freedom epitomized in the aesthetic illusion is predicated on power over others, just as the truth of the illusion

9. See Murray Krieger, "Literature as Illusion, as Metaphor, as Vision," in *Poetic Presence and Illusion* (Baltimore, MD: Johns Hopkins University Press, 1979), pp. 188–96.

is predicated on its capacity to produce error in others. Illusion and illusionism stand in a dialectical relationship of absolute opposition and mutual mimicry. The opposition of illusionism to illusion is that of human to animal, self-conscious being to machine, master to slave. These relations of power and domination must be continually invoked to reinforce the sense of freedom associated with aesthetic illusion and simultaneously forgotten or repressed so that this freedom can be represented as autonomous, slavery represented as freely chosen. That is why Pliny's stories of the power of illusion are bracketed as "naive" and removed from their context in the history of Greek and Roman politics: they insist on bringing back together what we would like to keep apart—freedom and power, illusionism and illusion, aesthetic "autonomy" and social "discipline." Pliny forces us to read the "natural history" of art, that is, its history as an apparatus of ideology, a history where nature and convention, percept and sign cannot be kept apart.[10]

Our modern Pliny, I want to suggest, is Ernst Gombrich. Gombrich inverts Pliny's priorities: instead of nesting the problem of pictorial illusion inside a densely woven material, social, and cultural history, Gombrich makes the history of pictorial illusion the framework through which all other history may be seen. What the two writers share is the conviction that illusion provides the link between history and nature. Like Pliny, Gombrich has two contradictory accounts of the meaning of pictorial illusion, one based in "nature," cognitive science, and experiments with animals, the other based in a conventionalist rhetoric which treats illusion as a historically specific cultural

10. It is worth noting that Pliny's history not only embeds painting in a social, political history, but in a history of materials and technology as well. At least half of his discussion is devoted to the materials of pigment and painting technology. The history of painting emerges in the midst of a sequence of volumes devoted to the mining of minerals, gems, and rare earths. Alongside Pliny's celebration of painting as the ideological apparatus of Greek and Roman nationalism is a darker story which connects the mining of gold with the degradation of nature and the rise of luxury, a story in which painting figures as simply another wealthy, luxurious object: "We trace out all the fibres of the earth . . . marvelling that occasionally she gapes open or begins to tremble—as if forsooth it were not possible that may be an expression of the indignation of our holy parent! . . . Alas for the prodigality of our inventiveness! In how many ways have we raised the prices of objects! The art of painting has come in addition, and we have made gold and silver dearer by means of engraving! Man has learned to challenge nature in competition!" (9:5).

practice.[11] Unlike Pliny, Gombrich is not explicit about the political and social function of illusionism. In recent writings, however, as Gombrich has reacted more and more strongly against what he sees as the "relativist" and "conventionalist" consensus of contemporary criticism, he has tended to fall back more fully on the one-sided naturalist account and, in the process, to make the ideological implications of his position clearer. In his naturalist guise, Gombrich treats illusionistic images as a special class of representations grounded in biological, wired-in mechanisms of perception that are shared by all cultures and by the higher animals. These images can be more or less sharply distinguished from "conventional" images which approach the condition of language. The two classes of images are exemplified at various times by the difference between Western and Oriental painting, between ancient or primitive and "modern" (that is, from the Renaissance through the nineteenth century) painting, or between photography (the "scientific image") and "hand-made" images like drawings and paintings.

As this list of paired examples suggests (and as Gombrich himself sometimes admits), the nature/convention distinction is a shifting and incoherent one; at best, it serves as a rhetorical trope to mark a distinction of degree between "more" and "less" illusionistic images, with illusionism understood as something like "ease of recognition" of the represented motif. At its "worst," or most insidiously effective level, this trope reinforces a host of ideological oppositions that pit Western-ness, modernity, and scientific truth against the primitive, the non-Western, and the superstitiously archaic. The mastery of "illusion*ism*" in Gombrich's view, is directly proportional to the overcoming of "illusion" in the sense of false belief. Ultimately, this mastery over images is the basis for control over others—the creation of deceptive appearances in the *trompe l'œil,* the perfection of a panopticon

11. See my essay, "Nature and Convention: Gombrich's Illusions," in *Iconology: Image, Text, Ideology* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1986), pp. 75–94. Murray Krieger also discusses the "two Gombrichs," an early "skeptical humanist" who treats pictorial illusion in terms of convention and a later "positive scientist" who privileges natural, biological explanations. See "The Ambiguities of Representation and Illusion: An E. H. Gombrich Retrospective," *Critical Inquiry* 11:2 (December 1984): 181–94. My view is closer to Norman Bryson's thesis of a single Gombrich whose argument "is in open contradiction with itself," (*Vision and Painting,* p. 33) from first to last, but I see Gombrich's deepest loyalties invested in the naturalistic account from the first, and I don't find the contradictions "open," in the sense of being transparent, or easily disentangled.

of surveillance and espionage, the deployment of effective "decoys" and "lures" in advertising, the instantaneous and effortless reproduction of visual reality in the service of voyeuristic gratification (pornography occasionally surfaces as Gombrich's clinching example of the natural image).[12]

What this rather schematic recapitulation cannot capture is the remarkable rhetorical agility which permits Gombrich to carry off this argument, nesting it within other claims and positions that qualify and contradict it in myriad ways. The "shifting" of the nature-convention distinction, for instance, over a whole range of opposed examples (images and texts, photographs and paintings) prevents it from occupying a fixed ground from which it might be dislodged: any example of the "natural image" one finds in Gombrich will, within a few pages, be transformed into a relatively conventional image. Alongside Gombrich's argument for the natural, illusionistic image is an equally powerful and equally compelling argument for the conventionality of all image-making, an argument which stresses the arbitrary making of "schematisms" as a precondition for any "matching" of images against visual appearances, which emphasizes the reliance of pictorial production and consumption on habits and conventions (pictures are made out of other pictures, not out of "reality"), and which appeals to analogies with language to explain the nature of pictures. These, in fact, are the arguments which made Gombrich famous, giving him a claim to be the Saussure of image theory, the creator of a "linguistics of the visual field." To this title we might now add, the Pliny of modern art history, the natural historian of the visual field. If Pliny's is a gloomy Tory history, lamenting the loss of an art that guarantees the continuity of the Roman republic, Gombrich's is a Whig history of scientific, liberal progress, the emancipation of Western civilization from barbarism. That Gombrich's accounts of illusion constantly hearken back to his experiences in World War II as a decoder and interpreter for British Intelligence, using his skills against the Nazi barbarians, is both the clinching rhetorical instance and the historical starting point for his work.

Let me conclude by returning to the theses with which I opened this essay. I cannot expect to have demonstrated any of them in this brief account, but I hope at least to have illustrated their sense.

The first two theses claim that illusion is to illusionism as nature

12. See "Image and Code: Scope and Limits of Conventionalism in Pictorial Representation," in *Image and Code*, edited by Wendy Steiner (Ann Arbor: University of Michigan Press, 1981), pp. 11–42.

is to culture: illusion is something built into the very conditions of sentience and extends from areas of animal behavior such as camouflage and mimicry right into *trompe-l'œil* and ultimately, I want to argue, into the universal structure of ideology or false consciousness. This is illusion as *error,* delusion, or false belief. Illusion*ism,* by contrast, is playing with illusions, the self-conscious exploitation of illusion as a cultural practice for social ends. We have a whole vocabulary of oppositions for keeping illusion and illusionism rigorously distinct from one another; at the same time, we have (as the fourth thesis argues) a whole set of metaphors and practices which tend to collapse them into one another: the phrase "aesthetic illusion" is one such conflation, since (on the logic of strict distinction) the phrase should really be "aesthetic illusion*ism*." The most dramatic form of this collapse is the one which suggests (as per thesis 6) that "illusionism is itself an illusion" in its pretence of freedom without power, its construction of an autonomous realm of play beyond illusion.

The visual fetishism of illusionism is, I hope, clear from the examples of Leonardo, Pliny, and Gombrich. There is nothing in theory to deny that illusion is possible in all the sensory, perceptual, and cognitive modes and that illusionism may be practiced in any medium or system of signs. We have produced, in fact, almost perfect aural illusions in laser disk recordings; phonography is capable of much more perfect simulacra than photography, or even holography. Yet it seems fair to say that aural fetishism is a relatively rare disease, confined to a few audiophiles, while visual fetishism in a culture of television, propaganda, and advertising is endemic, not to say an epidemic in advanced industrial societies.

How can we intervene critically, therapeutically in what is widely perceived as the contemporary epidemic of illusion, the virtual collapse of all distinctions between the aesthetic and the nonaesthetic, the play of what Baudrillard has called "simulacra," which undermine all distinction between illusion and illusionism? Not, my last thesis wants to suggest, by constructing a "theory of illusion" which claims to stand free of the phenomenon it criticizes. The postulation of this sort of theory in experimental psychology is what preserves the delusion that we might finally (as Gombrich puts it) find the "keys to the locks of our senses" by opening up the bodies of animals and probing their perceptual apparatus. (Recent experiments have involved such practices as injecting radioactive and electromagnetic dyes into animal nervous systems to trace the patterns of nerve impulses; "re-wiring" the visual cortex to the ears, and the aural cortex to the eyes of rats; stimulating the brain tissue of chimpanzees to produce hallucina-

tions.) On the side of philosophy and "critical theory," the notion, as Jean-François Lyotard puts it, of a "theoretical-critical *genre* . . . which claims as its object to tell the truth and to dissipate illusions, is a particular case of those genres we usually term literary."[13] Its rhetoric of truth, transparency, and verism is just that, a rhetoric, an art, and not a natural fact guaranteed by its (illusory) self-representation as beyond illusion. The question is whether the understanding of theory as rhetoric, as illusion*ism*, can be taken as an enabling discovery, one which returns us to our positions in the world of illusion, as propagators of ideology who play continually across the boundaries of illusion and illusionism. This is a game for which the rules are now being invented. One rule might be that reality is ruled out: the only weapon against illusion is illusionism. Another might be that we have to learn once more how to look at animals. But perhaps most fundamental would be the rule stated as my final thesis: illusion isn't everything; and vice versa.[14]

13. Jean-Françoise Lyotard, "Theory as Art: A Pragmatic Point of View," in *Image and Code*, edited by Wendy Steiner, p. 71.

14. I would like to thank Bob Kaster, Lauren Berlant, Joel Snyder, and Arnold Davidson for their help with this essay.

REALISM, IRREALISM, AND IDEOLOGY: AFTER NELSON GOODMAN

Then there is the story of the two detectives in the Chicago Police Department. One was a naive realist who believed literally in the copy theory of representation. The other was a sophisticated irrealist who believed in the relativity and arbitrariness of representation. Both detectives, it seems, had to be fired from the force: the realist, because he didn't see any need to arrest a suspect if he already had a mug shot; the irrealist, because once he had a mug shot, he started arresting everyone in sight.

Nelson Goodman's theories of representation have been useful primarily because his relatively neutral or value-free characterizations of symbol types provide a way of measuring the highly charged associations of value in traditional theories. Goodman's distinction between images and texts, for instance, as respectively dense and differentiated systems, offers a clarifying respite from metaphysical distinctions like space and time or nature and convention.[1] The differences between symbolic types become a relative matter, embedded in questions of function, context, and habit, and cease to be a question of essences or absolute categories.

I've always felt, however, that there was a certain price to be paid in the elaboration of what Goodman has called "a neutral comparative study" of artistic media and symbol systems.[2] This essay will try

1. See "Pictures and Paragraphs: Nelson Goodman and the Grammar of Difference," in *Iconology* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1986), pp. 53–74. I am grateful for the advice of Ted Cohen, William Brown, Jay Schleusener, and Joel Snyder on many of the issues in this essay.

2. Nelson Goodman and Catherine Z. Elgin, *Reconceptions in Philosophy & the Other Arts & Sciences* (Indianapolis: Hackett, 1988), p. 31, hereafter

to assess what that price is. I want to ask, first, exactly what is Goodman excluding under the rubric of value? How rigorous are the exclusions, and to what extent are aesthetic, ethical, or political values reintroduced as aspects of an expanded epistemology? How does the neutrality of Goodman's method enable or disable it for inquiries into historical and ideological issues? To what extent do Goodman's self-imposed limits create difficulties, not just in its extension beyond those limits, but in conceptual issues internal to his project?

The main focus for this critique will be Goodman's accounts of realism. My argument will be that realism constitutes an especially vexing problem for Goodman's theory, precisely because it occupies the unstable boundary between what lies inside and outside the scope of that theory. A critique of realism is absolutely fundamental to the internal integrity of Goodman's theory, and yet it seems to resist the kind of systematic account he is able to produce for other problems in symbolism. "Realism, like reality," Goodman concludes, "is multiple and evanescent, and no one account of it will do."[3] The question, then, is whether this negative result "will do" for the problem of realism. My suggestion is that it won't do and that a more satisfactory account of realism requires a breaching of Goodman's self-limitation to a "neutral comparative study" along with a broaching of the issues of value, interest, and power that he attempts to suspend. My conclusion will take something like the form of the following analogy: the issue of realism is to the prospect of a theory of symbols what the problem of ideology is to project of a unified epistemology.

The first question to consider is the scope of Goodman's project, what lies inside and outside the domain of his inquiry. There are three basic subject areas that Goodman routinely excludes from his system:

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cited as "R" with page numbers. I have not attempted to distinguish in the following pages between the positions (or words) of Goodman and Elgin in *Reconceptions*. I take their positions to be, in practice, indistinguishable, and I may occasionally have labeled a passage as written by Goodman when in fact the primary responsibility for its composition was Elgin's. For more general remarks on "comparative methods" and interartistic comparison, see chapter three of this volume.

3. Nelson Goodman, "Realism, Relativism, and Reality," *New Literary History* 14 (1982–83): 269–72. The best survey of the varieties of realism is still Roman Jakobson's classic 1921 essay, "On Realism in Art," in *Language in Literature*, edited by Krystyna Pomorska and Stephen Rudy (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1987), pp. 19–27. I am grateful to Tracy Fernandez for calling this piece to my attention.

values, knowledge, and history. But these are not, I think, excluded in the same way. Values (aesthetic, ethical) are marginalized or subordinated only as a temporary tactic. Although *Languages of Art* may begin with a disclaimer that it will "touch only incidentally on questions of value and offer no canons of criticism" (p. xi), it concludes with a section on the "question of merit" that offers a canon of criticism: "symbolization . . . is to be judged fundamentally by how well it serves the cognitive purpose" (p. 258).[4] This conclusion suggests that aesthetic value has not been abandoned, just shifted into the domain of epistemology. But this shift can't be properly appreciated without noting a related shift in the notion of epistemology itself. The "cognitive" is moved in Goodman's system from the realm of what he calls "knowing" to "understanding." Goodman sees knowledge (and its related notions of "certainty" and "truth") as supplanted in his system by understanding, "adoption" (of provisional terms and accounts), and "rightness" (R, p. 165). This exclusion is not provisional, but fundamental, absolute, and final. Goodman sees himself as overturning a long and deeply entrenched tradition of epistemological realism that draws strength from various alliances in aesthetics and symbol theory ("copy theories" of representation) and commonsensical notions about the world. Although Goodman occasionally engages in rearguard skirmishes with radical skepticism, solipsism, and limitless relativism, situating himself in a middle territory between absolutism and absolute relativism, his main energy is directed against realist epistemology and its cognates in symbol theory. His theory of symbols, in fact, is simply the first phase in a threefold project which aims to reconstitute, not merely our understanding of symbols, but "the very constitution of what is referred to"—the "world" or "worlds" constructed by symbols and, finally, the "conception of philosophy" itself (R, p. 164).

Goodman's exclusion of history from his philosophy is, I think, comparable to Saussure's exclusion of diachronic considerations of linguistic change from the study of language.[5] Like Saussure, Good-

4. Nelson Goodman, *Languages of Art* (Indianapolis: Hackett Publishing Company, 1976). Further references will be cited in the text as "LA."

5. Perhaps the more apt comparison here would trace Goodman's exclusions to the tradition of systematic pragmatism at Harvard associated with C. S. Peirce and C. I. Lewis. Goodman shares especially Lewis's combination of interests in symbolic logic and epistemology and his professional disdain for popular or "public" philosophy. See Bruce Kuklick, *The Rise of American Philosophy* (New Haven, CT: Yale University Press, 1977), p. 561.

man wants a synchronic, systematic map of the fundamental rules and types that operate in all symbolic behavior, in any language, culture, or moment in history: "I am thus concerned with structures rather than origins . . . My subject is the nature and varieties of reference, regardless of how or when or why or by whom that reference is effected."[6] He is not interested in the process of change and treats it with perfunctory formulas of habituation and novelty: conventions become established for the manipulation of symbols; systems acquire authority through habitual use. But human curiosity and love for novelty prevent any particular symbol system from prevailing forever: "practice palls," and some new system that offers "revelation" takes its place. The important thing is that we can never get beyond some symbol system or other, and they all, without exception, require formalizable "routes of reference" (not to be confused with genetic, historical "roots" of reference): that is, systems of notation, conventions of depiction, alphabets, scripts, characters, and other units of significance.

Goodman does for symbols in general, then, what Saussure did for language: transforms them into the objects of a universal science. His decision to begin *Languages of Art* with the problem of representation and depiction, rather than with language, was in this respect, a wonderfully cagey move to outflank the competing paradigm of semiotics, the other "universal science of signs." By starting with the *picture* as the entry point for this science, Goodman took on precisely the kind of sign which had proved irritatingly anomalous for semiotics. As Jonathan Culler noted some time ago, "study of the way in which a drawing of a horse represents a horse is perhaps more properly the concern of a philosophical theory of representation than of a linguistically based semiology."[7] Goodman notes that the word "lan-

6. Nelson Goodman, "Routes of Reference," in *Of Mind and Other Matters* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1984), p. 55.

7. Jonathan Culler, *Structuralist Poetics: Structuralism, Linguistics, and the Study of Literature* (Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press, 1975), pp. 16–17. I don't mean to say, incidentally, that semiotics has nothing to say about pictures, or more generally "icons"; in fact, it has a great deal to say. But much of what it says takes its interest precisely from the friction between the properties of iconicity and the paradigms of language. This friction—the feeling, for instance, that icons may lie partly outside the science of semiotics, that they may be "other" to language, linked to instinct, the unconscious, the body, or other pre- or nonlinguistic domains, is precisely what makes semiotics attuned to problems of history and value in pictorial representation in a way that Goodman may not be.

guages" in the title of *Languages of Art* is only a "vernacular" convenience for what should properly be called "symbol systems." The "vernacular" here is also the prevailing jargon of semiotics, in which language provides the basic model or at least "relay" for all symbolic functions.[8] Goodman uses this vernacular to situate his theory in the proper competitive relation with semiotics (though he never names it) and then immediately retracts the term to indicate his rather different starting point.

We may summarize Goodman's three exclusions then as tactical, absolute, and strategic. Values (at least aesthetic values) are excluded only temporarily, finally to be relocated in the cognitive; ethical and political values, one presumes, would also be ultimately relocated in the cognitive and would grow out of Goodman's picture of human subjects as freely choosing between visions, versions, and systems. Knowledge, truth, and certainty, by contrast, must forever be excluded as absolute error. Realism is wrong and irrealism is right.

History, by contrast, offers another way of being right, but it lies beyond the scope of Goodman's project. All Goodman offers on this front is a binary model of structural change: the static maintenance of the familiar and the disruptive appearance of the novel. This pattern governs Goodman's understanding of the historical position of his own work, as well as the transformations of symbol systems. Irrealism is simultaneously disruptive and familiar: "I have repeatedly had to assail authoritative current doctrine and fond prevailing faith. Yet I claim no outstanding novelty for my conclusions . . . most of my arguments and results may well have been anticipated by other writers" (LA, p. xii). Realism is not just wrong, it is historically obsolete, superseded by the rightness of irrealism, which is not just Goodman's original invention, but the expression of a new consensus: "Nowadays" the "traditional ideologies and mythologies of the arts are undergoing deconstruction and disvaluation, making way for a neutral comparative study" (R, p. 31). Although Goodman is generally critical of deconstruction, which he sees as an unlimited relativism, incapable of discerning rightness, he recognizes it as part of the context which enables his own work.[9] Irrealism overturns "dogma,"

8. See Roland Barthes, *Elements of Semiology*, translated by Annette Lavers and Colin Smith (1968; rpt., New York: Hill and Wang, 1977), pp. 10–11.

9. In Goodman's view, the "freedom" associated with deconstruction "is bought at the price of inconsequence. Whatever may be said counts as a right interpretation of any work" (R, p. 45). Goodman labels his own position

"prevailing faith," "myth," and "ideology," yet it also participates in a new, emergent consensus. It provides, we may say, both a cognitive revelation and a new set of habitual conventions and commonplaces.[10]

It is no criticism of Goodman's work to say that he is more interesting when he is constructing his own positive formalism than when he strays into the territory of history and value. I'm not suggesting that his work is damaged by these exclusions, that he should have paid more attention to these questions. On the contrary, my suggestion is that the less Goodman says about these things, the better. The question is whether he can avoid saying things about them, whether there are forces at work within Goodman's own account of the field of representation that tend to defeat any attempt to construct a "neutral comparative study." Insofar as irrealism "supplants" realism, the answer is clearly no. Like realism, irrealism must overturn superstition and ideology, provide stable cognitive and symbolic categories, and offer revelations of new understanding. Most fundamentally, irrealism, like realism, has to explain everything. The formal theory of symbol systems cannot be bracketed off as a special, limited project, but must take in the totality of cognitive universes. Since Goodman regards the world and cognition as completely mediated by symbol systems, the "languages of art" do not have an ornamental or supplementary relation to epistemology: the new epistemology is constituted by the aesthetic, the semiotic, and the symbolic. "My relativism," he says, "does not stop with representation and vision and realism and resemblance but goes through to reality as well."[11]

Goodman's attack on epistemological realism, then, is inextricably connected with his critique of representational realism, specifically, his well-known assault on resemblance, illusion, and informational accuracy as criteria for aesthetic forms of realism. Since these criteria have been dismissed from the domains of cognition and representation as such, it is not surprising that they would have no place

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"constructive relativism" and sees it as a "third view" that supplants both "absolutism" (or realism) and deconstructive "relativism," occupying a synthetic middle position. "Deconstruction" is thus only "a prelude to *re*construction" (R, p. 45), a passing phase of radical skepticism.

10. It will not escape the alert reader that irrealism's double face as consensual and innovative is a mirror image of Goodman's own account of realism.

11. Nelson Goodman, "Realism, Relativism, and Reality," *New Literary History* 14 (1982–83): 269; further page references will be cited in the text with the abbreviation "RRR."

in the subdomain of *realistic* representation. Goodman treats realism in *Languages of Art* as a "minor question" (p. 34). It comes up, I suppose, just because realistic representation would seem, to common sense, exactly the place where issues of resemblance, illusion, and information might recur, even if they had been dislodged from a more general account of representation. Representation—standing for, denoting, depicting, even "acting for"—can occur in so many patently nonrealistic ways, that common sense might be able to accept Goodman's antirealist account of it, while holding out a special place for realism as an exceptional kind of representation. This is the possibility Goodman needs to block. Realism may be a "minor question," but it would be a major embarrassment to his whole theory if it were allowed to sustain its own account of itself, as a privileged mode of representation that reaches out to the truth of the world, of nature, or the way we see. The relation between realism and irrealism is one of total war. Goodman can't be content, therefore, to simply dismiss realism; he has to have an account of it as a recognizable, conventional mode of representation within his system that will be more powerful than the account given by the realists themselves.

The account of realism in *Languages of Art* might be called "hyperconventional." Realism "depends upon how stereotyped the mode of representation is, upon how commonplace the labels and their uses have become" (p. 36). It is not absolute, but "relative"

> determined by the system of representation standard for a given culture or person at a given time. Newer or older or alien systems are accounted artificial or unskilled. For a Fifth-Dynasty Egyptian the straightforward way of representing something is not the same as for an eighteenth-century Japanese. (p. 37)

All representations are conventional in the sense that they depend upon symbol systems that might, in principle, be replaced by some other system. It looks as if realism is simply the most conventional convention,[12] the most customary custom. "We usually think of paint-

12. All representation is, of course, "conventional" in Goodman's terms, insofar as it depends on symbolic schemes, systems, and rules for reference that are not "given" by nature, but invented by people. Realism is simply the "familiar," or "standard," or "straightforward," or "traditional" mode of representation. Strictly speaking, then, convention is not a matter of degree. I am lapsing here into the vernacular sense of the conventional as the customary or habitual. Goodman flirts with this same lapse in the footnote to page 37 in *Languages of Art*, when he offers to substitute "conventional" for

ings as literal or realistic if they are in a traditional European style of representation" (LA, p. 37) but, Goodman warns, we need to realize that this judgment is "egocentric" (not to say ethnocentric) and that there are other realisms, based in other styles, visions, and constructions of "the real."

There is, however, one class of exceptions to this account of realism, a class that goes directly against Goodman's notion of "standard" realism. "*Most of the time* . . . the traditional system is taken as standard; and the . . . realistic or naturalistic system is simply the customary one" (LA, p. 38; emphasis added). But sometimes "shifts in standard" occur; a "departure from a traditional system" may introduce a "new degree of realism." In a later expansion of this point, Goodman associates this sort of realism with what he calls "revelation."

> Practice palls; and a new mode of representation may be so fresh and forceful as to achieve what amounts to a revelation. This was true for standard Western perspective when it was invented during the Renaissance, and no less true for modes that broke away from that system, such as the Oriental mode when rediscovered by late nineteenth century French painters. (RRR, p. 169)

I see two problems with this account. The first is that it fails to say anything specific to realism. The criteria for realism—that it be the "standard," "familiar," or "habitual" form of representation—are so capacious that many nonrealistic forms of representation would seem to be included. Rococo and mannerist painting, for instance, both employ stylistic and iconographic features that were "standard" and "familiar" in their time (the term "mannerist," in fact, is usually employed to label representational modes that are *excessively* habitual). But neither style counted as "realistic" in its own time. Goodman's own example of "the straightforward way of representing something" for "a Fifth-Dynasty Egyptian" would seem more apt as a counterexample. Egyptian painting is certainly standardized, but does that make it realistic? Cubism is now a familiar, standard style of Western painting, but no one calls it "realistic." One might as well argue that since allegorical and romantic narrative forms were familiar and standard in the Middle Ages, they were the realism of the day.

"traditional" and then draws back: "but 'conventional' is a dangerously ambiguous term: witness the contrast between 'very conventional' (as 'very ordinary') and 'highly conventional' or 'highly conventionalized' (as 'very artificial')."

Indeed, Goodman's sense of realism is so capacious that it looks as if it could apply to a single individual ("the system of representation standard for . . . a *person*"), a formulation that suggests the possibility of a private realism. Custom and habit and standardization would seem at best to be *necessary* conditions for realism (as for any enduring mode of representation), but not sufficient conditions. To conclude, as Goodman does, that "realism is a matter of habit" is to say nothing special about realism.

The second problem is Goodman's bifurcated account of realism as "most of the time" familiar and traditional, but "sometimes" novel and revelatory. Goodman can have it both ways only by introducing a specification that lies outside his own synchronic formalism, the dimension of time and history. Realism is the familiar at time T_1; it is the unfamiliar at time T_2. These temporal dimensions, moreover, are not simply homogeneous, quantifiable measures of chronology. T_1 is a long time, something like a period, an era, or an epoch. T_2 is a short time, a moment or a critical event in history.[13] As long as Goodman is talking about representation more generally, he doesn't need these mini-narratives. He can be content with a synchronic mapping of the "routes of reference" and ignore the genetic "roots" while mounting a formidable attack on copy theories of representation and their realistic connotations. As long as Goodman is attacking realism he is fine; when he has to provide a positive account of it, however,

13. The obvious (perhaps the *only*) example that fulfills all these conditions is artificial perspective. It begins (or at least represents itself as beginning) in revelation *ex novo* at a specific moment (Alberti's *De Pictura,* 1435) and lives on in routine and continued revelation. It becomes a standard mode of representation not just for artists, but for engineers, scientists, photographers, and surveyors, and it even becomes understood as an equivalent for natural, universal visual experience (an argument made familiar by Gombrich). Its "standardization" is sustained, not just by traditional practices and habits, but by rational measurement and scientific method (in this sense, it might be distinguished from the representational standards of Byzantine painting, which endured with little variation for hundreds of years and certainly made strong claims to be a "revelation" of "the real" in some form, but grounded its claims in religious tradition rather than scientific method). Perspectival realism clinches its hold on "the real" by becoming the key principle in the apparatus of mass, global visual communication (film, photography, and television) in the twentieth century. I owe this point to discussions with Rob Nelson of the Art Department of University of Chicago. See also Martin Jay, "Scopic Regimes of Modernity," in *Vision and Visuality,* edited by Hal Foster (Seattle, WA: Bay Press, 1988), pp. 3–23.

his theory transgresses its own boundaries. Were it not for the intrinsic interest of these vulnerable moments, one would be tempted to say that Goodman would have been better off never to write the section on realism in *Languages of Art* or the essay on "Realism, Relativism, and Reality." Or rather, one could wish for an explanation of why a positive account of realism, one that would explain realism to the realists better than their own account, is rigorously excluded from his system. The short way to do this would have been to consign realism to the dustbin of history. A longer route would have required that Goodman show why realism, as distinct from a general theory of representation, is strictly unformalizable within a synchronic system.

That Goodman, with all his rigor and self-consciousness about limitations, domains, and scope, could not resist the temptation to project his theory beyond its proper domain is perhaps testimony to the insatiability of theorizing as a rhetorical mode. The move from *Languages of Art* to *Ways of Worldmaking* indicates, in the very terms of the titles, something of this totalizing ambition. By the end of Goodman's most recent book, the limited attempt to produce a comparative theory of symbols has become a global project:

> We work *from* a perspective that takes in the arts, the sciences, philosophy, perception, and our everyday worlds, and *toward* better understanding of each through significant comparison with the others. . . . The present *third* phase starts from the realization that the prevailing conception of philosophy is hopelessly deficient when all fields of cognition, symbols of all kinds, and all ways of referring are taken into account. (R, p. 164)

The sound of "all" casts a pall over Goodman's practice, but it does not, I think, vitiate the insights of his theory in a more limited domain. Nothing I have said really contests Goodman's demolition of the copy theory of representation; the negative force of his critique remains as formidable as ever.[14] What we need at this point is a positive account of realism that registers the force of Goodman's critique without extending it beyond its proper domain.

14. In a reply to this essay, Catherine Elgin reads my argument as a claim that "indifference to history vitiates Goodman's aesthetics." My own view is that this indifference to anything but a formal notion of the historical is precisely what gives Goodman's work its distinctive power. See Elgin's "What Goodman Leaves Out," *Journal of Aesthetic Education* 25:1 (Spring 1991): 89–96, and my rejoinder, "Reply to Catherine Elgin," *Journal of Aesthetic Education* 25:4 (Winter 1991): 137–39.

Let us return, first, to Goodman's critique of the copy theory of representation. The key move in this critique is the debunking of resemblance as either a necessary or sufficient condition for representation. Goodman argues that many things resemble each other that don't represent each other, and vice versa: "no degree of resemblance is sufficient to establish . . . reference" by itself. "Nor is resemblance *necessary* for reference" (LA, p. 5). In place of the phenomenon of resemblance, Goodman treats representation as simply a form of denotation, a use of something to stand for something else. "Denotation" is thus the core of representation, a practical activity of using things to refer to other things, and this practice is independent of resemblance. I can use the saltshaker on my table to represent, that is, to denote, a man or a mountain, and this usage is quite independent of any prior condition of resemblance.

But Goodman's exclusion of resemblance from his account of representation, like so many of his exclusions, is not so absolute as it might seem. Resemblance (and the related notion of illusion or "deceptiveness") re-enter the picture once a representational practice has been inaugurated: "Resemblance and deceptiveness, far from being constant and independent sources and criteria of representational practice are to some degree products of it" (LA, p. 39). Although Goodman seems here to be reiterating the exclusion of resemblance, he is actually making a startling concession that is elaborated in the accompanying footnote:

> Neither here nor elsewhere have I argued that there is no constant relation of resemblance; judgments of similarity in selected and familiar respects are, even though rough and fallible, as objective and categorical as any that are made in describing the world. (p. 39)

The only time that resemblance (and perhaps illusion) could fail to be crucial to a representational practice would be prior to its institution. As long as the saltshaker isn't being used to represent anything, its resemblance to any possible referent (except possibly other saltshakers) is invisible and irrelevant. But as soon as we use the saltshaker to represent a man or a mountain, considerations of resemblance begin to surface. We start to think of the top as "like" a head, the sides as resembling a body; or we imagine a tiny climber struggling up the slippery, precipitous slopes. The placement of resemblance as a product rather than a precondition of representation loses much of its radicality when we realize that, even within Goodman's own system, there is no world or worlds of any sort prior to representation. All realities, experiences, cognitions (including the experience of like-

ness) are products of representational practices. Representation and resemblance and illusion are always already with us, late and soon.[15]

That does not mean that realism is always with us. Realism emerges in this modified account as a use of representation by resemblance to say how things are. Realism is thus representation plus a belief system, and the beliefs may refer either to the representational mode or to what it represents. That is why (for the proper belief system) a picture of a unicorn may be realistic and denote something real. For another system (our own) it might simply be a realistic unicorn picture and denote absolutely nothing. The saltshaker may be a long way from realistically representing a man, but that distance cannot be measured by an account of its formal features of referentiality or by an assessment of its familiarity or novelty.[16]

It is tempting to suppose that realism might be located in degrees of resemblance produced by representation. Goodman's notion that representational systems are "dense," "replete," and "continuous," relatively saturated with significant features (in contrast to languages, scripts, and notations), might be thought to offer a continuum between relatively schematic representations (saltshaker as man) and relatively "dense" representations (a photograph of a man which offers infinitely more information about his visual appearance). But realism is not just a formal matter of elaborating further discriminations of resemblance; we can paint eyes on the saltshaker and give it arms and legs without *necessarily* moving toward realism. The move from representation to realism is something like the move from denotation ("this is that") to a certain kind of assertion: the saltshaker has to be used to say "this is how things are" or "this is the way a man really looks." "Representations," as Ian Hacking has argued, "are not in

15. A more formal way to express the irrepressible return of resemblance into Goodman's system is to note that his argument that resemblance is not a "necessary" condition for representation may not be successful. While there are plenty of counterexamples to refute the notion that resemblance is a *sufficient* condition (think of all the things that resemble other things without representing them), it is hard to think of a counterexample for the converse proposition: whenever x represents y, x resembles y. Since Goodman insists that *every* x resembles every y in some respect, this must also be true in the special case of a representational relationship. I owe this point to Ted Cohen.

16. More precisely, an assessment of "familiarity or novelty" would require attention to those "roots of reference" that Goodman has excluded—how or why or when or to whom something is familiar or novel. See p. 348 above, and Goodman's *Of Mind and Other Matters*, p. 55.

general intended to say how it is. They can be portrayals or delights. . . . Pictures are seldom, and statues almost never used to say how things are."[17] Truth, certainty, and knowledge are *structurally connoted* in realistic representation: they constitute the ideology or automatism necessary for it to construct a reality. That is why realism is such an apt vehicle for spreading lies, confusion, and disinformation, for wielding power over mass publics, or for projecting fantasy. The great achievements of modern technologies of representation—propaganda, advertising, surveillance—are scarcely conceivable without modes of realistic representation. Idolatry, in fact, might be regarded as a form of realism *avant le lettre:* the idol is understood as a representation whose likeness guarantees the real presence of the god it represents. When the idolater becomes convinced that the represented god will "have no other gods before it," the special requirements of realism are on the way to being met.

From the standpoint of the philologist, all pre–nineteenth-century forms of realism are *avant le lettre.* As Raymond Williams points out, the term emerges as a label for certain kinds of pictorial and literary representation only in the nineteenth century.[18] But if we relax the philologist's insistence on the literality of realism and attend to the canonical precedents in Western theories of representation, we can go back much further. Western forms of realism have generally grounded their authority in nature and science, not religion. Pliny's account of "verism" in Greek and Roman painting treats it as a technique verified by the responses of animals (the birds flying at Zeuxis' grapes, most famously). But Pliny (as we have seen in the preceding chapter) makes it clear that the purpose of realism is not simply power over nature; verism is a tool of civic and political life, a way of assuring the continuity of the citizen aristocracy by preserving the likenesses of noble individuals and passing them on to succeeding generations.[19] Alberti links realism to perspective by way of the science of optics, but (like Pliny) he regards the truth of visual representation as merely instrumental for a social purpose—the presentation of vivid *historiae,* dramatic scenes of human action. Unlike Pliny, who treats verism as a set of traditional techniques and practices that are in danger of being

17. Ian Hacking, *Representing and Intervening* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1983), p. 138.

18. Raymond Williams, *Keywords: A Vocabulary of Culture and Society,* rev. ed. (New York: Oxford University Press, 1985), s.v. "Realism."

19. See chapter 10, "Illusion: Looking at Animals Looking."

lost, Alberti regards his realism as a rigorous method based on a scientific theory of vision: "we are not writing a history of painting like Pliny," says Alberti, "but treating of the art in an entirely new way."[20] But Alberti's new science of representation, even in its optical foundations, is a political science as well. The famous "visual pyramid" of light rays that constitutes the visual and perspectival field is an image of the ideal political order, a sovereign "centric ray" surrounded on all sides by its "ministers": "this ray alone is supported in their midst, like a united assembly, by all the others, so that it must rightly be called the leader and prince of rays" (p. 45).

The common thread of realist movements in Western painting might, in fact, be identified as the employment of naturally or scientifically authorized representations for social purposes. Nineteenth-century "social realism" in literature and art is perhaps the most explicit example, as (in a quite different way, and with reference to a different science) is "socialist realism." We now live in a time of hyperrealism, in which the technical mastery of illusion and realism is so complete that it offers itself as an aesthetic object in its own right or puts itself at the service of totalizing fantasies. Irrealist epistemology has made its peace with illusionistic technologies of representation, and the result is exemplified best by the multiple ways of world-making offered to the choice of the consumer in the contemporary theme park. At Disney World, for instance, one can travel inside the human body, through outer space, or survive a North Sea storm while never leaving the air-conditioned comfort of Florida. Disney World's wave pool advertises itself as "better than a day at the beach," and its relentless search for a more perfect reality has recently brought it to the attention of the environmentalists. Disney World has been killing off the native Florida buzzards (among other things) in the expansion of its "wilderness" park.

The new terms of the debate between realism and irrealism are dramatized vividly in *Jurassic Park*, a recent novel (and movie) about a theme park in which real, living dinosaurs have been artificially produced by cloning traces of DNA.[21] At one point in the novel, a debate is staged between the park's geneticist, Dr. Henry Wu, and John Hammond, the entrepreneur who has conceived of the park in

20. Leon Battista Alberti, *On Painting and On Sculpture*, edited and translated by Cecil Grayson (London: Phaidon Press, 1972), p. 63.

21. Michael Crichton, *Jurassic Park* (New York: Ballantine Books, 1990); further page references will be cited in the text.

the first place. Hammond is the showman, the P. T. Barnum of *Jurassic Park;* Wu is the scientist who controls the technology behind the scenes. We would expect Hammond to want dinosaurs that obey the rule of illusion—that is, that conform to what spectators expect, that gratify their prejudices, no matter what dinosaurs were *really* like. We would expect Wu to want realistic dinosaurs, not just convincing illusions; a scientist should want to make dinosaurs that correspond as closely as possible to what they were, what they must have been, given the objective constraints of genetics, environment, etc. And yet the debate is staged precisely to reverse these positions. The scientist wants to perfect the dinosaurs, to make them safe for a modern theme park, to make them slower, more stupid, more tractable, more in keeping with our stereotype of creatures destined for extinction. His reasoning is surely sound. First, he points out that "nobody really knows what" the dinosaurs were "really like" (p. 121). When Hammond objects that docile, domesticated dinosaurs "wouldn't be real," Wu replies: "But they're not real now. . . . That's what I'm trying to tell you. There isn't any reality here" (p. 122). The dinosaurs that have been cloned in Dr. Wu's lab are totally "artificial" creatures already. "The DNA of the dinosaurs was like old photographs that had been retouched, basically the same as the original, but in some places repaired and clarified." The image and reality they present are already a product of manipulation: they are palpable, living beings whose relation to "real" dinosaurs is already within a regime of illusion, so that the only question is what illusion we happen to want to present to ourselves, what image will be both safe and attractive to the consumer. Wu is the irrealist who is content to collapse the distinction between realism and illusionism, who believes that realisms are freely chosen ways of world making, that the world and its representations are made not given.

John Hammond, by contrast, has the eagerness and fatality of the realist. Science has made it possible to clone dinosaurs from traces of ancient DNA. The process has produced some creatures that look right and turn out to act in ways more in keeping with the accounts of contemporary paleontology (they are warm-blooded creatures closer to birds than to reptiles). Besides, Hammond is in a hurry to make his theme park operational. The present crop of dinosaurs is not only realistic enough; it is the reality at hand, and the investors are waiting to see a real profit.

The interesting thing about this debate, aside from the reversal of expected positions, is that it stages the oppositions between irrealism and realism as wholly contained within a framework of consumption

and display. Nowhere in this debate is it possible to ask whether it is a good idea to clone dinosaurs in the first place, much less to present them as commodified images in a theme park. The debate is completely contained within the assumptions of specular (and speculative) capitalism. What we display, what we visually produce and consume, may be debatable from a standpoint like "product safety" (a debate rather like the endless and pointless squabbles about whether television and movie violence "causes" violence in the streets), but the specular economy itself cannot be critiqued. It can only be "regulated" or "de-regulated." The public "debate" about *Jurassic Park* the movie is thus mainly about whether children should be allowed to see it, not what it means that adults have produced a film whose special effects for recreating dinosaurs cost "more money . . . than on funding all scientific research on dinosaurs undertaken to date."[22]

Dr. Wu and John Hammond epitomize what might be thought of as the postmodern re-positioning of the venerable debate between irrealism, constructivism, and relativism, and various forms of representational and epistemological realism. It is as if P. T. Barnum were to debate Charles Darwin with all of their assumptions about reality inverted. Wu is the iconoclastic showman, the master of illusions and realisms: he is happy to smash all superstitious notions of "real" resemblance and necessary correspondence between representations and what they represent. For him, the theme park is an infinitely malleable way of world-making. His position reaches its logical extension in the view of Jurassic Park's systems engineer "that the entire world was increasingly described by the metaphor of the theme park" (p. 138).

In *Languages of Art*, Goodman describes his theory of representation as an "iconoclasm," and we may now be in a position to understand the implications of this label. The "icons" that Goodman wants to smash are, at the most general reach of his system, epistemological and representational realisms. At the more specific and technical level of formalizing the concept of representation, the enemy is *resemblance* or, as the semioticians would say, "iconicity." But Goodman is no more capable of eliminating resemblance from his picture of representation than he is of eliminating realism from his account of cognition. Like realism, resemblance is exiled from the system only to come back

22. Pat Dowell, *In These Times* (28 June 1993), p. 33. It hardly needs to be said that Steven Spielberg's *Jurassic Park* eliminates nearly all traces of political or economic debate and confines the narrative strictly to the service of spectacle and speculation.

as its central problem. As with the perfectly engineered cloning of dinosaurs, "real resemblance" has a way of asserting—and reproducing—itself.[23] Goodman's own formal notion of the pictorial as the "undifferentiated" symbol recalls him, by antithesis, to the shattered icon: "Can it be that—ironically, iconically—a ghost of likeness, as nondifferentiation, sneaks back to haunt our distinction between pictures and predicates" (R, p. 131). Like most iconoclasts, Goodman supposes that his critique will take us into a realm of freedom from superstition, ideology, and atavistic beliefs in "natural" or privileged modes of representation: "Representation is thus disengaged from perverted ideas of it as an idiosyncratic physical process like mirroring, and is recognized as a symbolic relationship that is relative and variable" (LA, p. 43). Recognition of the relativity and variability of symbols will, in Goodman's view, overcome the perverse "mirror stage" of realism and liberate us into a cognitive pluralism where "the choice among systems is free" (LA, p. 40).

In the cognitive politics of irrealism, then, understanding rather than truth is what will make us free. Irrealism is a liberalism, however, whose notion of freedom is still quite ambiguous. Is freedom of choice among systems, symbols, and versions an ideal to be achieved by the irrealist critique? A fact about cognition and representation? Or a pragmatic consensus achieved by contemporary forms of relativism and skepticism? The answers to all these questions, at least as provided by Goodman's writing, is simply "yes." Irrealist freedom plays at least three roles: as critical ideal, it motivates the iconoclastic overturning of traditional idols of realism; as a "fact" about "the mind," it aligns irrealism with the authority of cognitive science; as historical consensus, it continues the long love affair between American philosophy (especially the Harvard tradition that goes back to Peirce and William James) and the liberal individualism of American political ideology—a tradition we might call "transcendental pragmatism."[24]

Irrealism's tripartite self-representation as utopian ideal, scientific fact, and historical consensus suggests that, like most ideologies, it is systematically ambivalent about its own "certainty," while relatively certain about its "rightness." This chameleon status is not a weakness,

23. One of the key elements in Jurassic Park's biotechnology is to maintain control of the dinosaurs by cloning all of them as females, thus preventing uncontrolled reproduction. Naturally, this enforced sterility-by-resemblance is the first thing to break down.

24. The term is Ian Hacking's, applied to Hilary Putnam in *Representing and Intervening*.

however; on the contrary, it is precisely what gives irrealism rhetorical power. Any one of irrealism's self-representations would, taken independently, raise questions. Is it a fact that "the mind" freely chooses how it will characterize everything from sensations to worlds? (R, pp. 5–6). Would an irrealist utopia in which this claim were true be desirable? Is American liberalism really the end of history and ideology and the gateway into a postrealist era of freedom? My own view is that the *only* version of irrealism that makes sense is the utopian, iconoclastic one. This is the authentic critical core of irrealism, its power as a negative critique of realism and as a positive, ahistorical account of representational systems. When irrealism strays beyond these boundaries into pronouncements on history, knowledge, and value, it gains rhetorical power at the expense of internal consistency. It becomes, in short, just another ideology, just another realism. Irrealism has a more important role to play, not as a philosophy that "supplants" realism, but as a therapeutic thorn in its side, a way of keeping realism honest. Realism, for its part, cannot be content to make peace with irrealism. That route offers nothing better than the liberality and "free choice" of consumer fantasies exemplified by the new world order of the theme park. Those are real monsters at the gates of *Jurassic Park*.

V·····Pictures·and·the·Public·Sphere

How should we picture the public sphere and the place of visual representation in it? The most comprehensive modern reflection on the public sphere is provided by Jurgen Habermas, who imagines it as a utopian "ideological template" that has survived from Hellenic Greece to the present day.[1] The public sphere is "the sphere of private people come together as a public" (p. 27), "a realm of freedom and permanence" in which public opinion may be formed through the operations of uncoerced reason and free discussion: "only in the light of the public sphere did that which existed become revealed, did everything become visible to all" (p. 4). The specific, concrete model (what Habermas calls the "type of representative publicness") of the public sphere changes, of course, with different social formations. For the Greeks, it was located in the marketplace, the court, or in war or games and was strictly separated from the regime of the *oikos* or private household with its women, children, and slaves; in medieval Germany it was divided between the commons (*publica*) and the feudal court, the sphere of "lordly" authority (*publicus*) (p. 6). While Habermas notes that "sociologically" a public sphere (in the sense of "a separate realm distinguished from the private" [p. 7]) did not exist under feudalism and monarchical absolutism, he notes what might be called

1. Jurgen Habermas, *Structural Transformation of the Public Sphere,* translated by Thomas Burger and Frederick Lawrence (Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 1989); further page references will be cited in the text.

"hyper-publicity" in the emphasis on the public display of lordly power and the staging of ecclesiastical authority.

Habermas's account of the emergence of the "bourgeois public sphere," the Enlightenment model of a literate, freethinking public, and of its endangerment by the emergence of mass culture, the sphere of "commercial industrial publicity," is too well known to retrace here. All I wish to note at this point are two consistent features in Habermas's "ideological template"—the emphasis on visual representation and uncoerced discussion. The template of the public sphere might be described as a theatrical/architectural imagetext, an openly visible place or stage in which everything may be revealed, everyone may see and be seen, and in which everyone may speak and be heard. The public sphere, in short, is a kind of utopian counterpart to the pictures of power we have just been contemplating. It imagines a place outside the realm of power and special interests, a place of freedom from power. If power is depicted by figures of coercion, domination, and resistance, the public sphere is imagined as a scene of free conversation. Foucault's panopticon of total surveillance is matched by Habermas's forum or civic plaza, with its spectacle of free public access.

The convergence of these two forms of visual culture was imagined with vivid precision in the figure of the telescreen in George Orwell's *1984*. The telescreen is a two-way medium, broadcasting political propaganda (most notably the spectacular images of war "news" to stir up hate against the enemy) while simultaneously serving as an instrument of public surveillance.

Combining the panopticon and the public spectacle, the telescreen effectively eliminates the boundary between the public and private spheres. Forms of resistance to this culture of total publicity are staged as futile efforts to retreat into a nonexistent privacy or into archaic refuges (the proletarian quarter and the countryside). It is not just that Winston Smith's efforts at rebellion against Big Brother are finally defeated. They are ultimately revealed as having been illusory all along. Smith's "resistances"—his retreat to a private corner of his apartment to write in his secret diary, his flight from the city to engage in a sexual rendezvous with Julia—are finally revealed as having been "staged" as a spectacle for Party surveillance.

The telescreen is a figure for the convergence of pictorial power and publicity under a totalitarian police state, a Stalinist dystopia. It leaves open a host of questions about our own situation in the advanced industrial democracies of the late twentieth century after the Cold War. What is the relation between power and publicity in the actual world of triumphant capitalism and international corporate culture? What is the role of art and image-making in a public sphere that is mainly constituted by forms of mass spectacle and the mediatization of experience—the world as theme park? What is the relation between spectacle and surveillance in a "New World Order" of televisual war and public melodrama? What forms of resistance are likely to be efficacious in an era when traditional oppositions (avantgarde versus mass culture, art versus kitsch, private versus public) no longer seem to have cultural or political leverage?

These questions are certainly not original with me. They might be described, in fact, as the canonical questions about visual culture in the postmodern era, the questions that have been central both to Frankfurt School critical theory and to the French critique of the "scopic regime" and the "society of the spectacle."[2] If there is any originality in the answers that emerge in the final two essays of this book, it would not come from any original "methods" that dictate these questions. The concepts of the metapicture and the imagetext, for instance, are simply crystallizations of what has become common sense in postmodern picture theory. What has changed, and what might offer a new, if as yet unsystematized insight, is the specific cultural and historical situation in which all of these essays have been written. I'm thinking here of the momentous historical shift in the late 1980s that has brought the postmodern era to an end and brought the pictorial turn into focus. The children of postmodernism matured in the nuclear, Cold War era; their metapicture of visual media evolved within narratives of paranoia and melodrama. The critical unveiling of "hidden persuaders," subliminal messages, and ideological codes was (and remains) a primary task of critical theory. But what do we make of an era when the persuaders are not hidden, the messages are overt, and ideology is both everywhere and nowhere? What do we say about a televisual spectacle like the video-

2. These two concepts are principally associated with Michel Foucault and Guy Debord respectively. Despite their differences, I associate these two figures with a continuing tradition of resistance to and critique of the visual, in contrast to Jean Baudrillard, whose work seems finally to preempt all dialectical negations of the regime of images.

tape of the Rodney King beating? Most critical commentators on media found themselves responding to this image with a rhetoric of pictorial transparency and realism.[3] All the skills for deciphering the imagetext, the disclosure of hidden strata of visual/verbal "layering," seemed irrelevant in the face of this spectacle. The "textualizing" of this image was, in fact, mainly supplied by the police defense lawyers, who subjected the image-track to frame-by-frame analysis and supplied multiple layers of interpretation, tacit dialogue, and implicit scripting.

The Rodney King videotape is only one example of this kind of breakthrough into transparency in recent media representations. The live images of dead bodies pulled from a bomb shelter in Baghdad "broke through" the screen/spectacle of high-tech, low-resolution images offered by CNN's Gulf War coverage. As in the Rodney King videotape, the main textualizing was provided by government "spin doctors"; the president's press secretary even confessed that it was difficult to counteract an image with words. Indeed, the new "transparency" of the media is not just to be located in these moments of breakthrough, when a large public is convinced that the spectacle it is witnessing is the truth, when illusionism and realism coincide. The television coverage of the Anita Hill/Clarence Thomas hearings collapsed the distinction between news and melodrama, surveillance and spectacle. The

3. The first attempt to prosecute the police officers who beat Rodney King was hampered by its naive trust and reliance on the transparency of the video, its "self-evident" authority. The second prosecution succeeded largely because the prosecutors realized the need to supplement the videotape with King's own testimony.

transparency of Anita Hill's honesty (and Clarence Thomas's mendacity) broke through all the narrative and textual codes that were interposed by the media and Thomas's media "handlers." Although Thomas won the short-term political struggle, the longer-range impact—the effect, for instance, of this spectacle in remobilizing a women's public sphere—may well be more significant.[4]

The new transparency of the image is also visible in the foregrounding of mediation itself. On one side this means that the transparency is an effect produced by a sense of randomness, improvisation, and accident. The Rodney King video betrays all of the signs of the amateur, accidental cameraman, not of professional image-making. On the other side, even the smooth illusionism of professional image/text suturing has become transparent in its way. The coverage of the Persian Gulf War was largely about the coverage itself. Media "personalities" were everywhere, and the institutions of mediation (cameras, control rooms, telestrators, intertitles, framing, scheduling) were placed on display as never before. Tom Engelhardt was right to call it "total television" and to contrast it with the coverage of Vietnam: "Vietnam . . . was not (as is so often said) our first television war, but our last nontelevision one in its inability either to adhere to precise scheduling or achieve closure."[5] The new transparency is a dialectical effect of total television: the effect of the real produced by

4. See the discussion by Patricia Mellencamp in *High Anxiety* (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 1992), pp. 68–70.

5. *Nation*, 11 May 1992: 613–30.

random, unscripted, unofficial, and unauthorized images (live images of dead bodies) depends on it.

Perhaps we have moved into an era when the point about pictures is not just to interpret them, but to change them. The following pair of essays is an exploration of some contemporary imagetext-events in public art, film, and television that attempt to break through and change the codes of contemporary visual culture. They also, in my view, signal the end of postmodernism, with its corrosive, hermeneutic irony about pictures. The films I discuss (*Do the Right Thing* and *JFK*) are notable, if not for their "transparency," for a certain frankness about their rhetorical address to the spectator, an explicitness about social/political intervention, and (especially in *JFK*) a kind of crudity and naivete in narrative construction. The contexts in which I place them (battles over "public art" in the late eighties; the unveiling of the New World Order of total television and mass destruction in 1991) are meant not just to provide a background for the "reading" of these films but to suggest the changing character of visual culture in the wake of postmodernism, both the threat of a kind of "soft" form of global corporate fascism (the much-heralded victory of capitalism) and the hope for new and critical pictures of the public sphere.

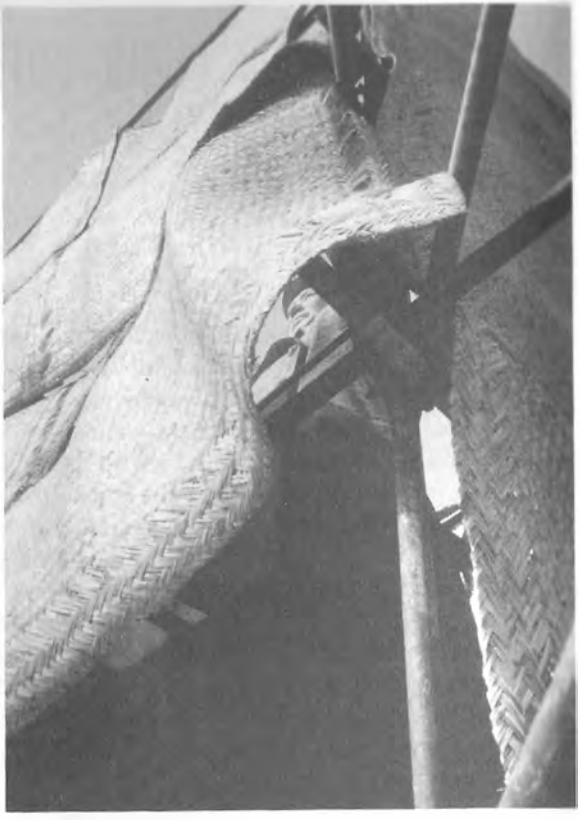
THE VIOLENCE OF PUBLIC ART: *DO THE RIGHT THING*

In May, 1988, I took what may well be the last photograph of the statue of Mao Tse Tung on the campus of Beijing University (figure 70). The thirty-foot monolith was enveloped in a bamboo scaffolding "to keep off the harsh desert winds," my hosts told me with knowing smiles. That night, workers with sledgehammers reduced the statue to a pile of rubble, and rumors spread throughout Beijing that the same thing was happening to Mao statues on university campuses all over China. One year later, most of the world's newspaper readers scanned the photos of Chinese students erecting a thirty-foot styrofoam and plaster "Goddess of Democracy" (figure 71) directly facing the disfigured portrait of Mao in Tiananmen Square despite the warnings from government loudspeakers: "This statue is illegal. It is not approved by the government. Even in the United States statues need permission before they can be put up."[1] A few days later the newspaper accounts told us of army tanks mowing down this statue along with thousands of protesters, reasserting the rule of what was called "law" over a public and its art.

The Beijing Massacre, and the confrontation of images at the central public space in China, is full of instruction for anyone who wants to think about public art and, more generally, of the whole relation of images, violence, and the public sphere.[2] "Even in the United States" political and legal control is exerted, not only over the erection of public statues and monuments, but over the display of a

1. See Uli Schmetzer, *Chicago Tribune,* 1 June 1989, p. 1.

2. For an excellent discussion of the way the events in China in June 1989 became a "spectacle for the West," overdetermined by the presence of a massive publicity apparatus, see Rey Chow, "Violence in the Other Country: Preliminary Remarks on the 'China Crisis,' June 1989," *Radical America* 22 (July–August 1989): 23–32. See also Wu Hung, "Tiananmen Square: A Political History of Monuments," *Representations* 35 (Summer 1991): 84–117.



70. Statue of Mao Tse Tung at Beijing University.

wide range of images, artistic or otherwise, to actual or potential publics. Even in the United States, the "publicness" of public images goes well beyond their specific sites or sponsorship: "publicity" has, in a very real sense, made all art into public art. And even in the United States, art that enters the public sphere is liable to be received as a provocation to or an act of violence.

This juxtaposition of the politics of American public art with the monumental atrocities of Tiananmen Square has struck some readers as deeply inappropriate. Zhang Longxi has argued that it is a "rather casual use of the Chinese example," one that "seems to trivialize the momentum of a great and tragic event" and "verges on endorsing the Chinese government's view" while failing to understand the "true meaning of that phrase"—"even in the United States"—"coming out

71. Goddess of Democracy in Tiananmen Square in China. AP/ Wide World Photos.

of government loudspeakers."[3] My aim, of course, is not to endorse the Chinese government's massacre of its people, but to see what might be learned from its manner of legitimating that massacre. The government's verbal pretensions of legality and public civility coupled with the most transparent visual representations of brutal violence effectively dismembered and disarticulated the smooth suturing of the television news imagetext. But the spectacle does more than undermine the phrase, revealing it as a cynical alibi for state repression; it also puts the phrase into a new orbit of global circulation and connects it, albeit anachronistically and a-topically, with other public spectacles of monumental violence and violence against monuments. "Even in the U.S. . . . " comes home to roost, as it were, and the

3. Zhang Longxi, "Western Theory and Chinese Reality," *Critical Inquiry* 19:1 (Autumn 1992): 114.

question is how. This sort of juxtaposition and circulation is what it means to live in a society of spectacle and surveillance, the world of the pictorial turn. Zhang Longxi is right to worry that such specular linkages risk trivializing great and tragic events. But the ability to differentiate and connect the trivial and the tragic, the insignificant and the monumental, is precisely what is at issue in the critique of art, violence, and the public sphere. Above all, the relations of literal and figurative violence, of violence by and against persons, and violence by and against images, can only be measured at the risk of trivializing the monumental and vice versa.

Our own historical moment in the United States has seemed especially rich in examples of public acts and provocations that cross the boundaries between real and symbolic violence, between the monumental and trivial. The erosion of the boundary between public and private spheres in a mediatized, specular society is what makes those border crossings possible, even inevitable. Recent art has carried the scandals previously associated with the cloistered spaces of the art world—the gallery, the museum, and the private collection—into the public sphere. And the public, by virtue of governmental patronage of the arts, has taken an interest in what is done with its money, no matter whether it is spent on traditional public art—in a public place as a public commission—or on a private activity in a private space that just happens to receive some public support or publicity. The controversy over Richard Serra's *Tilted Arc* sculpture in a public plaza in New York City marks one boundary of this phenomenon. Serra's is a traditional work of public art; it provoked another engagement in what Michael North has called the "tiresome battle, repeated in city after city . . . whenever a piece of modern sculpture is installed outdoors."[4] But now the battle has moved indoors, into the spaces of museums and art schools. The privacy of the exhibition site is no longer a protection for art that does symbolic violence to revered public figures like the deceased mayor of Chicago or to public emblems and icons like the American flag or the crucifix.

The erosion of the boundary between public and private art is accompanied by a collapsing of the distinction between symbolic and actual violence, whether the "official" violence of police, juridical, or

4. Michael North, *The Final Sculpture: Public Monuments and Modern Poets* (Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press, 1985), p. 17. *Tilted Arc* is "traditional" in its legal status as a commission by a public, governmental agency. In other ways (style, form, relation to site, public legibility) it is obviously nontraditional.

legislative power or the "unofficial" violence in the responses of private individuals. Serra's *Tilted Arc* was seen as a violation of public space, was subjected to actual defacement and vandalism by some members of the public, and became the subject of public legal proceedings to determine whether it should be dismantled.[5] The official removal of an art student's caricature of Mayor Washington from the School of the Chicago Art Institute involved, not just the damaging of the offensive picture, but a claim that the picture was itself an "incitement to violence" in black communities. A later installation at the same school asking *What Is the Proper Way to Display the American Flag?* was construed as an invitation to "trample" on the flag. It immediately attracted threats of unofficial violence against the person of the artist and may ultimately serve as the catalyst not simply for legislative action but for a constitutional amendment protecting the flag against all acts of symbolic or real violence. The response to Andres Serrano's *Piss Christ* and the closing of the Mapplethorpe show at the Corcoran Gallery indicate the presence of an American public, or at least of some well-entrenched political interests, that is fed up with tolerating symbolic violence against religious and sexual taboos under the covers of "art," "privacy," and "free speech" and is determined to fight back with the very real power of financial sanctions.[6] The United States is nowhere near to sending tanks to mow down students and their statues, but it has recently endured a period when art and various partial publics (insofar as they are embodied by state power and "public opinion") have seemed on a collision course.

The association of public art with violence is nothing new. The fall of every Chinese dynasty since antiquity has been accompanied by the destruction of its public monuments, and the long history of political and religious strife in the West could almost be rewritten as a history of iconoclasm. The history of communism, from Eisenstein's *October* to CNN's coverage of the collapse of the Soviet Union, has been largely framed by images of the demolition of public monuments. There is also nothing new about the violent opposition of art to its public. Artists have been biting the hands that feed them since antiq-

5. For an excellent account of this whole controversy and the decision to remove *Tilted Arc*, see *Public Art/Public Controversy: The Tilted Arc on Trial*, edited by Sherrill Jordan et al. (New York: American Council for the Arts, 1987).

6. On the neoconservative reactions against controversial forms of state-supported art in the late 1980s, see Paul Mattick, Jr., "Arts and the State," *Nation* 251:10 (1 October 1990): 348–58.

uity,[7] and even the notion of an "avant-garde" capable of scandalizing the bourgeoisie has been dismissed, by a number of critics, to the dustbin of history. The avant-garde, in Thomas Crow's words, now functions "as a kind of research and development arm of the culture industry."[8] Oppositional movements such as surrealism, expressionism, and cubism have been recuperated for entertainment and advertising, and the boldest gestures of High Modernism have become the ornaments of corporate public spaces. If traditional public art identified certain classical styles as appropriate to the embodiment of public images, contemporary public art has turned to the monumental abstraction as its acceptable icon. What Kate Linker calls the "corporate bauble" in the shopping mall or bank plaza need have no iconic or symbolic relation to the public it serves, the space it occupies, or the figures it reveres.[9] It is enough that it serve as an emblem of aesthetic surplus, a token of "art" imported into and adding value to a public space.

The notorious "anti-aesthetic" posture of much postmodern art may be seen, in its flouting of the canons of High Modernism, as the latest edition of the iconoclastic public icon, the image which affronts its own public—in this case, the art world as well as the "general" public. The violence associated with this art is inseparable from its *publicness,* especially its exploitation of and by the apparatuses of publicity, reproduction, and commercial distribution.[10] The scandalousness and obtrusive theatricality of these images holds up a mirror to the nature of the commodified image and the public spectator ad-

7. G. E. Lessing notes that beauty in visual art was not simply an aesthetic preference for the ancients but a matter of juridical control. The Greeks had laws against caricature, and the ugly "dirt painters" were subjected to censorship. See Lessing's *Laocoon: An Essay upon the Limits of Poetry and Painting*, translated by Ellen Frothingham (1766; New York: Farrar, Straus, & Giroux, 1969), pp. 9–10.

8. Thomas Crow, "Modernism and Mass Culture in the Visual Arts," in *Pollock and After: The Critical Debate,* edited by Francis Frascina (New York: Harper and Row, 1985), p. 257.

9. See Kate Linker's important essay, "Public Sculpture: The Pursuit of the Pleasurable and Profitable Paradise," *ArtForum* 19 (March 1981): 66.

10. Scott Burton summarizes the "new kind of relationship" between art and its audience: "it might be called public art. Not because it is necessarily located in public places but because the content is more than the private history of the maker" (quoted in Henry Sayre, *The Object of Performance* [Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1989], p. 6).

dressed by advertising, television, movies, and "Art" with a capital A. If all images are for sale, it's hardly surprising that artists would invent public images that are difficult (in any sense) to "buy." Postmodern art tries, among other things, to be difficult to own or collect, and much of it succeeds, existing only as ruined fragments, or photographic "documentation." Much of it also "fails," of course, to be unmarketable and thus "succeeds" quite handsomely as an aesthetic commodity, as Andy Warhol's work demonstrates. The common thread of both the marketable and the unmarketable artwork is the more or less explicit awareness of "marketability" and publicity as unavoidable dimensions of any public sphere that art might address. "Co-optation" and "resistance" are thus the ethical maxims of this public sphere and the aesthetic it generates.

The violence associated with this art may seem, then, to have a peculiarly desperate character and is often directed at the work itself as much as its beholder. Sometimes a self-destructive violence is built into the work, as in Jean Tinguely's self-destroying machine sculpture, *Homage to New York,* or Rudolf Schwarzkogler's amputation of his own penis, both of which now exist only in photographic documentation.[11] More often, the violence suffered by contemporary art seems simultaneously fateful and accidental, a combination of misunderstanding by local or partial publics and a certain fragility or temporariness in the work itself. The early history of Claes Oldenburg's monumental *Lipstick* at Yale University is one of progressive disfigurement and dismantling. Many of the works of Robert Smithson and Robert Morris are destroyed, existing now only in documents and photographs. The openness of contemporary art to publicity and public destruction has been interpreted by some commentators as a kind of artistic aggression and scandal-mongering. A more accurate reading would recognize it as a deliberate vulnerability to violence, a strategy for dramatizing new relations between the traditionally "timeless" work of art and the transient generations, the "publics," that are addressed by it.[12] The defaced and graffiti-laden walls that Jonathan

11. See Sayre, *The Object of Performance,* pp. 2–3.

12. For a shocking example of an artist's misrepresentation of these issues, see Frederick E. Hart, "The Shocking Truth about Contemporary Art," *The Washington Post,* 28 August–3 September 1989, national weekly edition, op-ed. section. It hardly comes as a surprise that Hart is the sculptor responsible for the figural "supplement" to the Vietnam Veterans' Memorial, the traditional monumental figures of three soldiers erected in the area facing the Memorial.

Borofsky installs in museum spaces are a strategy for reconfiguring the whole relation of private and public, legitimate and "transgressive" exhibition spaces. Morris's 1981 proposal to install the casings of nuclear bombs as monumental sculpture at a Florida VA hospital was both a logical extension of a public sculpture tradition (the public display of obsolete weapons) and a deadpan mimicry of the claim that these weapons "saved American lives" in World War II.[13]

The question naturally arises: Is public art inherently violent, or a provocation to violence? Is violence built into the monument in its very conception? Or is violence simply an accident that befalls some monuments, a matter of the fortunes of history? The historical record suggests that if violence is simply an accident that happens to public art, it is one that is always waiting to happen. The principal media and materials of public art are stone and metal sculpture not so much by choice as by necessity. "A public sculpture," says Lawrence Alloway, "should be invulnerable or inaccessible. It should have the material strength to resist attack or be easily cleanable, but it also needs a formal structure that is not wrecked by alterations."[14] The violence that surrounds public art is more, however, than simply the ever-present possibility of accident—the natural disaster or random act of vandalism. Much of the world's public art—memorials, monuments, triumphal arches, obelisks, columns, and statues—has a rather direct reference to violence in the form of war or conquest. From Ozymandias to Caesar to Napoleon to Hitler, public art has served as a kind of monumentalizing of violence and never more powerfully than when it presents the conqueror as a man of peace imposing a Napoleonic code or a *pax Romana* on the world. Public sculpture that is too frank or explicit about this monumentalizing of violence, whether the Assyrian palace reliefs of the 9th century B.C., or Morris's bomb sculpture proposal of 1981, is likely to offend the sensibilities of a public committed to the repression of its own complicity in violence.[15] The very notion of public art as we receive it is inseparable from what Jurgen Habermas has called "the liberal model of the

13. See Robert Morris, "Fissures," unpublished manuscript, Guggenheim Museum Archives; also see chapter 8.

14. Lawrence Alloway, "The Public Sculpture Problem," *Studio International* 184:948 (October 1972): 124.

15. See Leo Bersani and Ulysse Dutoit, "The Forms of Violence," *October* 8 (Spring 1979): 17–29, for an important critique of the "narrativization" of violence in Western art and an examination of the alternative suggested by the Assyrian palace reliefs.

public sphere," a pacified space distinct from economic, private, and political dimensions. In this ideal realm disinterested citizens may contemplate a transparent emblem of their own inclusiveness and solidarity and deliberate on the general good, free of coercion, violence, or private interests.[16]

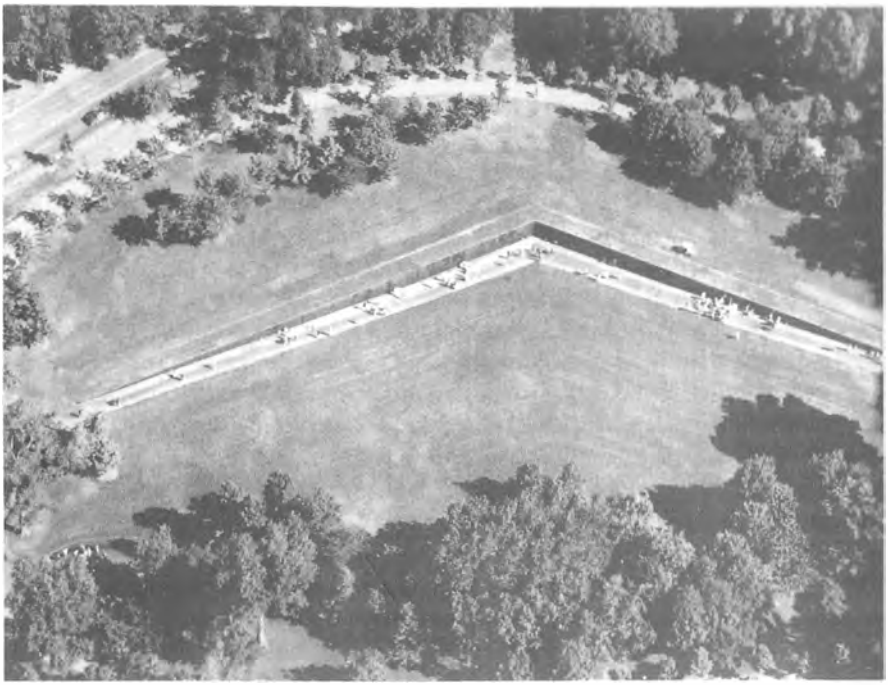
The fictional ideal of the classic public sphere is that it includes everyone; the fact is that it can only be constituted by the rigorous exclusion of certain groups—slaves, children, foreigners, those without property, and (most conspicuously) women.[17] The very notion of the "public," it seems, grows out of a conflation of two very different words, *populo* (the people) and *pubes* (adult men). The word *public* might more properly be written with the "l" in parentheses to remind us that, for much of human history political and social authority has derived from a "pubic" sphere, not a public one. This seems to be the case even when the public sphere is personified as a female figure. The famous examples of female monuments to the all-inclusive principle of public civility and rule of law—Athena to represent impartial Athenian justice, the Goddess of Reason epitomizing the rationalization of the public sphere in revolutionary France, the Statue of Liberty welcoming the huddled masses from every shore—all presided over political systems that rigorously excluded women from any public role.[18]

Perhaps some of the power associated with the Vietnam Veterans' Memorial in Washington, D.C., comes from its cunning violation and inversion of monumental conventions for expressing and repressing

16. Habermas first introduced this concept in *Structural Transformation of the Public Sphere,* translated by Thomas Burger and Frederick Lawrence (Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 1989). First published in German in 1962, it has since become the focus of an extensive literature. See also Habermas's short encyclopedia article, "The Public Sphere," translated by Sara Lennox and Frank Lennox, *New German Critique* 1, no. 3 (Fall 1974): 49–55, and the introduction to it by Peter Hohendahl in the same issue, pp. 44–48. I owe much to the guidance of Miriam Hansen and Lauren Berlant on this complex and crucial topic.

17. See Joan Landes, *Women and the Public Sphere in the Age of the French Revolution* (Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press, 1988), p. 3.

18. Rey Chow notes the way the "Goddess of Democracy" in Tiananmen Square replicates the "*King Kong* syndrome," in which the body of the white woman sutures the gap between "enlightened instrumental reason and barbarism-lurking-behind-the Wall," the "white man's production and the monster's destruction" (Chow, "Violence in the Other Country," p. 26).



72. Aerial view of the Vietnam Veterans' Memorial. Photo by Richard Hofmeister, Smithsonian Institution's Office of Printing and Photographic Services. From *Reflections on the Wall: The Vietnam Veterans Memorial* (Harrisburg, PA: Stackpole Books, 1987).

the violence of the pub(l)ic sphere (figure 72). The VVM is anti-heroic, anti-monumental, a V-shaped gash or scar, a trace of violence suffered, not (as in the conventional war memorial) of violence wielded in the service of a glorious cause.[19] It achieves the universality of the public monument, not by rising above its surroundings to transcend the political, but by going beneath the political to the shared sense of a wound that will never heal, or (more optimistically) a scar that will never fade. Its legibility is not that of narrative: no heroic episode such as the planting of the American flag on Iwo Jima is memorialized, only the mind-numbing and undifferentiated chronology of violence

19. See Charles Griswold, "The Vietnam Veterans' Memorial and the Washington Mall: Philosophical Thoughts on Political Iconography," *Critical Inquiry* 12, no. 4 (Summer 1986): 709. Griswold reads the VVM as a symbol of "honor without glory."

and death catalogued by the 57,000 names inscribed on the black marble walls. The only other legibility is that of the giant flat "V" carved in the earth itself, a multivalent monogram or initial that seems uncannily overdetermined. Does the "V" stand for Vietnam? For a pyrrhic "Victory"? For the Veterans themselves? For the Violence they suffered? Is it possible, finally, to avoid seeing it as a quite literal anti-type to the "pubic sphere" signified in the traditional phallic monument, the Vagina of Mother Earth opened to receive her sons, as if the American soil were opening its legs to show the scars inscribed on her private parts?

Even as this monument seems to invert the symbolic valences of the traditional war memorial, however, it reinscribes them at a more subtle level. The privates of Mother Earth are all men (Frederick Hart's "supplement" to the VVM, a traditional sculptural group of three male GIs, makes this exclusion of women visible). And although the authorship of the VVM design by a Chinese-American woman is sometimes adduced to explain its pacifist form, the ethnicity of Maya Lin seems mainly an ironic footnote to a memorial that (unsurprisingly) has no place for the suffering of the Vietnamese. If the VVM is a successful work of public art, it is not because it manages to "heal" the wounds of the past or to re-open them with forms of critical violence: it succeeds only in keeping the space between these possibilities open, in the way an indelible scar provokes an indefinite series of narratives and counternarratives.[20]

It should be clear that the violence associated with public art is not simply an undifferentiated abstraction, any more than is the public sphere it addresses. Violence may be in some sense "encoded" in the concept and practice of public art, but the specific role it plays, its political or ethical status, the form in which it is manifested, the identities of those who wield and suffer it, is always nested in particular circumstances. We may distinguish three basic forms of violence in the images of public art, each of which may, in various ways, interact with the other: (1) the image as an *act* or *object* of violence, itself doing violence to beholders, or "suffering" violence as the target of vandalism, disfigurement, or demolition; (2) the image as a *weapon*

20. These issues, and a suggestion that the "healing" provided by the VVM may have as much to do with nationalist amnesia and historical revisionism as with critical commemoration, are discussed by Marita Sturken in "The Wall, the Screen, and the Image: The Vietnam Veterans' Memorial," *Representations* 35 (Summer 1991): 118–42. See also chapter 8 above for Robert Morris's remarks on the VVM.

of violence, a device for attack, coercion, incitement, or more subtle "dislocations" of public spaces; (3) the image as a *representation* of violence, whether a realistic imitation of a violent act, or a monument, trophy, memorial, or other trace of past violence. All three forms are, in principle, independent of one another: an image can be a weapon of violence without representing it; it may become the object of violence without ever being used as a weapon; it may represent violence without ever exerting or suffering it. In fact, however, these three forms of violence are often linked together. Pornography is said to be a representation of and a weapon of violence against women which should be destroyed or at least banned from public distribution.[21] The propaganda image is a weapon of war which obviously engages with all three forms of violence in various ways, depending on the circumstances. The relation of pornography to propaganda is a kind of displaced version of the relation of "private" to "public" art: the former projects fetishistic images confined, in theory, to the "private sphere" of sexuality; the latter projects totemistic or idolatrous images directed, in theory, at a specific public sphere.[22] In practice, however, private "arousal" and public "mobilization" cannot be confined to their proper spheres: rape and riot are the "surplus" of the economy of violence encoded in public and private images.

These elisions of the boundary between public and private images are what make it possible, perhaps even necessary, to connect the sphere of public art in its "proper" or traditional sense (works of art installed in public places by public agencies at public expense) to film, a medium of public art in an extended or "improper" sense.[23] Although film is sometimes called the central public art of the twentieth century, we should be clear about the adjustments in both key terms—"public" and "art"—required to make this turn. Film is not a "public art" in the classic sense stipulated by Habermas; it is deeply entangled with the marketplace and the sphere of commercial-industrial public-

21. See Catharine Mackinnon, *Feminism Unmodified* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1987), especially pp. 172–73 and 192–93.

22. For more on the distinction between totemism and fetishism, see my "Tableau and Taboo: The Resistance to Vision in Literary Discourse," *CEA Critic* 51 (Fall 1988): 4–10, and the discussion in chapter 8, pp. 260, 266, 269–70, 278.

23. See Miriam Hansen, *Babel and Babylon: Spectatorship in American Silent Film* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1991), p. 7: "On one level, cinema constitutes a public sphere of its own. . . . At the same time cinema intersects and interacts with other formations of public life. . . . "

ity that replaces what Habermas calls the "culture-debating" public with a "culture-consuming" public.[24] We need not accept Habermas's historical claim that the classic public sphere (based in the "world of letters") was "replaced by the pseudo-public or sham-private world of culture consumption" to see that its basic distinction between an ideal, utopian public sphere and the real world of commerce and publicity is what underwrites the distinction between public art "proper" and the "improper" turn to film, a medium that is neither "public" nor "art" in this proper (utopian) sense.

This juxtaposition of public art and commercial film illuminates a number of contrasting features whose distinctiveness is under considerable pressure, both in contemporary art and recent film practice. An obvious difference between public art and the movies is the contrast in mobility. Of all forms of art, public art is the most static, stable, and fixed in space: the monument is a fixed, generally rigid object, designed to remain on its site for all time.[25] The movies, by contrast, "move" in every possible way—in their presentation, their circulation and distribution, and in their responsiveness to the fluctuations of contemporary taste. Public art is supposed to occupy a pacified, utopian space, a site held in common by free and equal citizens whose debates, freed of commercial motives, private interest, or violent coercion, will form "public opinion." Movies are beheld in private, commercial theaters that further privatize spectators by isolating and immobilizing them in darkness. Public art stands still and silent while its beholders move in the reciprocal social relations of festivals, mass meetings, parades, and rendezvous. Movies appropriate all motion and sound to themselves, allowing only the furtive, private rendezvous of lovers or of auto-eroticism.

The most dramatic contrast between film and public art emerges in the characteristic tendencies of each medium with respect to the representation of sex and violence. Public art tends to repress violence, veiling it with the stasis of monumentalized and pacified spaces, just as it veils gender inequality by representing the masculine public sphere with the monumentalized bodies of women. Film tends to express violence, staging it as a climactic spectacle, just as it foregrounds gender inequality by fetishizing rather than monumentalizing the female body. Sex and violence are strictly forbidden in the public site,

24. Habermas, *The Structural Transformation of the Public Sphere*, pp. 159–60.

25. The removal of *Tilted Arc* is all the more remarkable (and ominous) in view of this strong presumption in favor of permanence.

and thus the plaza, common, or city square is the favored site for insurrection and symbolic transgression, with disfiguration of the monument a familiar, almost ritual occurrence.[26] The representation of sex and violence is licensed in the cinema and it is generally presumed (even by the censors) that it is re-enacted elsewhere—in streets, alleys, and private places.

I have rehearsed these traditional distinctions between film and public art not to claim their irresistible truth but to sketch the conventional background against which the relations of certain contemporary practices in film and public art may be understood—their common horizon of resistance, as it were. Much recent public art obviously resists and criticizes its own site, and the fixed, monumental status conventionally required of it; much of it aspires, quite literally, to the condition of film in the form of photographic or cinematic documentation. I turn now to a film that aspires to the condition of public art, attempting a similar form of resistance within its own medium and holding up a mirror to the economy of violence encoded in public images.[27]

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In May of 1989 I tried unsuccessfully to attend an advance screening of Spike Lee's *Do the Right Thing* at the University of Chicago. Students from the university and the neighborhood had lined up for six

26. The fate of the Berlin Wall is a perfect illustration of this process of disfiguration as a transformation of a public monument into a host of private fetishes. While the Wall stood it served as a work of public art, both in its official status and its unofficial function as a blank slate for the expression of public resistance. As it is torn to pieces, its fragments are carried away to serve as trophies in private collections. As German reunification proceeds, these fragments may come to signify a nostalgia for the monument that expressed and enforced its division.

27. By the phrase "economy of violence," I mean, quite strictly, a social structure in which violence circulates and is exchanged as a currency of social interaction. The "trading" of insults might be called the barter or "in-kind" exchange; body parts (eyes, teeth notably) can also be exchanged, along with blows, glares, hard looks, threats, and first strikes. This economy lends itself to rapid, runaway inflation, so that (under the right circumstances) an injury that would have been trivial (stepping on someone's sneakers, smashing a radio) is drastically overestimated in importance. As a currency, violence is notoriously and appropriately unstable.

hours to get the free tickets, and none of them seemed interested in scalping them at any price. Spike Lee made an appearance at the film's conclusion and stayed until well after midnight answering the questions of the overflow crowd. This event turned out to be a preview not simply of the film, but of the film's subsequent reception. Lee spent much of the summer answering questions about the film in television and newspaper interviews; the *New York Times* staged an instant symposium of experts on ethnicity and urban violence; and screenings of the film (especially in urban theaters) took on the character of festivals, with audiences in New York, London, Chicago, and Los Angeles shouting out their approval to the screen and to each other.

The film elicited disapproval from critics and viewers as well. It was denounced as an incitement to violence and even as an *act* of violence by viewers who regarded its representations of ghetto characters as demeaning.[28] The film moved from the familiar commercial public sphere of "culture consumption" into the sphere of public art, the arena of the "culture-debating" public, a shift signaled most dramatically by its exclusion from the "Best Picture" category of the Academy Awards. As the film's early reception subsides into the cultural history of the late eighties in the United States, we may now be in a position to assess its significance as something more than a "public sensation" or "popular phenomenon." *Do the Right Thing* is rapidly establishing itself not only as a work of public art (a "monumental achievement" in the trade lingo), but as a film *about* public art.[29] The film tells a story of multiple ethnic public spheres, the violence that circulates among and within these partial publics, and the tendency of this violence to fixate itself on specific images—symbolic objects, fetishes, and public icons or idols.

28. Murray Kempton's review (*New York Review of Books*, 28 September 1989), pp. 37–38, is perhaps the most hysterically abusive of the hostile reviews. Kempton condemns Spike Lee as a "hack" who is ignorant of African-American history and guilty of "a low opinion of his own people" (p. 37). His judgment of Mookie, the character played by Spike Lee in the film, is even more vitriolic: Mookie "is not just an inferior specimen of a great race but beneath the decent minimum for humankind itself" (p. 37).

29. One of the interesting developments in the later reception of *Do the Right Thing* has been its rapid canonization as Spike Lee's "masterpiece." Critics who trashed the film in 1989 now use it as an example of his best, most authentic work in order to trash his later films (most notably *Malcolm X*) by contrast.

73. Sal's "Wall of Fame" in Spike Lee's *Do the Right Thing.*

The specific public image at the center of the violence in *Do the Right Thing* is a collection of photographs, an array of signed publicity photos of Italian-American stars in sports, movies, and popular music framed and hung up on the "Wall of Fame" in Sal's Famous Pizzeria at the corner of Stuyvesant and Lexington Avenues in Brooklyn (figure 73). A young bespectacled man named "Buggin' Out" (who is the closest thing to a "political activist" to be found in this film) challenges this arrangement, asking Sal why no pictures of black Americans are on the wall (figure 74). Sal's response is an appeal to the rights of private property: "You want brothers up on the Wall of Fame, you open up your own business, then you can do what you wanna do. My pizzeria. American-Italians only up on the wall." When Buggin' Out persists, arguing that blacks should have some say about the Wall since their money keeps the pizzeria in business, Sal reaches for a baseball bat, a publicly recognizable emblem of both the American way of life and of recent white-on-black violence. Mookie, Sal's black delivery boy (played by Spike Lee) defuses the situation by hus-

74. Buggin' Out looks up at the Wall of Fame.

tling Buggin' Out out of the pizzeria. In retaliation, Buggin' Out tries, quite unsuccessfully, to organize a neighborhood boycott and the conflict between the black public and the private white-owned business simmers on the back burner throughout the hot summer day. Smiley, a stammering, semi-articulate black man who sells copies of a unique photograph showing Martin Luther King and Malcolm X together, tries to sell his photos to Sal (who seems ready to be accommodating) but is driven off by Sal's son Pino. Sal is assaulted by another form of "public art" when Radio Raheem enters the pizzeria with his boom box blasting out Public Enemy's rap song, "Fight the Power." Finally, at closing time, Radio Raheem and Buggin' Out re-enter Sal's, radio blasting, to demand once again that some black people go up on the Wall of Fame. Sal smashes the radio with his baseball bat, Raheem pulls Sal over the counter and begins to choke him. In the riot that follows, the police kill Radio Raheem and depart with his body, leaving Sal and his sons to face a neighborhood uprising. Mookie throws a garbage can through the window of the pizzeria, and the mob loots

and burns it. Later, when the fire is burning down, Smiley enters the ruins and pins his photograph of King and Malcolm (figure 75) to the smoldering Wall of Fame.

Sal's Wall of Fame exemplifies the central contradictions of public art. It is located in a place that may be described, with equal force, as a public accommodation and a private business. Like the classic liberal public sphere, it rests on a foundation of private property which comes into the open when its public inclusiveness is challenged. Sal's repeated refrain throughout the film to express both his openness and hospitality to the public and his "right" to reign as a despot in his "own place" is a simple definition of what his "place" is: "This is America." As "art," Sal's wall stands on the threshold between the aesthetic and the rhetorical, functioning simultaneously as ornament and as propaganda, both a private collection and a public statement. The content of the statement occupies a similar threshold, the hyphenated space designated by "Italian-American," a hybrid of particular ethnic identification and general public identity. The Wall is important to Sal not just because it displays famous Italians but because they are famous *Americans* (Sinatra, DiMaggio, Liza Minelli, Mario Cuomo) who have made it possible for Italians to think of themselves as Americans, full-fledged members of the general public sphere. The Wall is important to Buggin' Out because it signifies exclusion from the public sphere. This may seem odd, since the neighborhood is filled with public representations of African American heroes on every side: a huge billboard of Mike Tyson looms over Sal's pizzeria; children's art ornaments the sidewalks and graffiti streaks subversive messages like "Tawana told the truth" on the walls; Magic Johnson T-shirts, Air Jordan sneakers, and a variety of jewelry and exotic hairdos make the characters like walking billboards for "Black pride"; and the sound-world of the film is suffused with a musical "Wall of Fame," a veritable anthology of great jazz, blues, and popular music emanating from Mister Señor Love Daddy's storefront radio station, just two doors away from Sal's.

Why aren't these tokens of black self-respect enough for Buggin' Out? The answer, I think, is that they are only tokens of self-respect, of black pride, and what Buggin' Out wants is the respect of whites, the acknowledgment that African-Americans are hyphenated Americans too, just like Italians.[30] The public spaces accessible to blacks in the film are *only* public and that only in the special way that the

30. I am indebted to Joel Snyder for suggesting this distinction between self-respect and acknowledgment.

sphere of commercial-industrial publicity (a sphere which includes, of course, movies themselves) is available to blacks. They are, like the public spaces in which black athletes and entertainers appear, rarely owned by blacks themselves; they are reminders that black public figures are by and large the "property" of a white-owned corporation—whether a professional sports franchise, a recording company, or a film distributor. The public spaces in which blacks achieve prominence are thus only sites of publicity or of marginalized arts of resistance, the disfiguring of public spaces epitomized by graffiti, not of a genuine public sphere they may enter as equal citizens. The spaces of publicity, despite their glamour and magnitude, are not as important as the humble little piece of "real America" that is Sal's Pizzeria, the semiprivate, semipublic white-owned space, the threshold space that supports genuine membership in the American public sphere. The one piece of public art "proper" that appears in the film is an allegorical mural across the street from Sal's, and it is conspicuously marginalized; the camera never lingers on it long enough to allow decipherment of its complex images. The mural is a kind of archaic residue of a past moment in the black struggle for equality, when "Black Pride" was enough. In *Do the Right Thing* the blacks have plenty of pride; what they want, and cannot get, is the acknowledgment and respect of whites.

The film is not suggesting, however, that integrating the Wall of Fame would solve the problem of racism, or allow African Americans to enter the public sphere as full-fledged Americans. Probably the most fundamental contradiction the film suggests about the whole issue of public art is its simultaneous triviality and monumentality. The Wall of Fame is, in a precise sense, the "cause" of the major violence in the narrative, and yet it is also merely a token or symptom. Buggin' Out's boycott fails to draw any support from the neighborhood, which generally regards his plan as a meaningless gesture. The racial integration of the public symbol, as of the public accommodation, is merely a token of public acceptance. Real participation in the public sphere involves more than tokenism: it involves full economic participation. As long as blacks do not own private property in this society, they remain in something like the status of public art, mere ornaments to (or disfigurations of) the public place, entertaining statues and abstract caricatures rather than full human beings.

Spike Lee has been accused by some critics of racism for projecting a world of black stereotypes in his film: Tina, the tough, foulmouthed sexy ghetto babe; Radio Raheem, the sullen menace with his ghetto blaster; "Da Mayor," the neighborhood wino; "Mother

Sister," the domineering, disapproving matriarch who sits in her window all day posed like Whistler's mother. Lee even casts himself as a type, a streetwise, lazy, treacherous hustler who hoards his money, neglects his child, and betrays his employer by setting off the mob to destroy the pizzeria. But it is not enough to call these stereotypes "unrealistic"; they are, from another point of view, highly realistic representations of the public *images* of blacks, the caricatures imposed on them and (sometimes) acted out by them. Ruby Dee and Ossie Davis, whom Lee cast as the Matriarch and the Wino, have a long history of participation in the film proliferation of these images, and Dee's comment on the role of black elders is quite self-conscious about this history: "When you get old in this country, you become a statue, a monument. And what happens to statues? Birds shit on them. There's got to be more to life for an elder than that."[31] The film suggests that there's got be more to life for the younger generation as well, which seems equally in danger of settling into a new image-repertoire of stereotypes. It is as if the film wanted to cast its characters as publicity images with human beings imprisoned inside them, struggling to break out of their shells to truly participate in the public space where they are displayed.

This "breaking out" of the public image is what the film dramatizes and what constitutes the violence that pervades it. Much of this violence is merely trivial or irritating, involving the tokens of public display, as when an Irish yuppie homesteader (complete with Larry Bird t-shirt) steps on Buggin' Out's Air Jordans; some is erotic, as in Tina's dance as a female boxer, which opens the film; some is subtle and poetic, as in the scene when Radio Raheem breaks out of his sullen silence, turns off his blaster, and does a rap directly addressed to the camera, punctuating his lines with punches, his fists clad in massive gold rings that are inscribed with the words "Love" and "Hate." Negative reactions to the film tend to obsessively focus on the destruction of the pizzeria, as if the violence against property were the only "real" violence in the film. Radio Raheem's murder is regularly passed over as a mere link in the narrative chain that leads to the climactic spectacle of the burning pizzeria. Spike Lee has also been criticized for showing this spectacle at all; the film has routinely been denounced as an incitement to violence or at least a defense of rioting against white property as an act of justifiable violence in the black community. Commentators have complained that the riot is

31. Quoted in Spike Lee and Lisa Jones, *Do the Right Thing: A Spike Lee Joint* (New York: Simon and Schuster, 1989), caption to pl. 30.

insufficiently motivated, or that it is just there for the spectacle, or to prove a thesis.[32] In particular, Spike Lee has been criticized for allowing Mookie's character to "break out" of its passive, evasive, uncommitted stance at the crucial moment, when he throws the garbage can through the window.

Mookie's act dramatizes the whole issue of violence and public art by staging an act of vandalism against a public symbol and specifically by smashing the plate glass window that marks the boundary between public and private property, the street and the commercial interest. Most of the negative commentary on the film has construed this action as a political statement, a call by Spike Lee to advance African-American interests by trashing white-owned businesses. Lee risks this misinterpretation, of course, in the very act of staging this spectacle for potential monumentalization as a public statement, a clearly legible image readable by all potential publics as a threat or model for imitation. That this event has emerged as the focus of principal controversy suggests that it is not so legible, not so transparent as it might have seemed. Spike Lee's motives as writer and director—whether to make a political statement, give the audience the spectacle it wants, or fulfill a narrative design—are far from clear. And Mookie's motivation as a character is equally problematic: at the very least, his action seems subject to multiple private determinations—anger at Sal, frustration at his dead-end job, rage at Radio Raheem's murder—that have no political or "public" content. At the most intimate level, Mookie's act hints at the anxieties about sexual violence that we have seen encoded in other public monuments. Sal

32. Terrence Rafferty ("Open and Shut," review of *Do the Right Thing*, in *The New Yorker*, 24 July 1989) makes all three complaints. Rafferty (1) reduces the film to a thesis about "the inevitability of race conflict in America"; (2) suggests that the violent ending comes only from "Lee's sense, as a filmmaker, that he needs a conflagration at the end"; and (3) compares Lee's film unfavorably to Martin Scorsese's *Mean Streets* and *Taxi Driver*, where "the final bursts of violence are generated entirely from within." What Rafferty fails to consider is (1) that the film explicitly articulates theses that are diametrically opposed to his reductive reading (most notably, Love Daddy's concluding call "My People, My People," for peace and harmony, a speech filled with echoes of Zora Neale Hurston's autobiography); (2) that the final conflagration might be deliberately staged—as is so much of the film—*as a stagey, theatrical event* to foreground a certain requirement of the medium; (3) that the psychological conventions of Italian-American neorealism with their "inner" motivations for violence are among the issues under examination in *Do the Right Thing*.

has, in Mookie's view, attempted to seduce his sister, Jade (whom we have seen in a nearly incestuous relation to Mookie in the opening scene), and Mookie has warned his sister never to enter the pizzeria again (this dialogue staged in front of the pizzeria's brick wall, spray-painted with the graffiti message, "Tawana told the Truth," an evocation of another indecipherable case of highly publicized sexual violence). Mookie's private anxieties about his manhood ("Be a man, Mookie!" is his girlfriend Tina's hectoring refrain) are deeply inscribed in his public act of violence against the public symbol of white domination.

But private, psychological explanations are far from exhausting the meaning of Mookie's act. An equally compelling account would regard the smashing of the window as an ethical intervention. At the moment of Mookie's decision the mob is wavering between attacking the pizzeria and assaulting its Italian American owners. Mookie's act directs the violence away from persons and toward property, the only choice available in that moment. One could say that Mookie "does the right thing," saving human lives by sacrificing property.[33] Most fundamentally, however, we have to say that Spike Lee himself "does the right thing" in this moment by breaking the illusion of cinematic realism and intervening as the director of his own work of public art, taking personal responsibility for the decision to portray and perform a public act of violence against private property. This choice breaks the film loose from the *narrative* justification of violence, its legitimation by a law of cause and effect or political justice, and displays it as a pure effect of *this* work of art in this moment and place. The act makes perfect sense as a piece of Brechtean theater, giving the audience what it wants with one hand and taking it back with the other.

We may call *Do the Right Thing* a piece of "violent public art," then, in all the relevant senses—as a representation, an act, and a weapon of violence. But it is a work of *intelligent* violence, to echo the words of Malcolm X that conclude the film. It does not repudiate

33. This interpretation was first suggested to me by Arnold Davidson, who heard it from David Welberry of the Philosophy Department at Stanford University. It received independent confirmation from audiences to this paper at Harvard, California Institute of the Arts, Williams College, University of Southern California, UCLA, Pasadena Art Center, the University of Chicago's American Studies Workshop, the Chicago Art History Colloquium, and Sculpture Chicago's conference on "Art in Public Places." I wish to thank the participants in these discussions for their many provocative questions and suggestions.

the alternative of nonviolence articulated by Martin Luther King in the film's other epigraph (this is, after all, a film, a symbolic and not a "real" act of violence); it resituates both violence and nonviolence as strategies within a struggle that is simply an ineradicable fact of American public life. The film may be suffused in violence, but unlike the "Black Rambo" films that find such ready acceptance with the American public, it takes the trouble to differentiate this violence with ethically and aesthetically precise images. The film exerts a violence on its viewers, badgering us to "fight the power" and "do the right thing," but it never underestimates the difficulty of rightly locating the power to be fought or the right strategy for fighting it. A prefabricated propaganda image of political or ethical correctness, a public monument to "legitimate violence" is exactly what the film refuses to be. It is, rather, a monument of resistance, of "intelligent violence," a ready-made assemblage of images that reconfigures a local space—literally, the space of the black ghetto, figuratively, the space of public images of race in the American public sphere. Like the Goddess of Democracy in Tiananmen Square, the film confronts the disfigured public image of legitimate power, holding out the torch of liberty with two hands, one inscribed with *Hate,* the other with *Love.*

We may now be in a position to measure the gap between the tragic events of spring 1989 in China and the impact of a Hollywood film that just happened to be released at the same moment. The gap between the two events, and the images that brought them into focus for mass audiences, may seem too great for measurement. But it is precisely the distance between the monumental and the trivial, between violence in the "other country" and our own, that needs to be assessed if we are to construct a picture, much less a theory, of the circulation of visual culture in our time. The Goddess of Democracy imaged a short-lived utopian and revolutionary monument that seems to grow in stature as it recedes in memory. It brought briefly into focus the possible emergence of a democratic, civil society in a culture and political order that has endured the violence of state repression for centuries. *Do the Right Thing* deploys its utopian, revolutionary rhetoric on a much smaller stage (a street in Brooklyn), and its challenge to established power is much more problematic and equivocal. If the Goddess claimed to symbolize the aspirations of a majority, an all-inclusive public sphere, Spike Lee's film articulates the desperation of a minority, a partial public, calling on the majority to open the doors to the public sphere promised by its official rhetoric. The violence in *Do the Right Thing* may be local, symbolic, even "fictional" in contrast to the Tiananmen Square massacre, but it refers unequivo-

cally to the widespread, unrelenting, and very real violence against African Americans in the United States, both the direct physical violence of police repression instantiated by Radio Raheem's murder and the long-term economic violence perpetrated by the white majority.

Perhaps the most obvious contrast between the Goddess and *Do the Right Thing* is the sense (doubtless inaccurate)[34] that the former is an image of revolutionary "purity," the latter a highly impure image-repertoire of compromises, trade-offs, and sell-outs. The harshest criticism that has been made of Spike Lee is the claim that he is merely another "corporate populist," franchising his own celebrity as a star and director, trading in his progressive principles for advertising contracts with the Nike Corporation.[35] The advantage of this *ad hominem* attack is that it saves a lot of time: one needn't actually look at *Do the Right Thing* (or at Spike Lee's witty, ironic commercials for Nike), because one already knows that he is a capitalist.

On the other hand, if one is willing to grant that corporate capital constitutes the actual, existing conditions for making movies with any chance of public circulation, then one actually has to look at the work and assess its value.[36] *Do the Right Thing* makes abundant sense as

34. The "purity" of the Goddess of Democracy is surely compromised by the mixture of sources and motives that went into its production and effect. As Wu Hung notes, "it was not a copy" of the Statue of Liberty, and yet it "owed its form and concept" to "other existing monuments"—most notably the image of "a healthy young woman," specifically "a female student"—to stand for a new concept of the public sphere ("Tiananmen Square: A Political History of Monuments," p. 110). The students' motives, moreover, ranged from revolutionary idealism to "mere" reform of government corruption and the hope for opportunities in more open exchanges with capitalist economies. Some observers, no doubt, saw the statue as an appeal to the true spirit of Maoism beneath the disfigured portrait.

35. This charge is made by Jerome Christensen in "Spike Lee, Corporate Populist," *Critical Inquiry* 17:3 (Spring 1991): 582–95. A more detailed rejoinder is provided in my "Seeing *Do the Right Thing*," in the same issue, pp. 596–608.

36. One of the more astonishing claims of Christensen's essay is its treatment of Lee's filmmaking as "the most advanced expression of the emergent genre of corporate art" (p. 589), a development in which "films . . . are rapidly being transformed into moving billboards for corporate advertising" (p. 590). This "emergence" and "transformation" will be news to film historians who have traced the links between corporate advertising and filmmaking to the earliest days of the industry. See Miriam Hansen on the commodification of the teddy bear in early cinema in her "Adventures of Goldilocks:

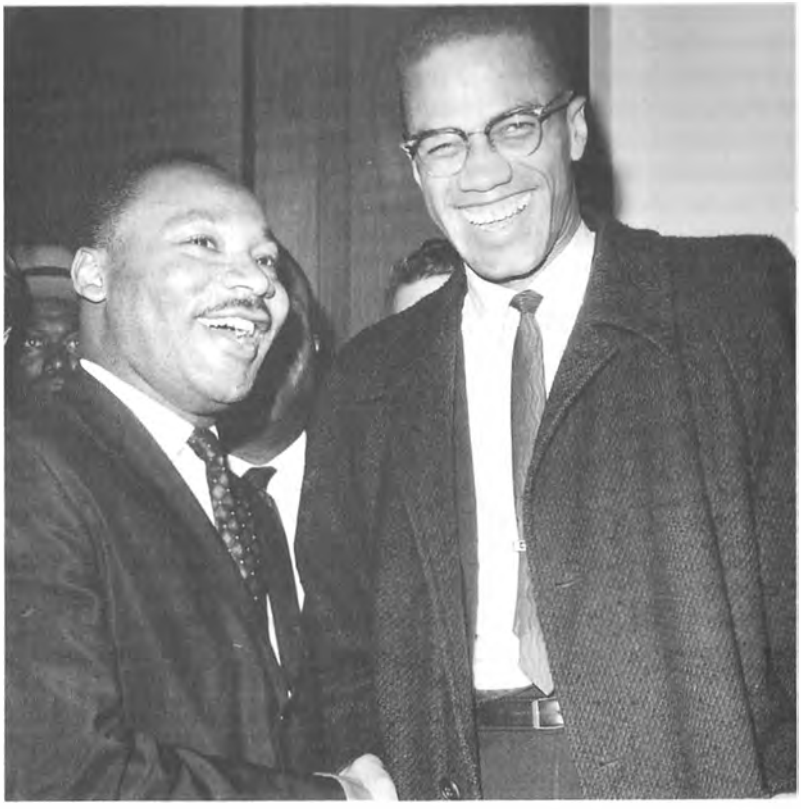
a film *about* corporate populism, a critique of the effects of capital in a multi-ethnic American community. The film shows what it is like to live in a community where no utopian public image or monument is available to symbolize collective aspirations, a community where personal identity is largely constituted by commodity fetishism—from Air Jordan sneakers to Magic Johnson jerseys to designer jewelry and elephantine boom boxes.

The meaning of these fetishes, however, is not confused with the labeling of them as fetishistic. They are treated critically, with irony, but without the generalized contempt and condescension generally afforded to "mere" fetishes. Radio Raheem's blaster is as important to him as Sal's pizzeria (and the Wall of Fame) is to him. Both are commercial objects *and* vehicles for the propagation of public statements about personal identity. Even the image in the film that comes closest to being a sacred, public totem, the photograph of King and Malcolm X shaking hands, has been turned by Smiley into a commodity. The affixing of this image, with all of its connotations of love and hate, violence and nonviolence, to the smoldering remains of the Wall of Fame, is the closest the film comes to the sort of apotheosis achieved by the Goddess of Democracy as she faced the disfigured portrait of Mao.

If *Do the Right Thing* has a moral for those who wish to continue the tradition of public art and public sculpture as a utopian venture, a "daring to dream" of a more humane and comprehensive public sphere, it is probably in the opening lines of the film, uttered by the ubiquitous voice of Love Daddy: "Wake up!" Public art has always dared to dream, projecting fantasies of a monolithic, uniform, pacified public sphere, a realm beyond capitalism and outside history. What seems called for now, and what many contemporary artists wish to provide, is a *critical* public art that is frank about the contradictions and violence encoded in its own situation, one that dares to awaken a public sphere of resistance, struggle, and dialogue. Exactly how to negotiate the border between struggle and dialogue, between the argument of force and the force of argument, is an open question, as open as the two hands of the Goddess of Democracy or the two faces of revolution in Smiley's photograph.

Spectatorship, Consumerism, and Public Life," *Camera Obscura* 22 (January 1990): 51–71, and Jane Gaines, *Contested Culture: The Image, the Voice, and the Law* (Chapel Hill, NC: University of North Carolina, 1991), especially her analysis of commodity "tie-ups"—"the consumer goods and services that have been linked with the release of motion pictures" (p. xiii).

75. AP/Wide World Photo of Martin Luther King, Jr., and Malcolm X.



Violence as a way of achieving racial justice is both impractical and immoral. It is impractical because it is a descending spiral ending in destruction for all. The old law of an eye for an eye leaves everybody blind. It is immoral because it seeks to humiliate the opponent rather than win his understanding; it seeks to annihilate rather than to convert. Violence is immoral because it thrives on hatred rather than love. It destroys community and makes brotherhood impossible. It leaves society in monologue rather than dialogue. Violence ends by defeating itself. It creates bitterness in the survivors and brutality in the destroyers. [Martin Luther King, Jr., "Where Do We Go from Here?" *Stride toward Freedom: The Montgomery Story* (New York: 1958), p. 213]

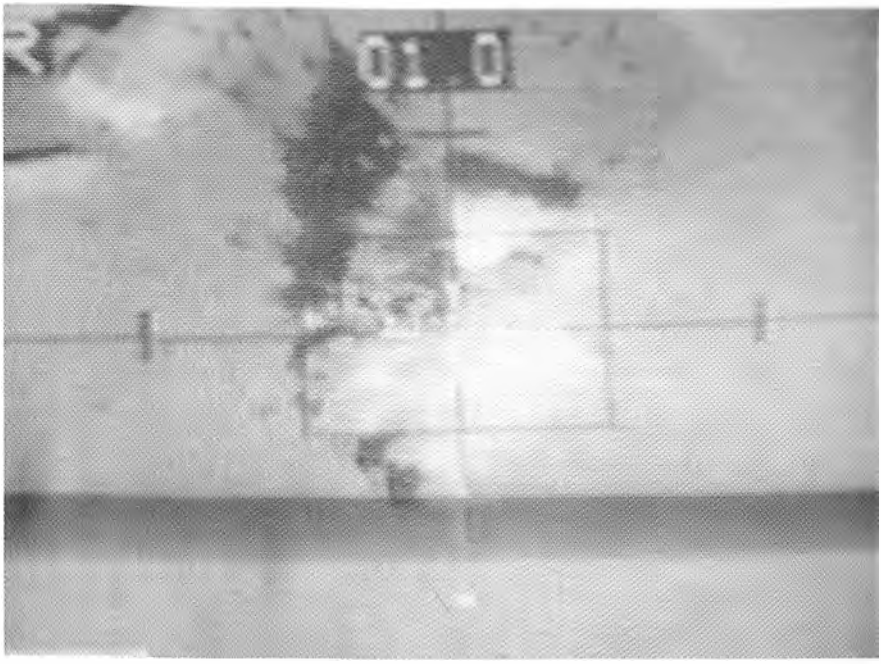
I think there are plenty of good people in America, but there are also plenty of bad people in America and the bad ones are the ones who seem to have all the power and be in these positions to block things that you and I need. Because this is the situation, you and I have to preserve the right to do what is necessary to bring an end to that situation, and it doesn't mean that I advocate violence, but at the same time I am not against using violence in self-defense. I don't even call it violence when it's self-defense, I call it intelligence. [Malcolm X, "Communication and Reality," *Malcolm X: The Man and His Times*, edited by John Henrik Clarke (New York, 1969), p. 313]

Thirteen

FROM CNN TO *JFK*

I am old enough to remember a time when going to the movies meant going to see the newsreels too. Perhaps that is why the juxtaposition of CNN and *JFK* makes so much sense to me. I've never been able to get over the idea that the news is just another kind of movie, and vice versa. That *JFK* is, at least in part, a movie about television news and that CNN's coverage of the 1991 war in the Persian Gulf was filled with echoes of war movies also makes the linkage feel appropriate. But CNN and *JFK* belong together in a historical proximity as well, as the framing media events of a very strange year in American cultural history. 1991 began, for American spectators, with the most heavily publicized war in American history and ended with a cinematic re-enactment of the Kennedy assassination, the most highly publicized event in what *JFK* represents as a secret war for control of America's national destiny. Between CNN's Operation Desert Storm and *JFK*'s "Operation Mongoose" fall the media shadows of what are now called America's "Culture Wars." These are the ongoing battles for the ideological soul of America played out in the convergence of television news and melodrama. Pitched battles of the sexes and races were staged with unprecedented intensity in such media "events" as the Clarence Thomas/Anita Hill hearings and the David Duke campaign. Conspiracy theories detailed the infiltration of American higher education by "politically correct" militants and lamented the takeover of the art world by feminists, homosexuals, and ethnic minorities. In short, for Americans who watch television news, 1991 was a year of war and publicity—not just the publicizing or representing of war, but the waging of war by means of publicity and representation. Oliver Stone's *JFK* is the perfect cinematic coda to such a year.

I don't wish to dwell here on the numerous and obvious differences between movies and television news, though this is a subject of considerable interest, or to rehearse the well-documented ways in which American television was "censored" and manipulated by the



76. "Ground Zero": Television image transmitted from the nose of a "Smart Bomb," photograph by Nadine L. McGann from CNN's *Operation Desert Storm.*

military or "distorted the truth" about the Persian Gulf War.[1] I want instead to compare two melodramatic scenarios that captured the imagination of American spectators in 1991 and to analyze the impact of these representations on public discourse. The Kennedy assassination and Operation Desert Storm are both widely perceived as major turning points in American history, the one signaling the beginning of the Vietnam era, the other marking the transition between the end of the Cold War and the unveiling of George Bush's "New World

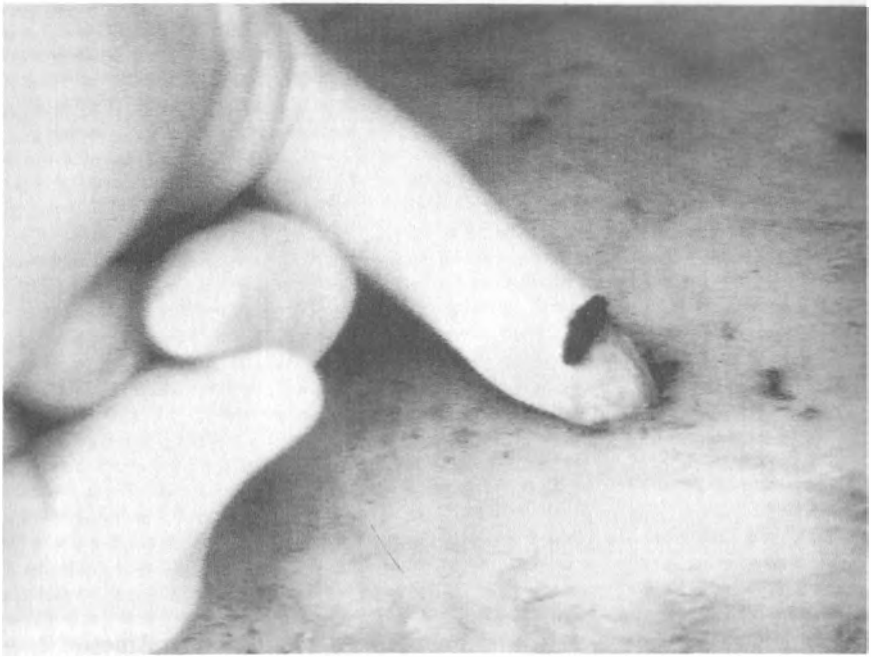
1. For an excellent account of bias in American television coverage of this event, see William Hoynes, "War as Video Game: Media, Activism, and the Gulf War," in *Collateral Damage,* edited by Cynthia Peters (Boston: South End Press, 1992), pp. 305–26. For a critique of the basic opposition between "impartiality" and "bias" as the relevant terms for the analysis of television news, see Ian Connell, "Television News and the Social Contract," *Screen* 20:1. Connell rejects, as I do, the "conspiracy theory" of television news coverage in favor of an ideological analysis that stresses the collaboration between popular mythology, vested interests, and journalistic professionalism.

77. *Dallas, November 24, 1963*, photograph by Bob Jackson of the assassination of Lee Harvey Oswald by Jack Ruby.

Order." Both events were also turning points in the history of American television, with each reaching unprecedented numbers of viewers. CNN's public relations office estimated that one billion people in one hundred and eight nations watched their coverage of the Gulf War.[2] The Kennedy assassination drew transfixed viewers into an instant international community of shock and mourning, while Operation Desert Storm elicited responses of horror, anxiety, and fascination at the spectacle of a war that combined the latest in high-tech electronic communications and weaponry. Appropriately emblematic for the convergence of war, representation, and the public spectacle are the famous image-sequences transmitted from the noses of the smart bombs descending on their targets (figure 76), taking a dazzled American public directly into the heart of mass destruction. The corresponding moment in the television reportage of the Kennedy assassination would be, I suppose, the moment when Jack Ruby shot Lee Harvey Oswald during a live television broadcast (figure 77).

These two images typify many of the differences between CNN's Desert Storm and Stone's *JFK*, purely at the level of representational

2. Major General Perry Smith, *How CNN Fought the War* (New York: Birch Lane Press, 1991), p. xi.



78. *JFK* frame enlargement of surgeon's finger in wound.

style. The Desert Storm image is abstract, like a display in a video game. It represents a war of aerial reconnaissance and electronic mapping, one in which bodies (except for the endangered bodies of heroic media personalities) rarely appear. The Oswald image is bodily, visceral, and intimate; its endangerment was realized in the instantaneous transmission of a close-up pistol shot to the gut. It is a perfect piece of raw material for a film that relentlessly explores the human body and assaults the body of the spectator. Stone's aim is not so much to make us see as to *feel* the physical reality of Kennedy's skull being shattered by rifle fire. We are even forced to watch the President's autopsy, including the spilling of his brains from the skull cavity and the insertion of a surgeon's finger into an open wound (figure 78).

Now one might object that these are simply differences in the objective content of two drastically different historical events, the assassination of a single individual and the waging of a massive military campaign. To this I can only reply that it would have been possi-

79. *Trang Bang, June 1972,* photograph by Nick Ut. Associated Press photo. AP/ Wide World Photos.

ble to represent both these events in very different ways. The Kennedy assassination can be (and has been) represented as a remote, abstract event whose physical reality can never be recaptured, a product of forces that will remain forever invisible and untouchable, even unknowable and insignificant. Mass warfare can be (and has been) represented in immediate and palpable ways on both film and television. Oliver Stone's *Platoon,* for instance, is notorious for the way it conveys the physical reality of combat. In this respect it is in keeping with what might be thought of as the dominant style of Vietnam's television representation. Vietnam was, above all, represented as a war about the human body. To remember Vietnam is to remember the television coverage of body counts and innumerable flag-draped caskets, of massacres, atrocities, and mass burials, and of singular images like the naked Vietnamese girl with her flesh aflame with napalm (figure 79) and the dismembered American soldiers returning home.

The abstract image provided for television by the remote, robotic sensors of a "smart bomb," then, is not just an accidental feature of the way this war was fought, but a crucial element in its overall narrative construction. A major objective in the presentation of the Persian Gulf War to the American public was the erasure of the human body from the picture. General Schwarzkopf announced at the very outset that there would be no "body counts" or "body bags" in this war. Instead, we had the euphemism of "human remains pouches" and the strict refusal to enumerate casualties, especially Iraqi casualties, which to this very day have received no official estimate from the Pentagon. The closest thing to a "crisis" in the public acceptance of Operation Desert Storm occurred when CNN's Peter Arnett broke the rule against showing bodies, transmitting images of Iraqi civilians killed by one of our "smart" bombs. Senator Simpson of Wyoming promptly labeled Arnett an Iraqi "sympathizer," and NBC military analyst Harry Summer suggested that he might be guilty of treason.[3] Military and political leaders were instantly dispatched to the major television talk shows to provide spin control with euphemisms about "collateral damage" and (in the case of the late Senator Tower) outright denial that the bodies even existed. Even the "veiled" representation of our own war dead was prohibited in this war. Media coverage of military funerals or the unloading of flagdraped caskets was strictly censored. This was a war without bodies or tears for the American public, but one filled, at the same time, with a sense of danger, paranoia, and spectacular violence.[4]

The reasons for the censorship on representations of the body are not difficult to grasp. Schwarzkopf rejected the body count on aesthetic grounds, as a tasteless, ghoulish, and demoralizing way of keeping score. But the more fundamental reason was to construct Operation Desert Storm as at once the antithesis and antidote to Vietnam. It is common military wisdom that the Vietnam War was lost because it lost the support of the American public. And the loss of public support is generally traced to the media coverage of the war. Vietnam is sometimes called the first "television war": it brought home to the American public harrowing images of mutilated human bodies in

3. See Smith, *How CNN Fought the War,* p. 32. The criticism even extended to Ted Turner, who was quickly labeled "Baghdad Ted," an appropriate consort for his new girlfriend, "Hanoi Jane."

4. The other moment when CNN received negative responses from its viewers was when it showed the press conferences of captured U.S. pilots, who had their faces covered with bruises from being beaten.

overwhelming numbers. CNN and the American media in general collaborated fully in the project of evoking while erasing all reminders of Vietnam by eliminating, as completely as possible, all traces of the human body. This control of the representation of the war was just as crucial to its "success" as control of the battlefield. Vietnam had shown us that American wars are won or lost on the home front, so the war of publicity was given at least as much attention as the military operation itself.

A more comprehensive account of this public relations war would take note, not only of its negative work—the erasure or "unwriting" of the Vietnam scenario—but also its attempt to provide a positive alternative story line. The main source of images and narrative materials for this positive construction was the American mythology of World War II, preserved in newsreels, photos, and (of course) the movies, from (say) *The Desert Fox* to *Patton*. The media heroes of the Gulf War were the war correspondents in Baghdad with their code of fearless professionalism and their rumpled Banana Republic clothing (*Doonesbury* missed a wonderful opportunity to dispatch Roland Hedley to the scene). Robert Wiener, the executive producer of CNN Baghdad, makes it clear in his memoir that the Gulf War was both a financial bonanza for CNN and a career-making opportunity for ambitious journalists.[5] CNN's video summary of Operation Desert Storm is "dedicated," not to those who fought in the war, but "to the brave men and women of CNN." Hunter Thompson praises Wiener as "a hero and living monument to the balls and best instincts of our trade." Wiener, unsurprisingly, never utters a critical word about the policy that led the United States into this war and never questions the assumption that his position at "ground zero" amounts to transparent access to the truth about the war.[6] The only moment of skepticism about CNN Baghdad's access to "history as it happens" is expressed in a joke by Wiener's cameraman, Mark Biello, who characterizes the CNN team as "first to go, last to know."[7]

Operation Desert Storm was thus a kind of utopian replay of

5. Robert Wiener, *Live from Baghdad: Gathering News at Ground Zero* (New York: Doubleday, 1992).

6. Thompson's words appear in a blurb on the dust jacket of Wiener's book. One can only imagine what a "monument to the balls . . . of our trade" would look like. Wiener is, as we might expect, totally contemptuous of the "scribblers" (print journalists) who flee the action, and his own prose has the feel of a Tom Swift boy's novel, jazzed up with ample profanity.

7. Wiener, *Live from Baghdad,* p. 3.

World War II, fulfilling all the fantasies of victory through overwhelming air superiority, reported by heroic reincarnations of Ed Murrow, pitted against an enemy portrayed as Hitler reincarnate, a Satanic father of lies threatening the mother of all battles. I don't mean to deny, of course, that Saddam Hussein was (and still is) an evil, vicious, and dangerous tyrant. I only want to note that his characterization as Hitler, as the Butcher of Baghdad, as a man whose very name on American lips elicits echoes of sodomy and sadism, has more to do with the strategies of a public relations war than it does with any political or historical analysis of the real aims and consequences of our war in the Middle East. The main function of this caricature was reductive and emotional—to simplify the issues to a straightforward moral choice, to whip up war fever and mass hatred against the enemy, and to make rational debate and opposition to the war seem like an act of treason.

The "Saddam as Hitler" card was, in short, a very effective weapon in the publicity war on the home front, as effective in its use of propaganda images as Bush's playing of the race card with the "Willie Horton" ads of the 1988 presidential campaign. It allowed the vast majority of the American public to celebrate without qualms the spectacle of mass destruction of unwilling Iraqi conscripts in Kuwait and of innocent civilians in Iraq. It allowed that public to see the restoration of an undemocratic oligarchy in Kuwait as a moral act of liberation. Most notably, it has permitted, at least so far, a kind of blissful amnesia about the strange outcome of a World War II scenario in which Hitler remains in power, his Gestapo and elite military units remain intact, and he continues to massacre ethnic minorities within his borders. It turns out that "our Hitler" has a new role to play now in American foreign policy: he is a regrettably necessary force for stability and order in the region or perhaps a convenient scapegoat for any U.S. president who needs a lot of foreign adventurism to bolster his standing in the public opinion polls, a possibility that has not been lost on Bill Clinton.

There is no use, I think, in wasting energy in moral indignation over the cynical exploitation of publicity in war. The Bush administration did nothing unusual in manipulating the war of representation; what was unusual was how well the job was done, how perfectly the media collaborated in the selling of a presidential war to a skeptical public and the suppressing of every sign of protest. There is also no use in complaining about CNN's exploitation of the war as the occasion for a massive journalistic coup that fixed the eyes of the world on the "story" as represented by a single network. CNN did nothing

unusual in making the war into a ratings bonanza. The specific role of CNN in the media war was, as their air war consultant, Major General Perry Smith points out, exactly analogous to the Air Force's role in the Gulf. After the first few days CNN "achieved total air superiority over the networks."[8] It provided saturation bombing of the American public with instant analysis by over sixty military experts and a steady stream of State Department officials. It offered "balanced" debates of the issues between far right hawks like John Tower and moderate hawks like John Mearsheimer and rigorously excluded the views of anti-war representatives. CNN's aim was, as General Smith puts it, "not just to beat the competition but to blow it away" (p. 7), and it succeeded in every way. General Smith's book is called "How CNN *Fought* the War," not how it "reported" the war. Indeed, this may well be the first time a major American television news network has so openly collaborated with the propaganda machine of the U.S. military. Peter Arnett, it seems clear in retrospect, was mainly useful in creating the illusion of controversy and immediacy and as a symbolic figure in the melodrama of American paranoia and endangerment.[9]

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If Operation Desert Storm showed us how the strategic use of media could convert a divided, skeptical, even resistant public into compliant spectators to a high-tech massacre, *JFK* showed that it is still possible for a single movie to administer the equivalent of shock treatment to a numbed, overstimulated public that seems to be reaching a saturation point in its receptiveness to war melodramas, whether public or private, foreign or domestic. This is not to suggest that *JFK* has accomplished anything remotely approaching the propaganda coup achieved by Operation Desert Storm. On the contrary, as propaganda, *JFK* has had very mixed success. The most discernible immediate ef-

8. See General Smith, *How CNN Fought the War,* p. 6.

9. CNN's subsequent release of videotape "highlights" of its war coverage ("Desert Storm," from Turner Home Entertainment), consolidates the work of erasure performed by CNN's live coverage. This condensed version eliminates almost all trace of protest against the war and contains the whole story in a narrative frame constructed around George Bush's career (his historic "gamble" in the Gulf) and Saddam Hussein's *eye,* which is treated, by the miracle of video graphics, as the frame for a ninety-second run-through of Arab "history" and "grievances."

fect has been a curious unanimity among critics and pundits across the political spectrum that this is an extremely bad movie—vulgar, crude, and tasteless as a piece of filmmaking and almost totally fraudulent as a piece of historical representation. Aside from that, *JFK* seems to be a commercial success, drawing large audiences (especially of young people who have no memory of the assassination) who emerge from this film, not simply convinced that Kennedy was killed by the CIA, but engaged in arguments, asking questions, sometimes even talking to their parents about this event. The film has carved out, in short, a tiny and perhaps ephemeral space of public discussion, not only about the assassination, but about the whole meaning of the Kennedy presidency and the implications of the widespread belief that Kennedy was killed by a conspiracy hatched in the U.S. intelligence community.

The narrative work of *JFK* is rather like that of Desert Storm. It manages to unwrite one scenario (the Warren Commission's story of Lee Harvey Oswald "acting alone" for personal, private, and unknowable reasons) and to put in its place an alternate script: that Lee Harvey Oswald was a "patsy" who was set up with an elaborately constructed "communist sympathizer" dossier to divert attention from the real assassins, who were in the employ of the CIA. This complex secret narrative is framed and motivated by a larger story: that the CIA, the U.S. intelligence community, and the whole range of interests summarized by Eisenhower's "military-industrial complex" saw Kennedy as a threat to their increasing dominance over America's Cold War economy. In particular, the fear was that Kennedy was "soft on communism," that he might withdraw from Vietnam and strike a deal with Castro and Khrushchev. Although the actual conspiracy may have been quite small, involving so-called "rogue elements" of the CIA, the conspiracy of consent, of plausible deniability, of silence and acquiescence, is virtually endless. It goes all the way up to Earl Warren and Lyndon Johnson. It continues to the present day in the unbroken wall of secrecy that is permitted to stand around the covert activities of the CIA and in the continued cooperation of major organs of U.S. journalism (*Time-Life, The Washington Post, The New York Times,* the major television networks) in trying to put the assassination behind us.

What exactly is wrong with this narrative? How is it likely to lead a gullible American public astray, and how can it be prevented from having this effect? Four basic kinds of arguments have been made against *JFK*. The first is *ad hominem*. It ignores the story and discredits the storyteller. Oliver Stone is denounced as a power-mad

Hollywood baron, a crude, vulgar filmmaker who will stop at nothing to coerce or pander to his audience. ("I think people who sell sex have more principle"—George Lardner, *Washington Post,* 19 May 1991.)[10] Jim Garrison, the New Orleans District Attorney whose narrative is the basis for *JFK,* is denounced as a mad publicity hound who lost his case in court.[11] Or the entire cottage industry of assassination research is ridiculed for its fascination with musty trivia, its paranoid obsession with unraveling the conspiracy. The second argument might be called macrohistorical. It disputes the large claims about the forces arrayed against Kennedy, denies that he would have withdrawn from Vietnam, and denounces Stone's attempt to revive the Camelot myth, with JFK as the fallen prince of peace. This argument rapidly turns *ad hominem,* getting into nasty stories about Kennedy's mob ties and sex life.[12] Or it takes the high road and declares the assassination a historical irrelevancy: "Whether J.F.K. was killed by a lone assassin or by a conspiracy has as much to do with the subsequent contours of American politics as if he had tripped over one of Caroline's dolls and broken his neck in the White House nursery" (Alexander Cockburn, *The Nation,* January 6/13, 1992, p. 6). The third argument

10. 19 May 1991, "Outlook," D1, 4. Lardner, who covers "national security issues" for the *Washington Post* and enjoys a cozy relationship with U.S. intelligence is quoting Harold Weisberg's opinion on Stone as a prostitute. Lardner's review was the first "pre-emptive strike" in the journalistic attack on *JFK.* His review appeared almost six months before the movie was released and was based on a script of the film "obtained by Harold Weisberg."

11. Garrison's own version of the publicity issue is that he tried, unsuccessfully, to keep his investigation confidential, but found this increasingly difficult in the face of media attention. For Garrison's side of the media assault on his investigation, see *On the Trail of the Assassins* (New York: Warner Books, 1988), chapter 13.

12. See, for instance, Christopher Hitchens in *The Nation,* 3 February 1992, p. 114. Hitchens dismisses the idealization of Kennedy as "dated" and "reactionary." He does, however, concede that the tarnishing of the ideal doesn't eliminate the probability of a conspiracy. It just alters the moral to be drawn from the story: "the fact that Kennedy was a howling little shit doesn't prove that there wasn't a plot to do him in. Indeed, like many a godfather before him, he may have been slain by precisely the same forces that he himself set in motion." The specific question of Kennedy's intentions concerning Vietnam has generally been regarded as closed by professional historians (JFK would have escalated just as Johnson did; the assassination changed nothing). John Newman's *JFK and Vietnam* (New York: Warner Books, 1992), has, however, reopened this whole question.

is microhistorical. It punctures holes in the details, brings up contradictory testimony, offers alternative hypotheses. It tends to trail off into indeterminacy: we'll never know who did it, or why ("Nearly three decades of mostly independent, non-official examination of the event have turned up virtually no answers."—Terrence Rafferty, *The New Yorker*, 13 January 1992, p. 73).[13]

The fourth and final argument is the cinematic/aesthetic. Unlike the others, it at least acknowledges that *JFK* is a film, a work of imagination and not a historical documentary. But it finds the film vulgar and coercively rhetorical. It resents the film's treating its viewers like children, playing a relentless game of "show and tell" to reinforce every point. It regards the scenes of the autopsy and the relentless dwelling on the body as in bad taste. It finds the treatment of the private lives of both Garrison and the conspirators an unbearable tissue of cliches and stereotypes (Garrison is portrayed as a decent, normal family man whose domestic bliss is disturbed by a bunch of perverted, homosexual right-wing plotters). The coerciveness of the film, its appeal to nostalgic, populist myths of American innocence, and its exploitation of homophobia (the unconscious basis of paranoia, according to Freud) have led some reviewers to associate *JFK* with "fascist" aesthetics.[14] Alexander Cockburn's review summarizes this point: "in its truly fascist yearning for the 'father-leader' taken from the children-people by conspiracy, it [*JFK*] accurately catches the crippling nuttiness of what passes amid some sectors of the left . . . as mature analysis and propaganda."[15]

Cockburn is half right on two fronts. First, he should have added that this sort of nuttiness passes for "analysis" on the Right as well as on the Left. Second, while he may be right that *JFK* is "immature" as political or historical analysis, he is certainly in strange territory with his suggestion that it is not "mature . . . propaganda." Propaganda by its very nature sorts very oddly with notions of analytic maturity; its point is persuasion and the production of emotional

13. Cp. Dan Rather, in CBS's umpteenth "white paper" on the assassination, now provoked by *JFK*, moralizing about the heavy burden of uncertainty that heroic journalists must bear, in contrast to the comforts of certainty and conviction enjoyed by conspiracy theorists.

14. Dave Kehr suggests that "as frequently as the film invokes the dark threat of fascism, Stone seems unaware of the totalitarian tendencies in his own style, which remains one of physical intimidation and cheap emotional appeals" (*Chicago Tribune*, Friday, 20 December 1991, Section 7, p. 8).

15. Alexander Cockburn, *The Nation*, 6–13 January 1992, p. 6.

effects, not cool, mature judgment. If maturity means power and effectiveness then *JFK* is certainly mature—though not nearly so polished and effective as the potent fantasies of good versus evil that structured media representations of Operation Desert Storm. Like the managers of the Persian Gulf's media war, Stone realized that a simple, comprehensive moral narrative was required. He saw that emotional shock would best be produced by intimate, bodily re-enactments of the key events, just as the media managers of Desert Storm realized that physical alienation and detached spectacle would best serve the purposes of anesthetizing the American public from the consequences of a high-tech massacre. Stone's idealization of Kennedy and demonization of the conspirators rests on the same assumptions about audience response that produce the figure of "Saddam/Hitler" and the heroic "liberation" of Kuwait. These are mature calculations based in an assessment of the subject matter, the audience, and the economic realities of filmmaking. *JFK* is, like the media management of Operation Desert Storm, a propaganda film that uses representation as a weapon in the war for the hearts and minds of the American public.

Having said that, a number of qualifications need to be registered. The first, and most obvious, is that the propaganda power of *JFK* is pretty much limited to what the film can accomplish with its sounds and images. In contrast to the media managers of Operation Desert Storm, Oliver Stone does not have a host of "spin doctors" and "media assets" to call on;[16] he does not have a political party, or a national security state, or a vast military apparatus at his disposal. When critics on the Right and the Left throw the word "fascist" at *JFK*, they would do well to keep in mind that the fascist filmmakers of Nazi Germany were mainly working for the state, propagating racist myths that would make mass destruction of innocent people acceptable to an anesthetized public.

A second qualification has to do with the actual effects that can be empirically attributed to the film. As we have seen, the main effect of television's Desert Storm coverage was the transformation of a divided, skeptical American public into a consensus of passive acceptance and image consumption. By contrast, the main effect of Oliver

16. Stone does have, of course, the usual publicity apparatus that accompanies the distribution of a major Hollywood film, and Cockburn (*The Nation*, p. 7) speaks darkly of the "conglomerate" backing the film. Much more important to the public impact of the film, however, has been the "free advertising" supplied by the barrage of hostile reviews and the treatment of the film's release as a potentially dangerous event in American public culture.

Stone's movie has been the provocation of controversy and debate. Complaints that the film will mislead the unwary, gullible American public seem quite at odds with its actual reception. When the film was released, the cover of *Newsweek* promised to show us "Why Oliver Stone's New Movie Can't Be Trusted."[17] One year before, *Newsweek* devoted a similar cover story to "How the New High Tech Weapons Will Save Lives." While it is good to be reminded that we should trust in our weapons (and in *Newsweek*), I have yet to meet anyone who claims to "trust" *JFK* as history or to feel comfortable with it as a film. On the contrary, the movie seems to arouse suspicion about its own credibility and to create a kind of massive discomfort, a vague anxiety which may be partly a consequence of the political horror it unveils and the private fantasies it links to that horror. While the film is certainly *designed* by its director to produce an effect of conversion and conviction in an audience that is treated as malleable and child-like, it contains elements that actually work against its own power as propaganda and have the effect of transferring power to its audience.

The empowerment of the spectator begins at the most microscopic level of editing and montage. Many reviewers complain of the "dizzying barrage" of images (Vincent Canby, *New York Times*) that assaults the spectator, but this response is as much a testimony to spectatorial resistance as to a passive "trust" of the images. Spectators nurtured on MTV (the "children" to whom Oliver Stone addresses his movie), moreover, are much less likely to find the "barrage" of images overwhelming. For the alert, visually literate spectator, the dazzling image sequences offer a challenge to discriminate different levels of representation and narrative authority. The rapid transitions from original visual documents (photographs, file footage of television broadcasts, simulations of the Zapruder home movie) to dramatic re-enactments, to courtroom models and diagrams, to subjective memories, to real locations, to the faces of actors, fictional characters, and historical personages caught in reactions create a dense weave of narrative and argument that invites sorting and differentiation, even as it seems to overwhelm the viewer. Even the casting, which from the standpoint of "director's intention" is clearly meant to enhance the film's authority with the presentation of recognizable stars like Jack Lemmon, Ed Asner, Gary Oldham and John Candy, has a curiously equivocal effect. One reviewer argues that the casting "hilariously compromises the film's credibility—simply because the star personas immediately eclipse the real-life figures they are supposed to be

17. 23 December 1991.

playing. One leaves 'JFK' with the confused impression that Johnny La Rue and the Odd Couple have set up Sid Vicious as the fall guy for Lou Grant."[18]

This slippage between intentional design and actual effect, between rhetorical coercion and solicitation of resistance is clear in the scene in which Donald Sutherland delivers a long monologue to Kevin Costner on the Mall in Washington, D.C., the great monuments to the republic arrayed around them. Sutherland as a mysterious "Mr. X" lays out the full scope of the conspiracy for the wide-eyed innocence of Costner's Garrison, his verbal account regularly overlaid with visual materials—historical footage of the Warren Commission, the Joint Chiefs of Staff, and Lyndon Johnson, all intercut with grainy black and white simulated documentary footage that purports to show high-level military officers engaged in conspiracy deep inside the Pentagon. Are we to take these images as illustrations of the speaker's voice, what Donald Sutherland as Mr. X is "remembering" as he speaks? In some cases, yes (certainly, where Sutherland himself appears), but in some cases they clearly go beyond what Mr. X could have observed. Are they then to be taken as what Jim Garrison, the listener, imagines as he hears Mr. X's narrative? Or are they to be taken as the visual narrative provided by the film itself, the views of an omniscient, all-powerful storyteller who is equivalent, for all practical purposes, to Oliver Stone's directorial "point of view"? The answer, I think, is that the images shift through all these levels of authority and that these shifts do as much to undercut as to reinforce the viewer's trust in the film's authority. Since so many of the "original" and "authentic" visual documents and physical evidence associated with the assassination (photos of Oswald, of the Warren Commission, of Dealey Plaza, of the Kennedy autopsy) are of dubious authenticity, or ambiguous in their meaning, or still hidden in secret archives, or already familiar "public" property, the notion of a secure and uniform visual authority, a clear boundary between history and imagination, is exactly what slips away from the film in spite of (perhaps because of) its best efforts to control all the visual information. Oliver Stone is right to call his film a "myth": the term is appropriate to describe both its truth claims and its melodramatic narrative structure.

The film's double effect of seizing and losing its grip on visual authority is nowhere clearer than in its treatment of the trial of Clay Shaw, which ends, after all, with his acquittal and ignominious defeat

18. Dave Kehr, "Born on Nov. 22," *Chicago Tribune*, Friday, 20 December 1991, Section 7.

for Jim Garrison's (and the film's) case for a conspiracy. The visual materials that show Clay Shaw in the company of key conspirators are clearly designed to make us skeptical about the rightness of the verdict, but they do not make us skeptical about the appropriateness of the jury's judgment, given what they are shown. And they do not constitute anything like "proof" that Clay Shaw was a key figure in the assassination. They merely re-awaken the suspicions that led Garrison into a trial he knew would probably fail, not only because of the suspicious death of a key witness, but because the jury would have had to believe a story so appalling that it defies credibility.

JFK actually represents the moment when Garrison's narrative undoes itself, by showing the response of the spectator to whom it matters most within the film. This is the reaction shot that shows Clay Shaw breaking into a relaxed smile as he listens to Garrison reach the highest levels of the conspiracy. Shaw's smile tells us that he knows he's safe. Garrison (and Oliver Stone and the film itself) have gone too far; no one will believe that Lyndon Johnson and Earl Warren were "accomplices after the fact." And if no one will believe in the Big Plot, then the little plotters have a place to hide and a motive for silence as well. When Garrison quotes Hitler on the effectiveness of the Big Lie as the cover-up for the Big Plot, we know that the game is up. Skepticism, suspicion, doubt—all the intellectual resources that might resist the Big Lie and the Big Plot—are crippled by the taint of paranoia, their attention turned from reality and history back onto the mind of the skeptic. The public accusation becomes evidence of a private neurosis. Statements about the world become symptoms of inner states, and the omnivorous interpretative strategies of conspiracy theory are consumed by the equally omnivorous hermeneutics of the psyche. Garrison cannot even pronounce the name of the ultimate meaning of his story out loud: the unspeakable secret of American politics must be whispered to the courtroom in a single word. That word is "fascism."

Fascism is a powerful word for terminating public discussion in an American context. We have seen it applied in its most traditional form in the representations of Desert Storm as a war against Hitler and in a formalistic and decontextualized way in the attacks on *JFK* as fascist filmmaking. Garrison uses it to describe the conspiracy as a military coup d'etat and to suggest further that the wider structure of industrial, military, and media interests amount, when coupled with a passive, apathetic citizenry, to a new cultural formation called American fascism. This may not seem so far-fetched when one reflects that a month before *JFK*'s release a publicly declared member of the

American Nazi Party received fifty-five percent of the white vote for governor of Louisiana, Jim Garrison's home state.

But the film's account of fascism is less concerned with its public face than with the shadow world of privacy and sexuality that lies behind it. At least one-third of *JFK* is concerned with these private matters, which are dismissed as excrescences, even by viewers who generally applaud the public, political narrative. There are real questions as to what Garrison's "family romance" is doing in this film and how it relates to the world of perverse sexuality associated with the conspirators. The most straightforward answer is rhetorical: Oliver Stone's reductive moralistic narrative requires that a straight, normal, decent American family man go up against a seamy underworld of perverse sexuality, an underworld that ranges from the pornographic ambience of Jack Ruby's nightclub to the aristocratic, homosexual sado-masochism of Clay Shaw's New Orleans mansion. By casting Kevin Costner, who has become a film icon of decent, indigenous American values, embodying baseball and sentimental "Native Americanism," as Jim Garrison, Stone erases the problematic image of the real New Orleans district attorney and sets him against antagonists (Joe Pesci as David Ferrie, Tommy Lee Jones as Clay Shaw) who are associated with uncontrollable violence and murder.[19] The sexual subplot may be nothing more than a propaganda device, eliciting traditional American family values, and traditional American homophobia, to suggest that the evil that kills Kennedy is not just a secret, conspiratorial malevolence, but a private, inner corruption that infects the American nuclear family, disrupting the bonds between fathers and children, husbands and wives.

This subplot, with its suggestion that the real moral struggle is between a homosexual cabal and the traditional American family, is certainly embarrassing in its crudity and naivete, and it is one of those blemishes that leads Norman Mailer to call *JFK* "one of the worst great movies ever made."[20] The question I want to raise is whether the "worst" parts of *JFK* are separable from its "greatness," or at least (since I'm not really sure it is a great movie) whether they are separable from what gives it its special power. My sense is that the film's blemishes are all of a piece: the looniness of its left-wing idealization of Kennedy requires an equally loony staging of right-wing

19. I'm thinking specifically here of Joe Pesci's role in Martin Scorsese's *Goodfellas* and Jones's role as Gary Gilmore, the murderer of *Executioner's Song*.

20. Norman Mailer, *Vanity Fair*, February 1992, p. 126.

homophobia; the crudity of its public narrative requires a corresponding crudity in the private sphere. Both stories focus relentlessly on the body, on the one hand as a private and sexualized region and, on the other, as the "body politic" in the form of the president's shattered corpse. The darkest moment in this relentless equation between public and private bodies occurs when Jim Garrison, still in shock from witnessing Robert Kennedy's assassination on television, is finally able to make love to his at last sympathetic wife. The hyperactive perversity of the prostitutes in Jack Ruby's night club and the Sadean fantasies of Clay Shaw's parlor are finally overmatched by the overtones of necrophilia at the heart of the bourgeois marriage bed.

There is one point, in fact, when it seems as if the film is employing the private subplot as an explicit parody of the main plot. This occurs in the scene when Garrison, after a fight with his wife about his neglect of the family, sits down with his children on the front porch swing and explains to them that Daddy has to work late because he is trying to keep America a country where children can grow up in freedom. Like the public "scenes of instruction" (Mr. X's briefing and Garrison's summation speech), this display of didacticism violates every rule of film rhetoric. It tries to persuade by telling rather than showing, and (even more damaging for a successful propaganda film) it *shows* the act of telling as a sentimentalized scene of parental instruction. As propaganda, this is a very dubious strategy. Effective propaganda must seem modern and up-to-date in its rhetoric, and it must conceal, not parade, its own exertion of pedagogical force. The echoes of Norman Rockwell and Frank Capra in this scene do as much to alienate as to engage its audience.

I'm not suggesting that Oliver Stone gets credit for being "ironic" about his own authoritarian film style in this movie: *JFK* seems to me a much more remarkable achievement, a genuinely "naive" work of cinematic art.[21] Oliver Stone's special talents as a director have found,

21. See Friedrich von Schiller's famous distinction between "naive" and "sentimental" forms of art as the difference between primitive and mythical works, on the one hand, and ironic and self-reflexive works, on the other. One could argue that CNN's achievement was the sentimentalizing of the Gulf War in Schiller's sense: that is, CNN continually foregrounded the mediated character of the war, staging it (as General Smith's memoirs suggest) as a war of the networks in which it was achieving "air superiority" and treating it as a television commodity to be marketed with devices borrowed from the dramatic mini-series (titles like "Countdown to Confrontation") and from sports (notably the "telestrators" or "John Madden machines" that allowed

in the Kennedy assassination, the perfect subject at the perfect historical moment. The "authoring" of the effects I'm talking about is as much to the credit of the national audience of Stone's film (including its hostile reviewers) as it is to any directorial agency. My sense is that an American audience knows itself, for better and for worse, in *JFK*: it encounters a projection of its own national fantasy in the film's intersection of private and public bodies.[22] What it does not encounter, and what prevents this from being a fascist film, is a clear embodiment of the evil it seeks to exorcise. There is no "Saddam/Hitler" figure to focus audience hatred and distract it from the erasure of real bodies elsewhere. The hostility evoked by *JFK,* therefore, tends to be displaced (and misplaced) onto its director (Oliver Stone, the power-hungry fascist), onto its principal actor (even the most fervent admirers of *JFK* will want to insist that Kevin Costner is the worst actor in the world), or onto JFK himself (the sexual transgressor, arch-cold-warrior, and crony of mobsters, hiding inside the body of the handsome prince).

But none of these figures, clearly, is adequate to the specter of conspiracy that the film presents, a new form of fascism that cannot be demonized in the person of a determinate villain or idealized in a heroic father-leader. *JFK*'s fascism is faceless and bodiless, a systemic feature of the New World Order outlined by Eisenhower in 1959 and unveiled in Operation Desert Storm in 1991: a new version of the "military-industrial complex" that has now added the persuasive apparatus of the American mass media to its arsenal. A hopeful reading of contemporary history would lead us to think that this new "soft" form of global domination by multinational capital, communications, and security will finally produce a New World Order of peace and international cooperation. In the same week that *JFK* was released,

visual analysis of aerial photography). The fact that the central figures of the television war were not the actual combatants but correspondents in Banana Republic garb (CNN's video is "dedicated to the brave men and women" of the network) is crucial to its modernity and self-reflexivity—and thus to its success as propaganda. *JFK,* by contrast, is, while filled with sentimentality, itself completely unsentimental: it has no irony toward its own authority and regards itself as a pedagogical device for children. It is a work of naivete, we might say, in a sentimental age, a piece of myth-making in a postmodern era. I owe this point to conversations with Jim Chandler.

22. I'm employing the notion of "national fantasy" here in the sense suggested by Benedict Anderson in *Imagined Communities* and its specific application to the United States by Lauren Berlant in *Anatomy of National Fantasy.*

Time magazine anointed Ted Turner as its "Man of the Year," declaring him to be the "Prince of the Global Village" for his revolutionizing of television news and praising CNN as a "beacon of freedom" that will force "despotic governments to do their bloody deeds, if they dare, before a watching world."[23] *Time* did not bother to mention that its parent corporation owns a controlling interest in Turner Communications. It also failed to include the massacre in the Persian Gulf among the "bloody deeds" shown to a "watching world."

Ted Turner, however, is a no more appropriate candidate for paranoid fantasies than Oliver Stone. Despite his megalomania and his heroic ambitions to "take over and save us all" (p. 39), Turner gets even less credit for the specific effects of CNN than Stone does for *JFK*. Like Stone, he is, in his own words, merely "the right man in the right place at the right time." The critical questions, then, are not about persons, but about places, times, and the kind of "rightness" or coherence they disclose. I've suggested that CNN and *JFK* serve as acronymic frames for a certain moment in cultural space-time that, for lack of a better phrase, I'll simply call "America, 1991." The task of cultural criticism in this place and time is far from clear. The great temptations are melodrama and paranoia, and I can't say that I've avoided them in this essay, nor do I have any clear sense of how they are to be avoided. The path of criticism can no longer be imagined, as it once was, to be the high road toward a utopian realm of truth or toward the conservation of a secure cultural legacy. Criticism has no choice but to work through the conditions it is given, to question the rightness of its own place and time. When "history as it happens" in the movies and the news takes the form of melodramas that induce paranoia in their audiences, we have to remember that even melodramas have their uses, and even paranoids have their enemies.

23. *Time,* 6 January 1992, p. 25.

SOME PICTURES OF REPRESENTATION

He is no longer quite sure whether he must draw a picture of indigenous theory, or construct a theory of indigenous reality.

—Claude Lévi-Strauss, *Introduction to the Work of Marcel Mauss* (1950)

A book called "picture theory" should, I suppose, end with a picture of the whole argument, a visible architectonic that would diagram the relation of all the parts and leave the reader with a grid to be filled in with infinite detail. Unfortunately, I have no such picture to offer. This book has instead been compiled in something like the manner of a photograph album. It is a collection of snapshots of specific problems indigenous to representation, addressed on particular occasions, at a definite historical moment that I have called the end of postmodernism, the era of the "pictorial turn." If the book has a unity, it has been in its insistence on staying for the many answers to its few simple questions: What is a picture? What is the relation of pictures and language? Why are these questions of any practical or theoretical interest?

The list of new theoretical concepts and terms in this book is deliberately short and unoriginal. It begins with the "metapicture" and ends with the "imagetext," concepts that have been harvested from the current crop of new work in art history and the study of visual culture. This terminological economy is partly a result of my conviction that we already have an overabundance of metalanguages for representation and that no "neutral" or "scientific" vocabulary (semiotics, linguistics, discourse analysis) can transcend or master the field of representation. Instead, I've offered reflections on the ordinary languages of picture theory, the indigenous vernaculars of verbal and visual representation. My hope is that these terms will make up in

scope and power what they lack in novelty and quantity. The scope of the imagetext, for instance, is not confined to visual representation, but extends to language as well. The pictorial turn is not just about the new significance of visual culture; it has implications for the fate of reading, literature, and literacy. This means that literary studies cannot simply "add on" the study of film, television, and mass culture to its list of courses without changing the whole map of the discipline, and it cannot stabilize its new relation to art history and visual culture with paradigms of structural comparison. The very concept of culture as a relation between texts and readers endures a sea-change when it encounters its "significant other," the image/spectator as a "resident alien" in its own household.

The power of these concepts is, as I have suggested many times in this book, largely negative. They are part of a de-disciplinary effort whose ultimate outcome cannot yet be pictured. If I were compelled to imagine the shape of a new disciplinary formation that might emerge from efforts to theorize pictures and picture theory, it would have a thoroughly dialogical and dialectical structure, not in the Hegelian sense of achieving a stable synthesis, but in Blake's and Adorno's sense of working through contradiction interminably. The power of the metapicture is to make visible the impossibility of separating theory from practice, to give theory a body and visible shape that it often wants to deny, to reveal theory as representation. The power of the imagetext is to reveal the inescapable heterogeneity of representation, to show that the body we give to theory is an assemblage of prostheses and artificial supplements, not a natural or organic form. At a time when culture (and related notions of social "difference" and "identity") is taking on renewed force as the master-concept for the humanities and social sciences, it may be useful to have a conceptual counterweight that emphasizes analysis of the formal, structural heterogeneity of representation, that examines cultural formations as contested, conflicted forms of mediation.

I've employed the term "representation" throughout this book as a general term to cover the work of imagetexts and metapictures. Perhaps the best place to conclude, then, is with some pictures of representation itself and its claim on beholders. I offer three "snapshots," admittedly unfocused and speculative, of three basic questions about representations: (1) what lies outside representation? (2) why are we so anxious about it? (3) what is our responsibility toward it? I realize that the last two questions beg the question of who the "we" is that is anxious, the "our" that has responsibilities, and part of my effort here will be to sketch in that collective identity.

Outside Representation: Some Wrinkles

What is beyond representation, different from it, antithetical or other to it? Attempts to give a positive answers to this question often return to the specular/iconic prototypes of representation and locate the alternative in forms of discourse (Foucault's neo-Kantian divide between the "seeable and the sayable"), textuality (Nelson Goodman's division between the "articulate" and the "replete," the semiotic division between the symbolic and the indexical/iconic), or the pragmatist distinction between "representation" and "action" (cp. Ian Hacking's "representing and intervening"). Equally important, however, is the tradition which offers an uncompromisingly negative answer: that is, *nothing* lies outside representation. This is the tradition of the aesthetic sublime, which posits a realm of absolute negation, of radical otherness and unknowability. The sublime, located in pain, death, transcendence, and the unknowable, is precisely the unrepresentable.

But suppose we thought of representation, not as a homogeneous field or grid of relationships governed by a single principle, but as a multidimensional and heterogeneous terrain, a collage or patchwork quilt assembled over time out of fragments. Suppose further that this quilt was torn, folded, wrinkled, covered with accidental stains, traces of the bodies it has enfolded. This model might help us understand a number of things about representation. It would make materially visible the structure of representation as a trace of temporality and exchange, the fragments as mementos, as "presents" re-presented in the ongoing process of assemblage, of stitching in and tearing out. It might explain why representation seems to "cover" so many diverse things without revealing any image of totality, other than the image of diversity and heterogeneity. It might help us to see why the "wrinkles" and differences in representation, its suturing together of politics, economics, semiotics, and aesthetics, its ragged, improvised transitions between codes and conventions, between media and genres, between sensory channels and imagined experiences are constitutive of its totality. The theory of representation appropriate to such a model would have to be a pragmatic, localized, heterogeneous, and improvisatory totality. That is, it would understand itself as an act of representation (in Ian Hacking's sense of theory as interpretation, description, or explanation), but also (in a violation of Hacking's model) as an intervention, an experiment, an interpretation of the world that amounts to a change in the world. What lies "beyond" representation would thus be found "within" it (as the "black hole" of the image is found within the ekphrastic text) or along its margins.

The Exile of Representation

Why are we so anxious about representation? It serves, on the one hand, as an indispensable and inaugural concept, not just for aesthetics and literary theory, but for semiotics, epistemology, and certain forms of political theory; and yet it also seems like a stumbling block, a crude, almost superstitious or regressive concept that brings up atavistic notions like "imitation," "copy" or "correspondence" theories of truth, and mechanical notions of political empowerment. A great deal of modern philosophy has been devoted to the expulsion of representation from its discourse. The paradigmatic examples of representation—pictures, images, and other "specular/iconic" symbols—are routinely treated as pariahs to be banished, idols to be smashed by a clearheaded iconoclastic critique.

But suppose we thought about representation, not in terms of a particular kind of object (like a statue or a painting) but as a kind of activity, process, or set of relationships? Suppose we de-reified the *thing* that seems to "stand" before us, "standing for" something else, and thought of representation, not as that thing, but as a process in which the thing is a participant, like a pawn on a chessboard or a coin in a system of exchange? This would bring us back to the notion of representation as something roughly commensurate with the totality of cultural activity, including (1) that aspect of political culture which is structured around the transfer, displacement, or alienation of power—from "the people" to "the sovereign," the state, or the representative, from God to father to son in a patriarchal system, from slave to master in an absolutist polity, or (2) culture understood as an economy, a system of exchanges and transfers of value, or (3) culture understood as a utopian imaginary encountering a pragmatic reality, as in the collision of the ideal public sphere (the paradisal scene of total visual and verbal transparency) and the actuality of mass mediation. Representation understood, then, as relationship, as process, as the relay mechanism in exchanges of power, value, and publicity: nothing in this model guarantees the directionality of the structure. On the contrary, it suggests an inherently unstable, reversible, and dialectical structure. The relation of the representation to what it represents, for instance, may transfer power/value to the representation and drain it from the represented, but inherent in such an understanding would be the assumption that the power/value quotient originates with the represented, that it has been (temporarily) alienated, transferred, and may always be taken back. If "presentation" is a giving, a gift, a transfer of wealth and power,

"re-presentation" is always a giving back, a present returned or (in what used to be called "Indian Giving," a parody of potlatch) a *taking* back of the present. In representations, as in dreams, begin responsibilities—the political responsibility entailed in the representative/represented relationship; the mutual obligations of the donor and debtor in exchange, what Derrida calls "economimesis." If taxation without representation is tyranny, representation without taxation is irresponsibility.

Representation and Responsibility

What is the relation between representation and responsibility? The traditional answer is that they are deeply implicated with one another: there is a kind of *correspondence* between them, a mutual resonance, a co-responsiveness. The good or true representation is "responsible" to what it represents and to whom it represents it. "Responsible representation" is a definition for truth, both as an epistemological question (the accuracy and faithfulness of a description or a picture to what it represents) and as an ethical contract (the notion that the representor is "responsible for" the truth of a representation and responsible *to* the audience or recipient of the representation). The terms co-respond at every level: representation is a form, an act of taking responsibility; it is itself a *response,* in the musical sense, an answering echo to a previous presentation or representation. Responsibility, for its part, cannot exist apart from representation. It takes the form of a pledge, warrant, or promise, a representation of how things are or will be. Responsibility is representation, and vice versa.

This means, of course, that a break or gap between responsibility and representation is not only a possibility, but a structural necessity for their mutual functioning, for their co-respondence. Representation can, must be irresponsible; responsibility can, must be unrepresentable. The lie, the fiction, the false oath, the error, the failure of correspondence, the playful, irresponsible representation, the unspoken promise, the invisible constitution—all these are not only possible within the polity of representational responsibilities, they are its necessary supplement. There would be no meaning to the notion of "responsible representation" if this were a tautology, if representations were automatically responsible, if responsibilities could be confirmed, affirmed by representations alone.

Art, culture, and ideology explore and exploit the gap between representation and responsibility. For art, the traditional (that is,

modernist) account of this gap is focused on self-reference: representation is responsible only to itself, to its own laws of form, genre, affect, its own playful necessity. Toward everything else, art must be rigorously irresponsible. Culture and ideology constitute the field within which this irresponsible game called art is played. There the laws of form, genre, and affect co-respond with power/knowledge relations, with historical forms of social stratification, with domination, mystification, propaganda, etc.

What, then, is our responsibility with respect to representation? This is the basic question that I want to raise. But of course all the key words in the question must first be defined. What is representation? What is responsibility? What is their relation? And (above all) who is the "we" that has some responsibility toward representation? The answer that "everyone" is responsible certainly follows from the notion that nothing lies outside representation, and this could be construed in ethical, political, or even the public terms of national identity (the "citizen" as "representative").

But let's assume for the moment that "we" are the people who make professional, public statements about representation, who are socially authorized and legitimated as scholars, critics, theorists of culture. The question, then, has to do with our professional responsibility, as teachers and scholars, toward representation. Our responsibility toward representation is relatively well defined. We know it to be *interpretation:* attentive, careful, loving reading of texts and images; learned, critical responsiveness to their meanings; and eloquent testimony to their power. Making sense of representations and publishing that sense, proclaiming it publicly as truth: that is our profession, a definition of our professional responsibility.

Of course, we do lots of other things: we theorize about the nature of representation. We differentiate it from and within other major cultural categories like narrative, performance, or discourse. We argue about which representations ought to be attended to, which are valuable, central, which marginal, useless, or despicable. We historicize it, analyze it, clarify and reify it. We are relentlessly skeptical, suspicious, and anxious about its power over us. We argue about whether we can get outside it, to reality itself, to some unmediated vision. Some of us—writers, artists—actually make "it," actually produce representations. And even the humblest historical scholar, patiently annotating the sacred text or icon, knows this work to be part of representation, itself an act of representation, and thus subject to all sorts of constraints and responsibilities—a professional ethics, as

it were. We could say that representation is our responsibility; we are its keepers, its professional caretakers. We make professional statements—that is, representations about representations.

It may sound like I'm substituting the word "representation" here for something like "culture" or at least "cultural forms." In a sense I am. The word "culture" is so mystified and loaded with honorific connotations that it instantly paralyzes the faculties. "Representation" is more neutral, and (if it's thought of as a kind of stand-in for "culture") it suggests the constructed, artificial character of forms of life, in contrast to the organic, biological connotations of "culture." Culture-as-representation helps to remind us that culture itself is a fractured concept, a suturing of convention and nature and not a homogeneous terrain. It also provides an analytic model for cultural forms, one which emphasizes semiotic, aesthetic, epistemological, and political relationships embedded in these forms. It leads us to ask not merely what these forms "mean," but what they *do* in a network of social relations: who or what represents what to whom with what, and where and why? Most important, it automatically raises the question of responsibility and raises it for us as a professional issue.

If representation automatically raises the question of responsibility, however, it does not answer it. We may know that we have responsibilities toward representation, even that they involve interpretation. But what sort of interpretation? And does interpretation exhaust our responsibilities? Are there claims on us that go beyond interpretation?

I don't think we can answer these questions abstractly or categorically. We must address them to the concrete conditions of our moment, to the ways in which representation is currently at work in our culture. This, of course, is a massive undertaking. It would involve, first, an assessment of our own epoch in the history of representation, a taking stock of issues such as hyperrepresentations and the hyperrealities produced by them. There seems little doubt that we are now undergoing a revolution in the technologies of representation that makes possible the fabrication of realities on an unprecedented scale. At the same time, we know that this type of revolution has occurred before, that it appeared previously in the inventions of writing and printing and engraving and mechanical reproduction, and that our interpretation of the present is always in danger of replicating previous narratives with their nostalgia for a lost authenticity understood as responsible representation.

Nevertheless, we must think our present in relation to these narra-

tives. The most salient comparisons, to my mind, would be drawn from Europe in the 1930s, when a "New World Order" called fascism began to employ the latest in representational technologies to produce, in Walter Benjamin's words, an "aestheticizing of politics." I don't mean to be melodramatic in invoking the specter of fascism; only to recall that the massive production of political hallucinations, the whipping up of war hysteria, and the formation of socially acceptable forms of race hatred and the mass destruction of populations is central to the work of representation under fascism. Whatever else we might want to say about our cultural moment in the United States, we would have to acknowledge the fact of a many-faceted "culture war" that is being waged on the fronts of ethnic and gender politics and (most directly for us) on the terrain of educational policy. I wrote these words at the end of a year in which our government managed to represent the systematic destruction of the most advanced, literate Arab society in the Middle East, the massacre of untold thousands of people, and the lingering death from disease and malnutrition of the survivors, as a "just war" against fascism. It was a year in which the high point of ethnic politics was the fracturing of the African American community over the Clarence Thomas/Anita Hill confrontation, a strategy that showed an American president how to play the "race card" and the "gender card" in a single trick, while weakening even further the judicial and legislative branches of government. It was a year in which a member of the Ku Klux Klan and American Nazi Party was able to represent his past as "intolerance" and garner forty percent of the vote for the governorship of Louisiana, including fifty-five percent of the white vote, and to begin being taken seriously as a national candidate. For us, the professional interpreters of culture, it was the year of the "political correctness" campaign, which represented the broad mainstream of humanities education in the United States as hopelessly dominated by "tenured radicals" preaching doctrines of nihilism, authoritarianism, and subversive forms of anti-American, anti-Western values.

What is our responsibility toward these representations? To begin with, we must see them as related to one another and to us. Although some of them may be "beyond our control," they are certainly not outside of our field. In the case of the political correctness campaign, it is precisely our field that is in question. The new legitimations of racism and sexism are mediated by representations about which we have considerable expertise. And the representation of war and mass destruction in narratives that simultaneously erase the memory of

Vietnam and replace it with a fantasy replay of World War II should activate our responsibilities as preservers of the historical record and of cultural memory. In short, though we probably cannot change the world, we can continue to describe it critically and interpret it accurately. In a time of global misrepresentation, disinformation, and systematic mendacity, that may be the moral equivalent of intervention.

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